you'd be paranoid too (if everyone was out to get you)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31588229.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Musician Catra (She-Ra), Fan Adora, Implied/Referenced Alcohol Abuse/Alcoholism, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Implied/Referenced Abuse, Homophobia, Suicidal Thoughts, this one is... darker than my usual, basically the darker side of fame that you don't get to see, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Childhood Friends, Kinda anyway, you'll see what i mean by that, Catra Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug

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Part 1 of popstar catra au

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by harrowhark

Summary

Adora wins the opportunity to shadow internationally famous pop star Catra on the last week of her tour. At first, the glamour of fame and stardom seems as perfect as anyone would think.

But Adora soon learns that everything is not as it seems.

Especially Catra.

Notes

yes this is the thing i literally mentioned yesterday in love adora and no i could not wait to post it so here you go

i do have to say i got inspo for the 'contest' way of meeting from a camren fic i remembered from waaaaaay back in the day and i can't for the damn life of me remember the name so if anyone knows which one i'm talking about pls comment it so i can credit that author thx

content warning for this fic overall (i'll put a warning in each chapter) for mental health issues, suicidal ideation, homophobia and abuse so yes this is darker than my usual cheesy romantic shit but there will also be some cheesy romantic shit

See the end of the work for more notes

Monday

Adora can't believe this is real.

Still. Even though she got the phone call a month ago telling her she'd been chosen. Even though she's sat on the plane right now, staring out onto the runway, about to set off to Los Angeles.

In less than 4 hours, she's going to meet Catra. As in, biggest pop star in the world *Catra*.

Her phone buzzes, and she realises she's forgotten to switch it to airplane mode. She looks at the message flashing on the screen and feels herself relax. It's just Glimmer in the group chat.

Glimmer (8:05AM): Have a safe flight, Adora! Try not to freak out on Catra when you meet her, I want her autograph and she's not going to give it to some psycho who might paste it onto a marriage certificate.

Adora laughs at the message. It's oddly comforting. Figuring she still has a few minutes before takeoff, she replies and then switches her phone to airplane mode.

Adora (8:06AM): Omg I'm not going to freak out on her, it's not like it's the first time I've met her anyway

Because it's not. Not technically, anyway. Just the first time, Catra wasn't a multiplatinum recording artist. The first time, Catra was a six-year-old playing in a sandbox. It was long before she adopted her stage name; back then, Adora knew her as Catrina.

"Do you want some help?" Adora asked when she saw the little girl frowning at the broken pile of sand in front of her. "I'm really good at building sandcastles."

The girl hunched over her bucket suspiciously. “You want to help me?”

“Yeah,” Adora smoothed out her summer dress and sat down in the sand next to the girl. She grabbed the bucket and piled the sand in. “What’s your name? I’m Adora.”

The girl looked up, and Adora let out a small whoa *when she saw the girl’s eyes. They were two different colours! She didn’t even know that was possible. “Are your eyes real?”*

The girl frowned. “What kind of a question is that? Obviously they’re real.”

“They’re really pretty,” Adora said as she piled more sand into the bucket. “You never told me your name.”

“Catrina,” the girl muttered, pouting a little bit, “I don’t like it, though.”

“I do!” Adora smiled earnestly, because Catrina was a pretty name. “It’s nice to meet you, Catrina. We should be best friends!”

They never did become best friends. Adora never saw her again after that day. Until she was browsing YouTube one day and she stumbled upon a cover of *Chocolate* by The 1975 uploaded by a user called Catra, before she signed to Horde Records and became an international superstar.

Adora realised it was little Catrina almost instantly. She knew she recognised her from somewhere – it’s been hard to forget those beautiful eyes – and it finally clicked that she was the little girl Adora spent a day building sandcastles with when she was seven.

She’d thought about leaving a YouTube comment back then. Catra’s video only had a couple of thousand views at the time. There was a good chance she could’ve responded. But Adora had chickened out, and a few weeks later, Catra’s channel went viral.

Now, Catra's a pop star, and Adora's just a fan with a funny story of how she met her one time.

When the contest to join her for the last week of her tour was announced, Adora hadn't planned on applying. In fact, she actively shunned the idea, because it's not like she was ever going to win. Bow and Glimmer had pushed her to apply, because according to them, "there's no harm in trying!"

Adora spent days wondering if she should. The contest almost seemed too good to be true. It still does, even though she's on the plane right now. She wouldn't have bothered applying if Catra herself hadn't tweeted about it.

@wildcatra: quick update to let you guys know that there's a contest going on (only open to those who are 18+ and from my hometown, sorry!) to come join me for the last week of tour plus free flights, a bunch of merch, preview of new music and a lot more. details here – etherianews.com/catracontest

Adora saw the tweet, thought *screw it, I won't win anyway*, and applied. A few weeks later she got the phone call telling her that she won.

And now she's here, on a flight to L.A., going to meet Catra. Going to spend a *week* with Catra. It's not just some thirty second meet and greet where the only thing she gets to say is, "I love your music," and jokingly mention their little sandbox day just to see if Catra remembers. She'll have a whole week to talk to Catra, get to know her, maybe befriend her? She's just really looking forward to this. She knows she and Catra will get along. They did when they were kids, after all.

Throughout the flight, Adora listens to Catra's music. Mostly her second album, *Wildcat*. It's her favourite out of the three Catra has released. The first self-titled album was more pop-rock, whereas *Wildcat* is pure pop genius. Her most recent album, *Fright Zone*, is just as perfect, but *Wildcat* has a special place in Adora's heart. It's

the album that took Catra from moderate success to international fame. It's the album that won her a Grammy. The title track and lead single, *Wildcat*, shot to number one on the Billboard Hot 100 and was played everywhere for months. Everyone in Etheria is still talking about how someone from their little town made it big.

Not that it matters. Catra hasn't been home in years. Since news travels so fast in a town like Etheria, Adora would know if she had.

She wonders what it's like, to have a life like Catra's. Everything must be so perfect for her. She travels the world doing what she loves, has millions of adoring fans, and probably has even more millions of dollars. She always looks so happy in the photographs that pop up on Adora's timeline occasionally. Adora doesn't blame her;Catra has everything.

No, that's not it.

Catra is living the dream.

And Adora gets to experience it for a week. She's already been sent a schedule in the form of an email, which she'd screenshotted and sent to her group chat with Bow and Glimmer. She'd promised them regular updates throughout the week, but now, Adora looks the schedule over for herself.

Tonight, Catra has the first of two sold out shows at the Staples Center. They're the final two shows of her North American tour, and the second is on Thursday. All week, she has recording sessions, a photoshoot, interviews, a music video shoot, and promotion for a single that's coming out on Friday;the first single from her highly anticipated fourth album. It's a busy week just looking at it written down, and Adora will experience it all. Until Sunday, the perfect whirlwind that is Catra's life will also be Adora's.

It doesn't really hit her until the plane lands and she fumbles her way through baggage claim. She was told that there'd be someone here for her. For a minute, she wonders if Catra will be there, but quickly

laughs that stupid thought off. Of course Catra can't be there. Adora has seen the videos of the crowds that form when Catra is spotted somewhere. Fans pushing to get to her and big bodyguards pushing them back. It would cause a mob in the middle of the airport, if Catra were here.

Eventually, Adora spots a woman in a posh business suit holding up a card that reads *Adora Gray.* Cautiously, she approaches, and performs an awkward little wave to get the woman's attention. "Hi. Uh, I'm Adora."

The woman looks her up and down a little bit coldly, and Adora is hit with an instant wave of dislike. The woman's smile is just as cold when she asks politely, "can I see some identification?"

Adora fumbles with her suitcase and gets her driver's license out, holding it up to the woman for her to examine. "I hope that's okay."

"Yes," The woman says again, and Adora puts her license away. "Apologies, but sometimes these checks are necessary. We'll have to have your bag searched when we arrive at Catrina's house. Plus, there are some contracts you need to sign. Just to say that you won't leak any of my client's personal information."

Adora takes a wild guess at who this woman is. "You're Catra's manager?"

"And I'm her mother," the woman says again. "Sharon Weaver. Pleasure to meet you. Now, come along. We have a tight schedule."

Weaver whirls around and stalks towards the airport's exit, and Adora hurries after her, hauling her suitcase along. She guesses that it's nice that Catra's mom is so involved in her career. Obviously, it means she cares.

The driver takes her suitcase from her the moment they walk up to a sleek black car. He places it in the trunk and then opens the backseat door for Adora like she's the celebrity here. It's incredibly

jarring, but Adora figures that this kind of thing is just something she'll have to deal with this week.

Weaver taps away on her phone in the front seat of the car, and the driver gets in wordlessly and sets off. It's uncomfortable; the only sound in the car is the soft hum from the radio. The final notes of an Ariana Grande song play out and then the DJ introduces the next song. It must be some cosmic coincidence that it's Catra's latest hit, *Open Skies.* The DJ talks over the intro synth to let listeners know that Catra will be on the show on Saturday afternoon to promote her new single.

Adora assumes they're going straight to Catra's, but she asks anyway, just to make sure she actually got in the right car and isn't about to be kidnapped.

Weaver surprises her with the answer. "Yes, but she won't be there. She has soundcheck for the show tonight plus a meet and greet and Q&A. We'll make you look a little more presentable and then let you give the contract a read over and sign. You'll meet her soon enough, and we want to get some footage of the two of you together for the tour documentary we're producing."

Tour documentary? That hadn't been mentioned in the schedule or announced yet to the public. Adora figures it makes sense, though. It's probably going to be a surprise announcement along with the new single on Friday.

After what feels like a whirlwind of a drive, they arrive at a house. The car rolls to a stop in front of high gates, and Weaver gets out of the car to punch in a security code in the little panel. As she gets back in, the gates slowly open and the car rolls forwards to park in the driveway, just as the big security gates shut again.

The house in front of her is huge. Actually, it's more like a mansion, at least compared to the little cottage Adora calls home. Adora can't even imagine what it'll be like inside, and she doesn't have much time to; Weaver opens her car door and ushers her out.

"Come along, we dont have much time," W eaver says firmly, rushing her towards the big black front door. Keys jngle in her hand as she unlocks it, and Adora turns around to see the driver taking her suitcase out of the car. "W e need to get you looking presentable for the cameras and then we can head to the concert venue. We should get there jst after Catrina has finished her meet and greet. She can give you a house tour later."

Weaver gestures her inside, and Adora is fairly certain that Catra's lounge is bigger than her whole house. It's a massive open space with a flat screen TV mounted on the wall, expensive leather couches, and of course at least $10,000 worth of guitars decorating the space. Adora doesnt get much time to look around, because Weaver ushers her up a flight of stairs, but she swears she sees a home music studio behind a door that's left slightly ajar .

Weaver leads her into a bedroom. It's plain and doesnt look lived-in, so Adora assumes it's a guest room.

"This is where youll be sleeping. Ill have Rogelio bring your bag up." Weaver says, and then snaps her fingers. A nervous looking blond guy comes over holding a makeup brush. "Kyle, make her camera-ready, and make it qick. W e need to be going to the concert venue in forty minutes," she dumps some papers into Adora' s hands, "read this and sign it."

Weaver's phone rings, and she excuses herself without another word. When she's gone, Adora sits down in the chair in front of the dresser and says to Kyle, "she seems...nice?"

Kyle grimaces as he gets to work on Adora's makeup, wiping away the stuff she'd applied before the plane trip. "She' s not. But without her, there's no way Catra would be as famous as she is."

"Supportive mother , then," Adora comments, "that' s nice. So, are you Catra's makeup artist?"

"Lonnie's the main one," Kyle says, "I'm actually just starting out. Lonnie is a childhood friend and she got me this job."

"That's cool," Adora says, and then she asks the question she really wants to know the answer to, "so...what's Catra like?"

Kyle grimaces again, and that definitely wasn't the response Adora expected. He smiles awkwardly. "She's...nice."

Adora frowns. She's never heard anything *other* than positive stories about Catra. Other fans have said that she's always so polite, and in interviews she's nothing less than kind and courteous. "What?"

"She's under a lot of pressure, I think," Kyle says, and he's much more composed when he adds, "but she's nice to fans."

To fans? So...not to her team? Adora wants to ask, but she gives Catra the benefit of the doubt. Kyle did say he's just starting out. Maybe he's only met Catra once, on a bad day.

Adora lets Kyle do the rest of her makeup in relative silence and reads over the contract. It's nothing sinister, thankfully. It's just making sure that she doesn't leak any private information like Catra's address or other personal information, or new content that hasn't been released yet. She signs it and leaves it on the dresser.

Weaver comes back up to drag her away again. It's a shorter drive this time – Catra's L.A. home isn't too far away from the concert venue. After an entire world tour, Adora can imagine that Catra's looking forward to sleeping in her own bed tonight.

"The cameras will be following us when we arrive at the venue," Weaver says. She looks Adora over almost disdainfully. "Please try to maintain some level of professionalism. The last thing we want for the tour documentary is a screaming fan. Trust me, we've got plenty of footage for that."

"Uh...okay," Adora hadn't planned on being a screaming fan. "Yeah, Catra is a celebrity, but it's not like they haven't met before. I won't scream at her."

"You do seem rather composed," Weaver says like it's a compliment. "Honestly, we were expecting one of these fourteen-year-old girls that have a silly crush on her and have deluded themselves into thinking they'll get married."

Oh, so Catra knows that most of her fans are gay, Adora thinks. She's always wondered about that, if celebrities know what their demographic is. She's also always wondered why most of Catra's fans are lesbians when Catra isn't one. Supposedly, anyway. A lot of gay rumours follow Catra around, but most people think they're just that, rumours. She has songs with he/him pronouns and had a very public, two-year long relationship with a fellow musician. A *male* musician.

Of course, there are the fans that think she was forced to sing songs about guys, and that the relationship was simply PR because her label want her to stay closeted. But they're mostly the ones Weaver referenced – the fourteen-year-old girls that have a crush on Catra.

Personally, Adora thinks it's too good to be true. Arguably the biggest female artist in pop music turning out to be a lesbian? Adora can't see it happening. If Catra really liked girls, she would've come out by now. It's obvious how much support she would get, and how groundbreaking it would be for a mainstream pop icon to come out. If it were true, she would be out and proud by now.

At least, that's just what Adora thinks.

She tries not to think about any of it as they pull up to the concert venue. Especially because there's a camera in her face the moment she steps out of the car, and an interviewer asking her questions. Adora registers maybe the third question, *how long have you been a fan?* "Uh, I came across one of her YouTube covers one day. It was *Chocolate* by The 1975."

And then she spent a while wondering where the hell she recognised her from until it finally dawned on her, but she doesnt want to say that to the cameras. It's one thing for *Catra* to know that they met innocently when she was six and Adora was seven, it' s another thing to have the whole world thinking she's been stalking this pop star since she was a child.

"Is Catrina ready to meet her?" W eaver asks someone on her phone – the device seems like it' s attached to her. Adora isnt sure she' s put it down the entire time so far. "Good. W e're just entering the venue now. Prepare her, you know what she can be like."

It's said with disdain, and it's shocking coming from Catra's *mother.* Adora frowns, but Weaver spots her expression and makes a *smile* motion, gesturing towards the camera. Adora nods, and answers a few more questions, like which Catra album is her favourite, which *song* is her favourite, simple stuff like that.

And then they're walking into what looks like a lounge area, and there she is. Catra is sat there on a leather couch, plucking the strings on a very expensive looking acoustic guitar . Weaver mutters something like *I told them to get her ready*, but Adora doesnt have time to question it because W eaver's already getting Catra's attention.

"Catrina, dear ," W eaver says, and Adora doesnt know if she' s imagining the way Catra freezes up for a second. She looks up, hand tense on the neck of the guitar she's holding. "This is Adora. She's the winner of the contest that was held back in Etheria."

Catra is even prettier in person. There's not a single flaw on her golden-brown skin. It's not even Lonnie or Kyle's makeup work, because Adora can still see those cute freckles dotted across her cheeks and the bridge of her perfect nose. And her eyes. God, her eyes. One piercing blue, and one a gentle amber. Adora remembers meeting those same eyes before, when she asked little six-year old Catrina if she wanted any help building a sandcastle. They were just as beautiful to her then.

"Oh," Catra says, and she puts her guitar aside. All of a sudden, it's like she switches on – there's a soft smile on her face, the one Adora has seen a thousand times in pictures. "Hey , Adora. It's nice to meet you. I'm looking forward to getting to know you this week."

Adora is very aware of the camera pointing at her, and also very aware of how surreal this whole thing is. She keeps her voice level – the last thing she wants is to look like some crazy fangirl on a tour movie that will be going out to the whole world. Plus, she doesn't want to freak Catra out.

"It's nice to meet you too," Adora says. She considers hugging her or something, but second guesses because Catra doesn't move from her spot on the couch until Weaver sends her a rather obvious glare just out of the camera's view. "I like your music."

Obviously you like her fucking music, you idiot, Adora thinks to herself, *why else would you be here?*

"Thanks," Catra says, and after exchanging another quick glance with Weaver, she pulls Adora in for a hug. It's so fucking awkward, because Catra clearly doesn't want to be doing it, and Adora is taken off guard that she really only manages to get in a small pat on Catra's back before she pulls away. "Ever been to a concert before?"

"No," Adora says, and wonders if that's rude, "I don't mean like, not yours specifically. I've never been to any concert before."

"You should watch from the floor," Catra says as she sits back down on the couch and pulls the guitar back onto her lap, "They're a lot more fun down there. Backstage sucks."

There's a weird bite behind it. It sounds bitter. But Weaver talks before Adora can dwell on it. "We wouldn't want Adora to get lost. It's best she stays backstage. In fact, why don't you give her a little tour of the venue? It'll be good for the tour movie."

Catra stays still, staring down at her guitar for a moment. But then that winning, celebrity smile is back and she puts the instrument aside again. "Sounds like fun. Come on, Adora."

Someone from her team swoops in and puts the guitar away in its case, and Adora watches in surprise as she trails after Catra, the silent cameraman and Weaver following them.

"So, this is the lounge area. It' s different in every venue, obviously, but this is where I like to relax when I have some downtime between soundchecks and meet and greets and the show," Catra talks to the camera instead of Adora, leading them out of the lounge and down a hallway, "and down here is where the catering is set up, not that it really matters to me because I cant eat a lot before a show"…

"Out here is the stage," Catra says, presenting it like it' s not very interesting at all. The tens of thousands of seats, plus the massive area for all of the standing attendees is even bigger than Adora could imagine. The thought of going out there and *performing* when every single seat is filled makes Adora feel a little sick, but it's just a regular Monday night for Catra. "This is where Ill be performing for all of you beautiful people later. I think the show that's getting recorded is the Thursday show, though, so that's in a couple of days."

"The hermit back there is my sound technician Entrapta, she probably wont want to say hi so well leave her alone," Catra says as they walk past a purple haired woman messing with some complicated looking wires, and when they turn down another hallway to the back entrance, she points out a big woman with short, white hair, "but this is my bodyguard Scorpia, and she definitely will say hi."

"What? Someone say my name?" Scorpia turns around in surprise, sees Catra, and pulls her in for what looks like a bonecrushing hug. "Wildcat! Hey! Who' s your friend?"

"Oh, uh," Adora cuts herself of f when Scorpia lets go of Catra and pulls her in for a *definitely* bonecrushing hug. "I'm Adora."

When Scorpia lets her go, Catra talks directly to her for what feels like the first time on this little venue tour. "I would say you get used to that, but you really don't."

Scorpia smiles sheepishly and lets her go. Adora takes too long to think of a witty response, so all she manages in reply to Catra is a soft smile.

Other than that, Catra looks at Adora maybe twice the entire time she's talking. She mostly looks at the camera and points out different things, until they finally end up back in the lounge area and she finishes up the tour with, "and that's pretty much it, because now I'm going to relax before my show," and collapses back onto the couch.

Weaver calls to the cameraman to cut, and the smile on Catra's face slips for a second. But it's barely a second, because she makes accidental eye contact with Adora again and it comes back in a flash. Adora questions if it ever really left.

"You need your makeup touching up, Catrina," Weaver says immediately, and Adora is taken aback when she reaches out and grabs Catra by the wrist, "We can't have you going on stage looking like that. Come on."

Adora watches in surprise as Weaver pulls Catra up and out of the room. She isn't sure if she should follow; she sort of awkwardly hangs around in the lounge room, but nobody tells her to do anything and the cameraman has gone away. Carefully, Adora sits down on the leather couch and waits.

The opening act – an up-and-coming pop star called Perfuma – sits down on the couch next to her with a tray of food, and that's when Adora realises just how hungry she is. "Where did you get that?"

"Catering," Perfuma says. She has flowers tied into her hair, and Adora wonders if that's for show, or if she just likes it. "I think they've closed up now though, I'm late because I was outside meeting fans. But feel free to take anything you want."

Adora isn't sure if the offer is real, but Perfuma offers out her tray, and Adora takes half of the sandwich. "Thanks."

"You're welcome," Perfuma smiles, and looking at her, Catra's smile seemed a lot less genuine. "Also, not to sound really rude or anything, but who exactly are you? Haven't seen you around all tour and I don't think they'd hire someone new for the last two shows, so if you're a crazy fan who wants to meet Catra, it'd be nice to know."

"Oh, uh, I won that contest?" Adora says it like she's not sure if she did win the contest. "The one held in Etheria, Catra's hometown. To spend a week shadowing her on the last week of tour and first week of promo for her new single."

"Oh, I didn't realise you'd be arriving today," Perfuma says, "Well, it's nice to meet you! I'm Perfuma."

Adora stops herself before she says *I know.* "Adora. Nice to meet you too. Especially because you gave me a sandwich."

"Sharing is caring," Perfuma jokes, "so, how long have you listened to Catra's music?"

"Pretty much since the beginning," Adora says, "I subscribed to her YouTube before she was signed. I liked her covers."

Perfuma looks more than a little surprised. "You're really composed, for someone who's been a fan for so long. Do you meditate?"

"Uh, no," Adora laughs awkwardly. Even though she had been really excited, it wasn't in an *I'm going to scream in Catra's face and then faint* way. "Maybe it's because I'm older? I'm twenty-two, so it's not like I see her as some almighty god. She's just a person that happens to play music for a living."

Or maybe it's because I met her when she was six, Adora thinks to herself.

"I have a feeling she's going to like you," Perfuma says, and Adora wonders what the hell that's supposed to mean. She stands up, pushing the leftover tray of food to Adora. "I've got to go check something with my guitarist. Feel free to finish this off. It was nice meeting you!"

Adora watches her go and settles back onto the couch with a sigh. So far, this is shaping up to be a pretty weird day.

Adora barely sees Catra before the concert.

Aside from their awkward first meeting, Catra is extremely busy. Downtime doesn't sound like it's supposed to be busy, but she is. First, Weaver rushes her off to get her makeup touched up, which actually turns into hair *and* makeup from the way Catra looks like a runway model when she shows up in the lounge an hour later.

She's barely sat down and had a sip of water before the purple haired girl from earlier, Entrapta, comes rushing in and asking her to sound test her guitar again. Adora still doesn't know if she's supposed to go with her, but Catra doesn't look at her when she follows Entrapta out of the room again.

Adora gets up anyway because she remembers the way to the stage, and watches from the sidelines as Catra plays on an *extremely* expensive looking guitar. It's the one she always uses on stage; a shimmering, flaming red colour with birds on the frets. The way she plays it makes it look like the easiest thing in the world, effortlessly gliding through classic rock solos, and Adora wonders why she barely plays guitar on stage anymore when she's so good at it. She actually looks happy, too. Jamming out on her guitar even though there's nobody there to see it. It makes something in Adora's chest flutter.

The loud guitar makes it easy for Weaver to find her, though. Her expensive heels click across the stage, and the *Van Halen* song that Catra is playing cuts off mid-note as she spots her.

I think you have better things to be doing than messing around on a silly guitar, don't you?" Weaver takes the guitar off Catra, and one of the roadies hurries onto the stage to take the instrument. "Come. Fans have been lining up outside the venue all day. There's an upstairs window you can greet them from."

Adora watches as Catra goes with her without argument, her shoulders sagging as she walks.

The next time she sees her, she's in the lounge again doing vocal warmups, ready for the show. Adora leaves her alone to it, because it's not like Catra can talk to her anyway. She watches Perfuma's opening performance instead and decides that Catra had it right before – concerts look much more fun out in the thick of things.

It's still fun to watch Catra perform, though. She's just as talented live as she is in the studio, and she plays in front of 20,000 people like she's still just making covers in her bedroom. Adora admires that.

After the show, they're ushered quickly into a black car with tinted windows. As they drive past the venue, Weaver tells Catra to wind down the window and wave to the fans still there.

Catra stares at her like she's going to defy her, but Weaver stares right back. Eventually, Catra sighs and does as she asks. Adora looks between them confusedly. Why would Catra *not* want to wave to her fans? She's always talking about how much she loves her fans in interviews.

Catra stays quiet for the drive back to her LA home. She leans against the tinted window and stares out at the road, while Weaver stares at her. Almost like she's daring her to make eye contact. Catra doesn't cave to it, and Adora wonders what's going on here. Weaver is just trying to get her to do the things she needs to do, right? Like, waving to fans, or getting her makeup done. Maybe her way of doing it comes across a little harsh, but she's just trying to do what's best for her daughter, isn't she?

Adora dwells on it until they get back to the house. When they walk inside, she turns to ask Catra if she wants to do something, like get to know one another, but Catra is already slinking up the stairs.

Weaver tuts in disapproval. "I apologise for her . She can be so… *ungrateful* sometimes."

"It' s okay." Adora trails of f, staring in the direction Catra had disappeared in. "She' s probably just tired."

"She' s been tired her whole career, in that case," W eaver mutters to herself, and raises her voice as she gestures over to the big kitchen, which literally has its own built-in bar. "Feel free to make yourself anything you'd like for dinner . God knows my insolent daughter won't offer you anything. Im heading home myself now , but Ill be outside with a car at eight in the morning. We have a studio day tomorrow. Have a good night."

Adora watches as Weaver walks down the wide hallway and out of the door. So they don't live together , then. Maybe Catra had bought her mother a house with her music money. Adora knows that's what she'd do, if if her mother was still around, anyway .

She sighs. No point in thinking about that. She *is* hungry, though, so she heads to the kitchen and finds a fully stocked fridge, even though Catra's been travelling around the world for the last year on tour. Adora figures she must have a person to do her grocery shopping for her. Hard to find the time when you're a world-famous musician, probably.

She pokes a fork in the film of a microwaveable pasta meal and picks up her phone. She has a lot of texts from the group chat asking her how her day has been, so she texts Bow and Glimmer back to let them know it's been strange.

Once her pasta is done, Adora goes to sit on the couch. She figures out how to work the TV and puts an old episode of *Friends* on as she eats. Occasionally, she glances towards the stairs in case Catra

comes down, but she doesn't make an appearance. It's nearly midnight, though—the show didn't finish until ten thirty—so maybe Catra just went to bed.

Adora cleans up her dishes and heads upstairs herself. The room she's staying in is at the end of the hall, but she hears a light guitar strumming echoing out of a door that's been left a little bit ajar. An invitation, maybe?

Adora steps closer and pulls the door open. It's obviously Catra's bedroom. There are vinyl records and guitars hanging on the wall, photographs of different cities and concert crowds with little dates at the bottom, because Adora knows she always takes a picture of the crowd as a joke 'group selfie' thing. Catra is sitting on the bed, plucking at the strings on an unplugged electric guitar and humming a quiet melody to herself.

Adora opens her mouth to talk, but she has no idea what to say. Eventually she settles on, "That's pretty. The thing you're playing."

Catra whirls around and fixes her with a glare. Her hand's grip on the guitar neck tightens. "What the fuck do you want?"

Adora is incredibly taken aback by the harsh tone. That was nowhere near the response she was expecting. The girl staring back at her now, glare fixed on her face and angry fire burning in her eyes is nothing like the girl she met this afternoon with the winning celebrity smile.

Neither are at all like sweet little six-year-old Catrina.

"Uh. I just- um, wanted to see if you wanted to get to know each other a little bit," Adora says when she manages to find her voice, "I mean, isn't that the whole point of this contest?"

Catra barks out a laugh, and it's nothing like the one from earlier. It's bitter and sarcastic. "The whole point of this contest is good press. That's it. You think any of this was my idea? You think I want some

fucking stranger in my house all week? I barely have any personal space as it is. Fuck off and leave me alone."

Catra turns back around and returns to plucking the strings on her guitar like Adora had never spoken.

"Okay , what the fuck," Adora says, and Catra ignores her , "you cant just talk to people like that. I get that you think youre some big deal just because youre famous or whatever , but I wont let you treat me like Im beneath you."

Catra laughs that bitter laugh again. "Y ou think that's what this is? God, you really must be an idiot, huh? I dont want you here. That' s it. Now fuck off."

Catra doesnt give Adora any chance to reply or give her a piece of her mind. She puts her guitar aside, stalks over to the bedroom door and slams it in Adora's face.

Adora stands and stares at the closed bedroom door in shock. *What the hell was that?*

Tuesday

Chapter Summary

> Adora goes to Catra's recording session and starts to understand some things.

Chapter Notes

> so i know i said i was going to post this yesterday but instead i got drunk w my friend so whoopsies but it's here now
>
> tw on this chapter for emotional abuse, references to alcoholism, physical abuse and suicidal ideation

When Adora wakes up the next day, she's almost forgotten where she is.

It's an unfamiliar bed, in a plain, unfamiliar room. There's an incredibly expensive looking guitar hung up on the wall, and that's what makes Adora remember. Catra. The contest. Catra *last night*, telling Adora to leave her the fuck alone. Adora wants to be positive, to justify it because Catra was tired or something, but she cant. Imagine if Adora had been a young girl who looked up to Catra. Imagine how that girl would be feeling if her idol yelled at her. There's no excuse for it.

Suddenly, Weaver's comments make a lot more sense.

Still, she forces herself up and out of bed, checking the time on her phone. It's seven, and Adora knows that Weaver is going to be here at eight with a car to take them to the recording studio. She opens up her suitcase and picks out some fresh clothes, then opens the door to the bedroom's en-suite bathroom.

She figures out the shower easily, and once she's ready for the day, Adora braves the house outside of her bedroom. It's completely

silent – not even the light plucking of guitar strings can be heard behind Catra's closed bedroom door. Adora almost considers waking her up, but after the way Catra spoke to her last night, she decides she's not going to be her babysitter. Catra should know what time she needs to be up and ready.

Catra isn't in the kitchen, or in the lounge, so Adora assumes she's still sleeping. Whatever. After rooting around in the cupboards, she finds the ingredients to make pancakes, and pretends that she only made extra by accident.

She plates herself some pancakes up and uses the maple syrup she finds in the cupboard, and leaves a plate on the counter for Catra. Adora glances towards the stairs as she eats, and then towards the clock, because it starts getting closer and closer to eight and Catra still hasn't made an appearance. But then at 7:55, light footsteps sound down the stairs, and a tired looking Catra finally surfaces.

Without the professional makeup and hair styling, she really *does* look tired. There are dark circles under her eyes, an irritable scowl on her face, and her wild mane of hair sticks up in every direction. At least she's not in her pyjamas; she's wearing a pair of ripped black skinny jeans and a *Led Zeppelin* t-shirt. She looks a whole lot like the sixteen-year-old posting YouTube covers, minus the tired scowl.

At least until she looks at Adora and the scowl doesn't waver.

Adora doesn't give her a chance to say anything. "Weaver's going to be here in five minutes."

"I honestly couldn't give less of a fuck," Catra mutters as she stalks her way to the kitchen. Adora watches as she notices the plate of pancakes, pauses, and then asks quietly, "Are these yours?"

"I overestimated how much batter I'd need and made too many, so you can have them if you want," Adora pretends to scroll through something on her phone and makes her tone as disinterested as possible, "or not. I don't care."

She feels Catra's gaze on her but she doesn't look over. She listens as a drawer opens, and there's a distinct sound of someone grabbing cutlery. A few moments later, Catra sits down on the adjacent couch, the plate of pancakes in her lap.

Adora acts like she's very interested in whatever's on her phone, but when Catra finishes and silently takes her plate over to the kitchen again, she says loudly, "You're welcome."

Maybe it's a little petty, but Adora thinks she has a right to be petty when Catra had spoken to her the way she had.

There's the scrape of a key in a lock, and Adora realises that Weaver is here. She turns around at just the right moment to see Catra taking a shot of *something* at the kitchen's built in bar, and Adora's stomach drops.

"Come on, we have to get to the studio," Weaver says, and then takes one look at Catra and tuts in disapproval. "Catrina, darling, you can't go out looking like that. You look like you just rolled out of bed five minutes ago."

That's because she did, Adora thinks to herself.

"It's just the studio," Catra rolls her eyes, "don't have to look like a fucking model to sing a song."

Even the hairs on Adora's neck stand up when she sees the icy cold glare Weaver sends in Catra's direction. "Are you forgetting that we have a guest?"

"Are you forgetting that I don't give a fuck?" Catra snaps. *She must talk to everyone like that*, Adora realises, and wonders how Catra has managed to keep such a good reputation. "I don't care about your stupid fucking contest, and I'm not playing along with it. For the cameras, whatever, fine, but not in my own goddamn house."

Weaver looks so angry that Adora almost pities Catra, but she remembers that Catra brought this on herself. "You have a guest in your home and you will act accordingly. End of discussion. Get outside and get in the car before anyone sees you looking like some homeless grifter."

Catra trudges past her, muttering something under her breath.

"Sometimes I wish you were too. You're more trouble than you're worth." Weaver scoffs in reply to whatever Catra had said, and then looks over at Adora. "Come, Adora. We have a busy day and thanks to *someone*, we're already behind schedule."

Adora figures it's best not to say anything and follows Weaver outside.

Catra is silent for the drive. She puts her earphones in and stares out of the window, avoiding eye contact with everyone in the car. Weaver talks on the phone as Rogelio drives silently, and Adora switches between looking out of the window at the L.A. sights she's probably not going to get to see outside of the car and looking over at a broody Catra.

When Weaver is done with her phone conversation, she turns around to look at Catra. "Kyle will meet us at the studio for some light makeup. The cameras will be there and I expect you to act accordingly."

Catra ignores her, and Weaver rolls her eyes and mutters something about an *insolent child*. Adora doesnt think she should talk to Catra like that, but she also doesnt think Catra should talk to *everyone* the way she does. Maybe it's thanks to Weaver that the whole world doesnt think Catra's an asshole.

The car pulls up outside of the Horde Records building, and they're ushered inside by Weaver, Rogelio, and bodyguard Scorpia, who is as optimistic as she was yesterday.

"Ah, it's a beautiful day, isn't it?" Scorpia says as she escorts them inside, blocking a few fans who must've known Catra would be recording today. "By the way, nice shirt, wildcat."

Catra doesn't even look at the group of girls screaming at her behind Scorpia's big arm. They're a little shrill—even Adora is cringing—but their words are kind. They're telling Catra through screams that they love her and her music, and Catra can't even be bothered to wave at them? Adora feels like she's losing respect for her by the second.

They get inside, and Scorpia stays by the door, but not before pulling Catra into a hug again. Adora wonders how she'll react to it without any cameras around.

"Keep your chin up, wildcat," Scorpia says as she lets Catra go. She looks at her meaningfully and adds, "Only one more album cycle."

One more album cycle? What's that supposed to mean?

Catra surprises Adora completely when she sighs and mutters. "Yeah. I guess. Thanks, Scorpia."

"Always here for my bestie!" Scorpia calls back with a big smile as Weaver marshals them down a corridor. "Whatever you need!"

When they're far enough down the corridor, Weaver scoffs. "That woman is getting too familiar with you. She needs reminding that she's your *staff*, not your friend."

Adora raises her eyebrows, because *what*? Is Weaver telling Catra to go down there and threaten to fire Scorpia?

Again, Catra surprises her. "She *is* my friend."

"Typical," Weaver mutters, "that the only friend you've ever managed to make on your own is a completely useless one. You need to make connections with other artists in this business, Catrina. Yet I never

see you bothering with any of them whenever there's an opportunity to network. You just sit and sulk like the ungrateful brat you are."

"Stop calling me that," Catra says, and Adora feels increasingly uncomfortable being in the middle of this. "And I don't make friends with people for their uses. Maybe *you* do because you're a fucking sociopath."

"You're one to talk," Weaver says with a cold smirk, "and I am your mother and I'll call you whatever I like."

Catra stops dead as they walk. "You're not my mother."

It's said in a low, icy growl that chills Adora to the bone. It doesn't have the same effect on Weaver.

"I'm as close as you'll ever get," Weaver grabs Catra by the wrist and pushes her into a room which Adora realises is the recording studio. "Stop acting out. It's not becoming of you. You're lucky that Adora has already signed the NDA or I'm sure word of how you truly are would already be buzzing around Twitter by now."

So they do remember I'm here, Adora thinks to herself, but neither Catra nor Weaver spare her a glance. They stare at each other, one of them waiting for the other to buckle.

Catra's the one to cave first. She sighs and pulls out one of the chairs by the mixing console, sinking down into it. "Whatever."

Weaver glares at her, but her expression changes into that polite smile that doesn't meet her eyes when she turns to look at Adora. "I apologise for my daughter's behaviour. She knows she's not supposed to act like her nightmarish self around fans."

Even if Adora wanted to reply to that, she doesn't get the chance. The door to the studio bursts open, and the purple haired sound technician Entrapta comes in followed by a tall, pale man with dark hair. "Catra!"

Catra looks up as Entrapta sits down in the chair next to her and starts pushing a lot of buttons on the mixing console. "What?"

"We have a demo!" Entrapta says. "For a thing. Oh, it's going to be so *fun* to produce it, I cant wait to play around with all the different sounds-"

"What Entrapta means to say," the pale man interrupts as he walks by Weaver and Adora to stand in front of Catra, "is that Sea Hawk has a single coming out for his debut album. It needs female vocals, and because you are both on the same label, it makes sense for you to contribute. It will be good exposure for him, and I believe Prime mentioned some… *business opportunities* will follow to promote the single."

Whatever *business opportunities* means, Catra clearly doesnt like the sound of it. She pales, mutters something about needing the bathroom, and darts out of the room before Weaver can stop her. Adora wonders if she's okay.

"Always so dramatic," Weaver comments, and then looks to the pale man, "Hordak, play the demo."

"I must make it clear," Hordak says, "Prime said that she is to record the female vocals. She's the biggest artist on our roster and her fans will listen to anything she's on. We must use that to promote Sea Hawk if we want the label to continue to succeed the way it has been."

"She'll do it," Weaver says easily, "Prime has nothing to worry about."

Hordak plays the demo, and it sounds like the standard pop song of the summer about a boy and a girl falling in love. Adora doesnt doubt that it would be successful, even without Catra on it.

It's when the cameraman arrives to film the recording session that Adora realises that Catra still hasnt come back from the bathroom.

Weaver realises at the same time and tuts in disapproval. "How long does it take to use the bathroom?"

She turns like she's going to go and drag Catra out of there by her hair, and Adora jumps in quickly without thinking about *why* she's doing it. "It's okay, I can go and get her. I need the bathroom anyway."

Weaver pauses with her hand on the door handle. She pulls it open, but only to hold the door open for Adora. "It's the fourth door on the left just around that corner. Be quick, please."

Adora nods and follows the directions that Weaver had given her. She finds the bathroom easily, and when she pulls open the door, she's taken aback by what she sees.

Catra is sat on the floor underneath the bathroom window, a half-full miniature vodka bottle in her hand. There's another empty one on the floor next to her. She looks up at Adora, and Adora doesn't know if she's ever seen anyone so tired and defeated before.

"Uh...are you *drinking*?"

"It's none of your fucking business," Catra snaps, but the miniature vodka bottle in her hand answers Adora's question for her. "Just stay out of my way."

Adora looks down at the tired, broken girl on the floor and sighs. She sits down in front of Catra and looks her right in those beautiful eyes. "Are you okay?"

Catra stares back at her like she can't believe those words just came out of her mouth. She blinks, frowning. "What?"

"You're right, probably a stupid question considering you're drinking vodka on a bathroom floor at nine o'clock in the morning," Adora says, and tries again. "What's wrong?"

"What's *wrong*?" Catra repeats, and she drains the miniature vodka bottle in one. "What's wrong? That's fucking hilarious."

Adora raises her eyebrows. "Are you going to answer my question?"

"What *isn't* wrong?" Catra rolls her eyes. The vodka bottle rolls across the floor and she sinks down against the wall. "Just leave me alone."

"I just don't get it," Adora doesn't move from where she's sat. "You have everything. A huge house in L.A., your dream career, fans that would do anything for you, money. What is there to be upset about?"

"Dream career?" Catra scoffs. "More like a fucking nightmare."

"But... what?" Adora frowns. "You always seem so happy."

"Here's a little fact about the music industry," Catra says bitterly, "you only see what they want you to see. Doesn't matter how far it is from the truth. They write their little narrative and you have to play whatever part they give you. No matter how miserable it makes you."

Adora frowns. What is she talking about? She's saying she's not happy, Adora knows that much. But it's so vague and Catra's half-drunk that she doesn't get *why* she's not happy. "What do you mean?"

Catra stares back at her, before her shoulders drop in a sigh and she pushes herself up off the floor. "Doesn't matter. I've already said too much, anyway."

Adora watches as Catra stops in front of the mirror, looks herself over, and turns and walks out of the bathroom without another word.

She sighs and stands up herself. Something is going on here. At first, she thought that Catra was just an asshole who let fame go to her head, and Weaver was mad at her for it. But now it seems like

there's something bigger happening. Nobody drinks at 9AM because they're happy with their life.

Adora jumps when her phone rings, and she sees the contact name on the screen. It's Glimmer, asking to FaceTime. She answers the call and tries to put on a smile. "Hey , guys."

"Hey!" Glimmer says, and Bow waves in the background. "How' s L.A.? How' s *Catra*? Are you guys best friends yet?"

Bow barely gives her a chance to reply. "Let her know that if she' s best friends with you, she's automatically best friends with us, too!"

"Y eah, I dont think that' s going to happen any time soon," Adora says, leaning against the sinks, "she' s dif ferent in person."

Glimmer frowns. "Do I need to come over there and kick her ass?"

Adora laughs. Of course that's Glimmer's first instinct. "No, no, nothing like that. She just seems really sad."

"What could she possibly be sad about?" Glimmer questions. "She' s a famous musician. Most people *dream* about that."

"Is she nice to you, at least?" Bow asks. "Are you guys getting along?"

Adora laughs awkwardly. "She' s told me to leave her the fuck alone like three times, so not exactly getting along. Honestly , I'm wondering if I should just come home. It' s really uncomfortable here."

"What?" Glimmer asks. "Y ou really hate it that much?"

"It' s just..." Adora wonders if this is part of that contract that she signed, and if she's not supposed to talk about this. But it's just Bow and Glimmer, and they're not going to run to the press. "Catra and her mom slash manager... momager... whatever , they fight all the time. It's so awkward, and neither of them seem like they're happy . Catra especially. I just dont want to be in the middle of it all."

"If you really want to come home, you know well pick you up from the airport," Bow says with a smile, "I dont mind cutting class."

"It' s fine, Ill probably just wait it out," Adora says, "so..how' s Razz? Did you guys check in on her?"

"She' s good," Glimmer says, "and Im good too, because she gave me like three pies to take home. She misses you, though."

"I miss her too," Adora says. It' s hard not to worry about her grandma – she' s the only family that Adora has left, and she had a pretty big health scare last year. Adora has deferred her final year of university to keep an eye on her and build up some money in the meantime working as the assistant soccer coach at her old high school. "Next time you're over there you should call me. She doesnt know how to work technology by herself."

There's a knock on the bathroom door, and Weaver peers around. Adora kicks the miniature vodka bottle on the floor under the stall door. She tells herself it's because she doesnt want to sit through another awkward fight, and not because she's trying to protect some jerkface musician. "Adora, we need you for some footage. Personal calls can be taken later."

"Sure," Adora says, glancing back to Bow and Glimmer on her phone screen. "I've got to go, guys. See you later ."

She hangs up the phone and follows Weaver back into the recording studio. Catra is already in the booth, headphones on, a sheet of paper in her hands that she's reading lyrics off. From the melody, Adora realises it's that Sea Hawk guy's song.

It's not as glamourous as Adora had imagined. Hordak orders Catra to sing certain parts over again until they're perfect, even when they already sounded perfect to Adora's ears. Entrapta spends her time pushing buttons and flipping switches, and even though she's singing, Catra looks completely miserable.

It takes three hours for Hordak to be satisfied with the recording. He allows Catra to take five, but it's not really much of a break, because Weaver brings her over and makes her answer questions for the cameraman and his interviewer friend. She's not very cooperative.

"Are you excited for this new album cycle?"

A scoff. "I'm excited for it to be over."

Weaver sends her that *look*, but Catra ignores it as the interviewer asks another question. "The *Fright Zone* world tour wraps up with your final show on Thursday. Do you have any plans to tour again soon?"

An eye roll. "Yeah. Not like I'll have a choice."

"Your schedule for the last couple of years has been pretty relentless. You got signed when you were seventeen, and four years later, you've released three albums and been on three world tours." The interviewer says. "What keeps you motivated?"

A loud, bitter laugh. "A contract."

"*Catrina*, that's enough," Weaver scolds her, and then turns to the cameraman, "we can't use any of that. Erase it and redo it. And *you,*" Weaver grabs Catra by the collar of her shirt, and Adora steps back in shock, "will answer the questions you are asked in a professional manner."

Weaver lets Catra go, and she stumbles back. Adora doesn't think about it, she grabs her and helps steady her before she goes crashing into the mixing board, and Catra looks so surprised that someone actually helped that it breaks Adora's heart a little bit.

Until Catra shoves her away and sits down on one of the chairs. "I'm done answering questions. Can I just record my fucking music now?"

Entrapta looks a little stunned, but she quickly snaps back to attention and says, "Yes! So, we only have a few more songs left to record for album four, don't we? I think I have the demo for that song you wrote and recorded at home on my computer"…

Entrapta whips out a computer from basically nowhere and starts typing away furiously. Adora watches Catra as she sighs and runs a hand through her hair. She swears that there are tears sparkling in heterochromatic eyes, but she doesn't say anything. Catra would probably just tell her to fuck off again, and then Weaver would get mad.

"Ah, got it," Entrapta says, and then she presses play on the track, "I liked it, by the way!"

The song that plays is *nothing* like Catra's last two albums. It's similar to the first one, but barely. While her self-titled album was pop-rock, this song is pure *rock.* Heavy guitars, fast paced drums, and Catra's vocals are on a level she's never heard them before. And the lyrics…they're not the typical 'I love you' love song or 'I hate you' breakup song that Catra usually releases. There's so much depth and pain behind it. Everything in the words screams *help me.*

Adora catches the lyric '*I don't know if I'll make it to twenty-two*' and if she thought that Catra wouldn't push her off, she'd hug her.

When the song finishes, Hordak and Weaver exchange a glance, and even Adora knows what they're going to say.

"That can't go on the album," Weaver says immediately, "it's not a good fit. The rest of the album is pop, it would sound so out of place. It's much too angry."

"Then I'll change the rest of the album," Catra says, "I don't want to make pop music and I never wanted to make pop music. We can scrap what you made me record so far and I can start-"

"I'm afraid that's not possible," Hordak interrupts her, "we have already used valuable studio time to record the songs we've got. Your new single has already been teased to the public and the Friday release is set in stone. And frankly... rock music won't sell. That's why we did our best to steer you away from that direction after your first album and look what happened when we did. You are *internationally famous*, thanks to your second album, which was a pop album. You won a Grammy for that pop album. That's what your fans expect, and we don't want to let anybody down, do we?"

"Actually, speaking as a fan," Adora feels her stomach drop when she realises those words had come out of *her* mouth, and everyone turns to look at her. She sucks in a breath and keeps going. "I think that song would sell. Yeah, it's not the typical pop song you hear on the radio, but I think that's what makes it good. It's unique, and you can really feel what Catra's feeling through the lyrics and the music."

Everyone stares at her, but Catra especially. Her beautiful heterochromatic eyes bear right into Adora's soul, searching her for something, but whatever connection they make is broken by Weaver.

"You are an established pop artist, Catrina," Weaver says, smiling condescendingly, "that is the music that you will make. We already have some perfectly good songs selected for you, written by our professionals. We thought it was best because the lyrics you bring in always have to be... edited. You're lucky to be in this position with a team that looks out for you like that. You wouldn't want your music to be a failure, would you?"

Catra looks so defeated that it breaks Adora's heart. "Fine. Whatever. I'll just sing whatever."

"Ah, for once, she cooperates," Weaver mocks, and then turns to Entrapta, "you. Play back the last recording. We will get a few insert shots on the camera of Catra and Adora listening to the collab with Sea Hawk. Look *alive,* both of you."

Weaver pushes Adora down into the chair next to Catra. Adora almost wants to say something to Catra again, but she doesn't know what. Entrapta sits down on Catra's other side and beats her to it. "I'm sorry they said no, Catra. I really liked the song."

"It's fine," Catra says, but it doesn't sound fine at all. "I didn't think they'd say yes, anyway."

The camera switches back on, Catra smiles that celebrity smile again, and Adora realises that it's never reached her eyes.

They get back to the house at nine o'clock after a twelve hour recording session. Adora is starving – they barely ate lunch, just a couple of sandwiches that Scorpia picked up from the store down the street – and she's so tired she doesn't think she can be bothered to cook herself dinner. Catra disappears to her bedroom again, and Adora doesn't know what she expected. Only this time, she doesn't really blame her. If Adora is tired, Catra must be too.

It would be easy for Adora to hate her just because she'd spoken to her so horribly. But after today, Adora understands at least a little bit why she's so abrasive. If her mother had been like Weaver, and spoken to her like that, she'd probably be pretty snappy too. And there was everything with that song; obviously, Catra isn't allowed to make the music she wants to make.

Maybe that's what she meant when she scoffed and called her dream career a nightmare.

Adora settles on the couch and is halfway through ordering herself some pizza online when light footsteps tread carefully downstairs. She expects Catra to leave – say she's going out somewhere and tell Adora that she's not invited – but instead she awkwardly hovers by the staircase for a few moments until Adora eventually breaks the silence.

"Yes?" Adora asks expectantly. "Did you want something?"

Catra stares at her. "Did you really like the song? Or were you just saying that to make me like you?"

"You really think I'm so pathetic that I'd lie to make some asshole musician like me?" Adora snorts with laughter. "Get over yourself. I liked the song. I'm still on the fence about you."

Catra blinks at her, like she hadn't expected to be spoken to in that way. Adora imagines that's how she looked last night. "Oh. Well. Thank you for what you said about it to Hordak and Weaver. I... I appreciated it."

Catra sends her one last lingering gaze before traipsing over to the kitchen. She looks so tired and small in her pyjamas, and Adora caves easily. Maybe because a part of her feels bad for Catra, even if all she's done so far is treat Adora like she's nothing.

"I'm ordering pizza, if you want me to get something for you too," Adora offers, and Catra pauses with her hand on the refrigerator door. "Decide quickly though, because I'm starving, and I want to get the order in."

"I'll have a small pepperoni," Catra turns away from the refrigerator, grabs something off a counter by the door and drops a credit card in Adora's lap. "Use that to pay."

"I do have a job, you know," Adora jokes, "normal people also work too."

Catra was halfway sat down when Adora said that, and she immediately stands back up. "Never said you didn't. Call me when it's here, I guess."

She heads in the direction of the stairs, and Adora sighs. "I was only joking. Come and sit down."

Catra hesitates by the stairs, but after a few moments of thought, she turns around and slowly makes her way to the other couch

again. She sits down and looks at Adora reproachfully, and Adora knows she has to be careful here. One wrong word will send Catra running back up those stairs and locking her bedroom door behind her.

She orders the pizza and pays using the card Catra had given her, and then puts her laptop aside. Adora doesnt want to push this, so she puts the TV on and lets some random sitcom play for background noise. The waiting pays off. After five minutes of excruciatingly awkward silence, Catra speaks.

"So, um," Catra starts, "what do you do? You know, for a job. You said you had one."

Adora doubts she's actually interested, but she tells her anyway. "Right now , Im an assistant soccer coach at Etheria High. I still have another year of college left but Im taking leave right now to look after my grandmother. Once I finish college, Id like to be a personal trainer. I like athletics."

"Oh," Catra says quietly , "that's cool."

"Not exactly as glamourous as being a professional musician," Adora shrugs, "but that kind of path isnt for everyone."

Catra sighs and sinks down on the couch. "Not even sure if it's for me."

Adora looks over at her, and she finally puts a finger on what she's been feeling around Catra. Melancholy. It's like it radiates off of her, even when she's faking happiness. And she's always faking it.

It must be hard, to pretend around all of these people like she's happy when she's not. Adora has only experienced true sadness once, when she lost her mother. She never had the energy to get out of bed, let alone go on world tours and record albums and meet thousands of screaming fans every day while pretending like everything is fine when it's not.

"Are you going to quit?" Adora asks, and Catra looks up in surprise. "Scorpia said something like 'only one more album cycle to go'... are you going to quit after that or something?"

"I don't know. I haven't really thought about what I'm going to do after." Catra says quietly. She picks up one of the couch cushions and cuddles it to her chest. "My contract expires after this album. All I know is that I'm not going to re-sign with the label. I'd rather die."

"Because"... Adora pauses, "because they won't let you make the music you want to make?"

"Yeah," Catra says, and then she sighs, "...among other things."

Adora raises her eyebrows, but Catra doesn't elaborate. She stares up at the ceiling, deep in thought, so Adora asks. "What other things?"

"I'm not allowed to talk about it," Catra says, but after a few moments of thought, she mutters, "It's kind of like... like I have to play this character all the time. This famous girl who is *so happy* and *so grateful* and *does anyone want to hear me sing a song?* But underneath all of that, I barely know who I am. And the parts I do know, I'm not allowed to share."

Adora frowns. "Why don't you try, though? Like, if there's something different you want to do, why don't you do it?"

"You've met Weaver, haven't you?" Catra says cynically. "It doesn't matter, anyway. If I do anything to violate my contract, they'll sue me. The best thing I can do is just deal with it until my contract ends. If *I* don't end before that."

The heavy remark is said with so much resignation that Adora sits up in shock. "Don't say that."

Catra frowns like she hadn't realised what she'd said. And then all she does is sigh. "It's whatever. Everyone knows I'm too much of a

coward to actually do anything like that. It just.it' s hard not to think about it when I want everything to stop."

"Okay , I dont want to sound like a condescending asshole," Adora starts, "but have you considered therapy?"

Catra barks out a bitter laugh. "What' s a therapist going to do? Stop my record label and management from suing me if I refuse to do what they say? I dont think so. Besides, I dont have the time. I barely have time to *breathe.*"

"So you're just going to put up with it all?" Adora asks incredulously . "Y ou're not even going to try and fight for what you want?"

"I dont have the energy to fight," Catra says, and she sounds so defeated that Adora wants to bundle her up in her arms and fight her battles for her. She pushes herself up off the couch and murmurs, "I think Im just going to go to bed. Im not that hungry anymore."

Adora watches as Catra trudges up the stairs, and realises she's never met anybody so deeply sad.

She feels a weird determination in her chest as the sound of Catra's bedroom door closing echoes through the big, hollow house. Almost like she wants to help.

Wednesday

Chapter Summary

adora makes a little bit of progress with catra

Chapter Notes

tw for emotional abuse, suicidal ideation and homophobia

If she hadnt already known that something was wrong, Adora would believe the smile on Catra's face right now. She'd believe the soft laughter as the radio interviewer asks questions she must've answered a thousand times, she'd believe the happy-go-lucky tone Catra's words are spoken in.

But Adora notices now. She can see the way the smile doesnt reach her eyes, the way she sinks into herself when the radio show goes to commercials, the way she looks so *over* it all.

Catra had barely spoken to her after last night. This morning, Weaver had shown up with a last minute radio interview booked for her. She dragged a disappointed Catra and a tired Adora out to the car, and now they're here. After this, they have to head straight to a photoshoot and interview for *Rolling Stone* magazine.

Adora wonders if Catra ever gets a break. Even just a single day off to lay around the house in her pyjamas and watch whatever she wants on TV. It doesnt seem like it. From the way Catra answered that question yesterday – *What keeps you motivated? A contract.* – it comes across like she hasnt had a single day off since she was signed at seventeen. If she's not in the studio working on music she doesnt even seem to like, she' s touring and singing the songs she definitely doesnt like. It seems like a constant cycle of album-tour-album-tour.

It's no wonder her eyes look so tired.

"So, Catra, you have a pretty wide variety of fans," the interviewer says as he preps the next song, "we thought it would be a good idea to take to Twitter while you're on the show and get some fan questions. Only a few, because we're running out of time, so we're going to make this a little speed round."

"Okay," Catra says, and if Adora didn't know any better, she'd believe the enthusiastic tone it's said in. "Let's go for it."

"You heard her, folks," the interviewer says, "send your questions to the Elberon FM Twitter account and she'll answer them after this next song!"

The song plays, and Catra does that thing again, where she deflates and lets herself have a few moments of relief. This time, it's short lived, because Weaver leans over her chair and mutters, "One of those idiotic little fans will ask you who your celebrity crush is, no doubt. If that question is asked, you will say Sea Hawk. We must plant the seeds now. Are we understood?"

Adora frowns. Why would Catra need *coaching* on who her celebrity crush is?

She doesn't think she's imagining things when Catra pales, and she's never heard someone sound so desperate when Catra mumbles, "please, no."

"He needs the publicity, Catrina," Weaver's hand squeezes Catra's shoulder tightly, and Catra winces. Adora has to strain to hear what she says. "As do you. Your duet will sell if the public believe the two of you are madly in love. We are already drawing up a contract with his management and public relations team. Possibly a two-year deal. We have to make these things look realistic, after all."

"No," Catra says, louder this time, and a lot more panicked, "no, please, I can't do that again. You can't make me. I won't sign it."

"Don't make a scene, darling," Weaver's nails dig into Catra's shoulder, and Adora wants to jump forwards and push her off. "You have no choice. There is a clause in your record deal on public relations. You already gave your consent."

Catra moves, like she's going to jump up and run away, but Weaver pushes her back down into her seat. There are tears in her eyes, Adora can see, and she feels completely helpless.

"Don't make me do it again," Catra says quietly, "please. If you've ever cared about me even a little bit, you won't make me. I lost so much last time."

"I do care about you, Catrina," Weaver says, and Adora doesn't believe her in the slightest, "I am doing what is best for you to have a successful career. After all, a music career is all you ever wanted from the day you bought that nuisance guitar home. Do not be ungrateful. You asked for this. Now, smile, darling. We're about to go to the questions."

Roughly, Weaver wipes the tears from Catra's eyes and turns to stand next to Adora. Adora doesn't know if she's being stupid when she asks quietly, "what was that about?"

Weaver looks her up and down with that same condescending look. "Public relations. Don't mind Catrina, she's always put up a fuss about things, the ungrateful little brat."

Adora's jaw drops at the disdainful tone. She's never felt hatred before, but what she feels for this woman comes pretty close. How can she talk about her own daughter like that?

"And we're back," the interviewer says as the song fades, "if you're just tuning in, I'm here with pop sensation Catra, and she's about to answer your questions. Ready to go?"

Catra's happy, "yeah," isn't as convincing as before, and Adora knows it's because of whatever that conversation with Weaver was

about. She coughs, clears her throat, and delivers the rest much more convincingly. "Let's go. Ask me anything."

"@magicatra asked if you can reveal anything about the upcoming album, and if you can, which track is your favourite?"

"It's actually not finished yet, we're still finalising the tracklist and there are a couple of things left to record," Catra says, and she sounds so enthusiastic about an album Adora's fairly certain she hates, "but out of everything we've got, I can say that track three is probably my favourite. It's hard to pick, though. It's like picking your favourite kid."

"@chaoticcatra asked which album out of the three you've released and the upcoming one is your favourite?"

"My debut," Catra says in an instant, and it's the one time in this whole interview Adora thinks she's actually been honest. "A hundred percent. I love that album."

Weaver scowls and mutters something about the *wrong answer*, and Adora feels that rage flare again.

"@catrawildcat asked if you'd ever make another YouTube cover, for old times' sake."

"I don't know," Catra answers, and again, Adora thinks she's being honest. "The last time was so long ago; I've probably forgotten my password. Honestly, I'm not opposed to the idea, but I don't know if I'd ever find the time to sit down and record and edit. Especially not with another album coming out."

"But," the interviewer says, "it's still a possibility?"

"Yeah," Catra says, "just not right now when I'm so busy. But I'm definitely not ruling it out. Maybe one day, if I ever get a break."

It's said in a joking manner, but it's painful when Adora knows the truth. Because Catra doesn't get a break. Like she'd said last night. *"I barely have time to breathe."*

"Oh, here's a juicy one," the interviewer laughs at his phone screen and then looks back at Catra, "@catrastoenail – great username by the way – wants to know who your biggest celebrity crush is. It'll let all your guy fans know who they've got to match up to."

It's almost unnoticeable, the way Catra tenses. Her nails scrape against the arm of her chair, and her gaze immediately flicks up to Weaver, who stares right back at her like she's telling her exactly what to do. Adora expects Catra to do it.

But she doesn't. In a small act of defiance, Catra looks back at the interviewer and says calmly, "I don't actually have one."

"Oh, come on," the interviewer laughs that off, "everyone has one."

Catra refuses to make eye contact with a furious Weaver. "Not me. But I do have a pretty huge crush on this one PRS private stock guitar I've been staring at online the last few weeks, so we'll say that."

"One woman married the Eiffel Tower," the interviewer jokes, "so I'm sure you can find a way to be with your true love too."

Catra's laugh is fake, but believable. "I'm definitely going to look into that once this interview is over."

"Well, you'll be happy, because we've just run out of time," the interviewer says, "do you want to introduce the next song before you go? I think you'll know it."

Catra takes a piece of paper that's offered out to her and half-smiles down at it. It's that composed, celebrity smile, the one that doesn't meet her eyes. "Hey, this is Catra, and you're about to listen to *Wildcat* by- uh, me, on Elberon FM."

The opening notes to Catra's biggest hit play out, and after thanking the radio host for having her on, Catra stands up and walks past Adora muttering, "I hate this fucking song."

Weaver grabs her by the wrist and pulls her out of the radio station, only letting go for public appearances when they get outside to the big crowd of fans gathered there. Scorpia's security team are there making a pathway through the group of mostly girls, and Scorpia herself shields Catra until she gets to the car that's ready and waiting to take them to the photoshoot and magazine interview.

Weaver makes her move when the car sets off. Probably because she knows there's nowhere for Catra to go.

"You are an ungrateful, disrespectful little brat," Weaver points a finger at Catra, who flinches, and Adora's heart drops at the implications behind that. "I told you what you were supposed to say should that question come up, and you directly disobeyed me."

"It's not like any of it fucking matters," Catra sinks against the window and stares out like she's genuinely considering opening the door and jumping out. "You're going to force me into it anyway, but I'm not playing along until I literally have no choice."

"Just for your disobedience, I will make sure we get that contract drawn up as soon as possible," Weaver snaps, "I am sick of your unappreciative insolence. Everything I do is for you and your career, and this is how you act? You've always been a bad apple, Catrina."

Catra ignores her, and Weaver mutters a quiet *typical* before turning back around to face the front of the car. Adora glances over at Catra, and those tears are shining in her eyes again. She doesn't know what she's supposed to do, or how she can help. It's not exactly a common situation, to find out that one of your favourite artists is being abused by her manager, who also happens to be her mother.

Adora glances down. Catra's hand is rested by her leg, her fingernails digging tensely into the car seat. Slowly, she reaches over

and puts her hand on top of Catra's as a way of letting her know she's here.

Catra jumps in surprise, but she doesn't pull her hand away and immediately file a restraining order like Adora thought she might. She keeps her hand still and closes her eyes, leaning back against her seat's headrest and letting out a small sigh.

When they reach the building the photoshoot is being taken in, Weaver whisks Catra away to get her hair and makeup done. Or as she says, "we must make you somewhat presentable."

Adora decides to have a walk around, and at least make herself a little busy. It's kind of boring to sit and watch Catra get her hair and makeup done, so she explores the building. That's just as boring, and when she's on her way back to the shoot area, she bumps into Scorpia.

"Hey!" Scorpia smiles and Adora doesn't think she's ever met anyone as friendly before. "Adora, right? How are you? How's the week going? Are you having fun hangin' with my bestie? Oh, I shouldn't say *hangin'*, that doesn't suit me. Anyway... having a good time?"

"Not... not really," Adora admits quietly. She knows that there are a lot of people who would kill to be here right now, but Adora honestly wishes she was at home eating pie with grandma Razz. "Is it always like this here?"

Scorpia frowns. "Like what?"

"I mean... Weaver is *horrible*, and Catra seems miserable, and..." Adora sighs, "I don't know. Has it always been like this?"

"Weaver has always been pretty harsh, yeah," Scorpia admits, and Adora isn't surprised. "Even before all of the fame stuff. Catra's told me some things that... they make my heart break for her. But Catra wasn't always the way she is now. I think she just... she's burnt out.

They overwork her because she's the big money-maker of the label. They dont want to lose any of that hype so they go from album to touring then back to an album and anyone with eyes can see she's exhausted. They kept it pretty quiet, but she was actually hospitalised for exhaustion a little while back. But they got her fixed up and threw her right back into the schedule that put her there in the first place."

Adora glances across the big room to the makeup chairs. Catra is still there. It's hard not to feel sorry for her. "It must be hard. Are you guys- are you really friends?"

"Of course. Like I said, my wildcat is my bestie," Scorpia smiles, and there's nothing about her that seems false. Adora is pretty sure Scorpia is the one honest person here. "I know she can come of f a little frosty at first, but she's got a good heart underneath it all. It's just hard for her , because she's never been the best at making friends, and the fame stuff happened really fast when she was really young. She had a lot of people in the beginning who tried to use her for what they could that it made her shut down the way she has."

"And," Adora pauses, "she told you all of that?"

"She told me some of it," Scorpia says, "the rest wasnt hard to piece together myself. You've just got to try with her . Catra has to *see* that people care, she cant just hear it."

"Okay ," Adora says, "thanks, Scorpia."

"No problem," Scorpia smiles as Adora heads back over to the photoshoot area, "I'm always happy to help!"

Adora walks over to the makeup chairs with a goal in mind. She's going to get through to Catra. Obviously, the hard front she puts up is just because she' s stuck in the situation she's in.

She stops in her tracks when Catra snaps, "Jesus fucking *Christ*, Lonnie, just get it done. Any old idiot can do makeup. God, I'd

fucking fire you right now if I could."

"You want to go over there when you're not ready? Fine, that's on you." Lonnie steps back and gestures over to the photoshoot set, where Weaver is stood. "Go. I'm sure Weaver will be happy with you."

"I don't give a fuck what Weaver thinks," Catra stands up with a scowl on her face, "and it's you she'll be mad at, so it's really not my fucking problem, is it?"

Catra starts stalking away, but she pauses in her tracks when Lonnie laughs sardonically and says, "You're just like her, you know."

Adora watches as Catra's hands clench into fists and she stomps away to the photoshoot set. When she turns around, Lonnie is looking right at her, gentle green eyes a lot softer than the disdain she was looking at Catra with.

"You're Adora, right?" Lonnie asks, and Adora nods. "Weaver wants me to get you ready too. There's a part of the interview where they're going to ask the she-beast about the contest, and Weaver thinks it's a good idea to have pictures to accompany that section."

She pats the chair, and Adora sits down. "She-beast?"

Lonnie laughs and nods towards Catra as she gets started on Adora's makeup. "You don't agree?"

"I mean." Adora chews on the inside of her cheek, because she probably would've agreed on Monday night. But now she isn't so sure. "It's obvious that she's going through a lot."

"She has nothing to worry about. She's rich, famous, and she'll never have to work a day in her life," Lonnie says, "the only things she has to worry about is looking pretty, singing a song and waving to the fans, which she can't even be bothered to do half of the time

because she's so up her own ass. Weaver's a bitch, but she's right when she calls Catra ungrateful and lazy."

Adora stays quiet and thoughtful as Lonnie does her makeup and then moves onto her hair. She casts a couple of glances over to the photoshoot set and sees Weaver muttering something to Catra, jabbing a pointed finger into her sternum as she talks. Catra has that same tired, empty look on her face, and she shoves Weaver's hand away with a scowl.

"I think she needs help," Adora says quietly as Lonnie trims a few dead ends off her hair, "Catra, I mean. Weaver...she seems a little more than just *stern*, if you know what I mean. Scorpia said that Catra told her Weaver was, uh, *harsh*, before all of the fame stuff."

"Scorpia- I don't want to say anything bad about her, but she always wants to see the good in people, which means she can be a little blind to the truth," Lonnie says as she brushes through Adora's hair, "Look, I get that you want to help Catra. You're a fan, it's different for you. But Catra has a tendency to...dramatize things. And the truth is, the stuff she complains about just comes hand in hand with being one of the most privileged people on the planet. She's rich. She can get away with just about anything because she has that much power. She's never had to work a real job in her life. She has millions of people telling her just how *amazing* she is every day. And it's all gone to her head."

Lonnie pauses halfway through straightening Adora's hair. "She was never all sweet and innocent, but at least she knew how to smile and laugh and take a joke. She was decent, when all of this began. Now, she's probably one of the most self-involved people I've ever met. She throws a tantrum at the tiniest inconvenience. She doesn't appreciate what she has. And people like you and me? We're nothing to her. She treats us like we're her lackies. You saw the way she spoke to me before. Catra only cares about Catra. Honestly, I don't think that girl will ever be happy."

Adora stares at her own reflection in the mirror. "Why do you still work for her, then?"

"I'm not just *Catra's* stylist," Lonnie says with a laugh, "lots of different people employ me, because I'm good at what I do. And the only one who doesn't show me even a shred of respect is Catra. I'm under a contract right now, but once it expires, that girl can find a new stylist. I made a mistake signing it in the first place. Usually, I know how to tell the good ones from the bad."

Adora frowns. "The good ones?"

"Celebrities," Lonnie says, "the industry changes people. Some for the better, and some for the worse. Catra is in the latter half. God knows how she manages to keep such a good reputation for herself. Maybe because the people she treats the way she does are all under NDAs. Weaver's good with those."

Adora thinks back to the contract she had to sign on Monday. Weaver really *is* good with NDAs. "So, you think she's just a bad person?"

"I think the industry has turned her into one," Lonnie says, holding up the mirror to show Adora the back of her hair. "And I honestly don't think she'll change. She'll just keep getting richer, more famous, and treating anyone who isn't as rich and famous like garbage."

Adora frowns, and Lonnie squeezes her shoulder. "You're all done. And I'm sorry. I know it's hard to find out that someone you admire is kind of an asshole. Don't meet your heroes, I guess."

With one last pat on the shoulder, Lonnie dismisses her, and Adora wanders over to the photoshoot area with a lot on her mind. When she thinks about the things Scorpia had said, she wonders if the big bodyguard actually is just blind to the truth. But then when Weaver complained that Scorpia was too familiar yesterday, Catra had said they were friends.

"Adora," W eaver says, a tight hand on her shoulder guiding her towards the photoshoot set, "good, you're ready . We're just waiting on my spoiled brat of a daughter, who has disappeared off somewhere."

"If we're waiting, do you mind if I just head to the bathroom?" Adora asks, because she has a feeling that's where Catra is. Possibly with more of those little vodka bottles. "I won't be long."

Weaver sighs, but she lets go of Adora's shoulder with a nod. "Fine. Make it quick."

Adora nods, and she heads out of the set area and follows the sign to the women's bathroom. She pulls open the door, and her guess was half-correct. Catra is in there, but she's not drinking. The window is open, and Catra is leaning over it, staring down at the ground below. The sight makes Adora feel uneasy; they're four storeys up, and if Catra fell.she' s not sure it would be entirely accidental. Not from the way she's looking at the ground almost longingly.

She clears her throat to get Catra's attention, but she doesn't move. "What?"

"I." Adora falters, because she doesn't think saying *please don't fling yourself out of that window* is a good idea. "How can I help you?"

"Nobody can help me," Catra whispers. She still hasn't turned around. "Why do you even want to? What do you want from me?"

"I just want to help," Adora says, "because nobody should be as.as sad as you are. I don't want anything from you. I just want to help."

Slowly, Catra moves. Her hands grab the open window and pull it down, closing it. Adora breathes in quiet relief. Catra turns around, those beautiful heterochromatic eyes staring right into Adora's soul until finally, she moves past her and towards the bathroom door.

She pauses with her hand on the door handle. "Nobody can help me."

Adora watches, helpless, as Catra slowly walks out of the bathroom and the celebrity takes over.

"So, are things any better today?"

Adora leans against her pillows with a sigh. Bow waits on her phone screen patiently, and as much as Adora loves her, she's glad that Glimmer isn't with him. Bow is the patient one, good with advice and reassurance, whereas Glimmer is much more chaotic and dives into everything headfirst.

Right now, Adora needs patience. "Not really . If anything, it's all just getting worse."

Bow winces. "That bad, huh?"

"I'm not supposed to talk about any of this," Adora says, "they made me sign an NDA when I got here, and the longer I'm here, the more I understand why. So you can't tell anyone I told you this."

"You know I won't," Bow says, "talk to me."

"She's miserable, Bow," Adora says, "like, I've never met anyone so sad. I think the record label and everyone working for them- it's obvious that they're overworking her and making her do things she doesn't want to do. They won't even let her make the music she wants to make, and she hates basically all of the songs she's released already. And her mom, or her manager, or whatever she is.she's horrible to Catra. I want to help her but I don't know how ."

"And this is all just.stuff if you've seen?" Bow asks, and Adora nods. "Well, has Catra said anything?"

"I asked her what was wrong and she replied with *what isn't wrong*. She said all of this cryptic stuff about the label creating narratives and she feels like she has to lie and pretend all of the time, and that if she doesn't, the label will sue her," Adora says, "W eaver was talking about this contract earlier that Catra clearly doesn't want to sign, but they're going to force her into it anyway . I think it's abuse. And if this is the stuff that they'll do in front of me, imagine what it' s like behind the scenes?"

"That' s..that' s horrible," Bow says, but when he looks back at the camera, Adora knows she's not going to like what he says nex, "but I don't think there' s anything you can do about it, Adora. Especially if they've made you sign a contract. They're a big powerful company , and you're just a normal college student."

"I can't just sit here and do nothing while they treat her the way they do," Adora answers, because she'd feel so wrong just standing by and letting it happen like everyone else. She sits up and grabs the copy of the contract she had to sign, flicking through it. "This expires in a year. I could- I could tell people then"…

"D you have any proof?" Bow asks. "They'll make you look like some crazed fan, and if she's under all of these contracts too, they'll get her to deny it. I know you always want to help and do what's right, but sometimes it's a losing battle and this isn't a fight you can win. I think if you really want to help her, you just need to treat her with kindness. It doesn't sound like anybody ever has."

"I think" Adora pauses and sighs, "I honestly don't think anyone has ever treated her like a real person before. They either use her for money or put her on a pedestal. Her only friend is her bodyguard, and even that seems kind of one-sided. Maybe you're right. Maybe I just need to be kind to her . And maybe she can help me help her"…

Bow looks a little concerned. "Adora. Y ou can't take on a big, powerful record label."

"You said I needed proof," Adora says, trying to think of a way she could get it. Maybe recording on her phone? After the contract they made her sign is no longer valid, she could share the evidence. There's no way the general public would just sit by and let it happen. "Maybe I could get proof. People leak things all the time. Sometimes it's okay to break laws if it's for the greater good."

"Adora," Bow repeats sternly, "you can't fight every single battle."

"I just want to help," Adora defends herself, "is that so bad?"

"It's not bad that you want to help, but sometimes you just can't," Bow says, "I don't want you to get into something that's going to be bad for you."

"I'm not going to!" Adora says, because she's not planning on storming the CEO of Horde Records and demanding that they treat Catra better. "It's just... if I *can* help, even just a little bit, I want to."

"I get that," Bow says, "just promise me that you'll be careful."

"I'll be careful," Adora answers, holding up the contract, "I'm going to look through this and try to find some kind of loophole or... or something. I'll see you later."

Adora hangs up the phone before Bow can protest and begins scouring the contract for something she could use. She finds a pen in the bedside table drawer and underlines passages and paragraphs, and even sends a few pictures to Glimmer's mother Angella, who is the best (and only) lawyer that Adora knows. It's a headache inducing task, and Adora can't find anything herself. She waits for Angella's response and gets up with the intention of getting a glass of water, when there's a light knock on the bedroom door.

Adora looks at the door in surprise. Slowly, she walks over and pulls it open, and she has to blink a couple of times to make sure that the Catra standing in front of her isn't a hallucination.

Catra meets her gaze for a moment, and then looks away. "Hey , Adora."

"Hey ," Adora says, and she tries not to sound too surprised, "what' s up?"

"I.I was wondering if you wanted to watch a movie," Catra says, "or something."

It's hard not to sound surprised, especially when she blurts out a loud, "what?"

"Or.or not," Catra mutters, and she' s already turning around and heading back to her room.

Adora snaps out of her shock and quickly grabs Catra' s wrist, before realising what a bad idea that might be. Catra flinches, and Adora lets go, quickly apologising. "Sorry , sorry, I shouldnt have grabbed you. I just- yeah, Id.Id like to watch a movie."

"Okay ," Catra says quietly , and when she turns towards the stairs, Adora follows. It's really awkward, and really silent, and Adora is trying to think of *something* to say to break the ice. Surprisingly, it's Catra that gets there first. "They made you sign an NDA, didnt they? I want to tell you the truth but I cant unless..."

Weird icebreaker, but Adora goes with it. "Y eah. They did."

"They make everyone do it. Everybody that works around me. The only one that got out of it is Entrapta and that's just because Hordak is basically in love with her and told her she didnt have to sign as long as she keeps quiet." Catra says, slowly sitting down on the couch. She doesnt make a move to turn on the TV, and stares down at her own lap anxiously . "They dont want the truth to get out."

Adora frowns. "The truth about how they treat you?"

"Not just that," Catra glances up at Adora again. She lets out a long breath, bites down on her bottom lip like she's trying to stop the words coming out, and then lets them anyway. "I'm a lesbian."

"Oh," Adora says. There are a lot of thoughts spinning around her mind at *that* revelation, but all she manages to say in reply is, "me too."

"Oh," Catra answers, and she shifts uncomfortably in her seat. Adora glances over at the other couch, but figures *fuck it*, and sits down next to Catra instead. "They won't let me come out."

"And..." Adora tries to think of the reason why on her own, but she can't, "why not?"

"It's not *marketable*," Catra mutters, scowling down at her lap, "my contract- it's bad. It's really bad. There's a clause in it somewhere that says they're allowed to manipulate and present my image however they want, including my *relationships.* They forced me into a PR relationship, made me change all of the pronouns in my songs, and my actual girlfriend got so fucking sick of hiding in the closet and watching me with that *guy* that she dumped me and left me in this mess on my own."

Adora wants to hug her, but she doesn't know how Catra would feel about that. She pauses, and settles for reaching out to put a gentle hand on Catra's shoulder. "I'm sorry ."

"They're going to make me do it again. They're going to force me into another PR relationship with Sea Hawk, and you- you heard what Weaver said. *Two fucking years.*" Catra laughs bitterly . "It's never going to end. They're never going to let me do what I want. I'm just- I'm just their fucking puppet. Their singing, dancing puppet. And any time I try to fight back, or speak up, people just roll their eyes. *You have everything. You wanted a music career. You asked for this."*

"I never wanted any of this," Catra says, and it breaks Adora's heart to see her so broken, "I never wanted to be *famous*. I never wanted to be a pop star. I just wanted to make the music I want to make, and if people liked it, then that would be enough. That's why it meant a lot, what you said about that song yesterday. They never would've listened to you, but you tried anyway. I feel like- I don't know why, but I feel like I can trust you."

Adora doesn't know what to say. She's never been the kind of person to do well with words, and when her friends are upset, she's more of a *let's go to the gym and punch one out* kind of friend.

Maybe it's stupid, but she settles with a joke. "Maybe you could sense that I'm gay too."

"I mean, it's not hard to tell," Catra murmurs, and Adora laughs. When she looks up Catra doesn't look *as* distressed as she did before. "Thank you for listening."

"It's okay," Adora says, and she scoots a little closer and puts an arm around Catra, "If it means anything, I've got my friend's mom looking through the NDA they made me sign. I do want to help you."

"I just- I just have to wait it out," Catra says, and she sounds so hopeless that it breaks Adora's heart all over again. "My contract expires after this album cycle. Two years-ish. I just have to stick it out until then."

"There's really no way to get out of it sooner?" Adora asks, and Catra shakes her head solemnly. "How do you know?"

"I looked through it with a lawyer. She said it was one of the worst contracts she'd ever seen," Catra murmurs, "The only way they're going to let me go is through a mutual termination agreement, and there's no way they're going to let that happen when I make them so much money. I hate Weaver for that. She took the one thing I loved and turned it into her little money maker."

"Why did you let her be your manager , then?" Adora asks, and follows it up with another hunch, "If you never really got along, then…"

Catra pauses. She looks like she's not sure if she should answer. "When she found out about my YouTube and the money I was making from it, she got…weirdly nice. She finally seemed like she was proud of me, and after so many years of feeling like I'd never be good enough for her, it felt good. But she wasn't proud – she just saw how much money she could make off me, and I was a stupid kid who fell for her manipulation. When I got signed, I was still a minor, and because she was my legal guardian – and acting all nice still – she suggested that she manage me because she'd have my *best interests* at heart. That was a fucking lie."

Adora pulls Catra closer. She has a feeling that she needs a hug, whether she wants one or not. "Why don't you just fire her , then?"

"Contract," Catra says quietly , and proves Adora's theory correct when she rests her head on Adora's shoulder. "I was seventeen when I signed the recording contract with Horde Records. It was just for the first album, because obviously they don't know if you're going to do well. I resigned with them when the album was a success, for a three-album deal, so albums two, three and four. That was the one that fucked me over. It took away my creative control, my right to be *myself*, and pretty much makes me their little slave, because any time they introduce something new, they can wave the original contract in front of my face and tell me I already consented. That's what they're going to use to force me into another PR relationship. They'll probably find some little loophole to make me resign with them after this contract expires. They'll keep me trapped there until I'm no longer useful to them."

"I can't believe your own *mother* would do that to you," Adora murmurs, mostly to herself, "surely , there must be some part of her that wants to help you."

"She's *not* my mother," Catra snaps, and when Adora recoils slightly, she takes in a breath and mumbles, "sorry. I just- I hate it, how she calls herself that. She's not my mother. She adopted me when I was eight. She's not my mother, and she never will be. She couldn't care less what happens to me. She works for the label now, and once she got that job, she stopped giving a fuck what happens. She's going to let them drain me for every penny they can and then kick me out onto the curb."

"I hate her," Adora says quietly, and Catra looks up in surprise, "I've never said that about anyone, but literally the moment I met her, something felt off."

"That's the perfume she wears," Catra mutters, "it's called *Unspeakable Evil.*"

Despite the heavy conversation, Adora laughs. It's the first time she's heard Catra make a real joke, and even Catra smiles weakly. It makes Adora even more determined to help her.

"I want to help you," Adora says, "maybe I can't take on a big corporation in your name, but...but I can be your friend. If you want."

"That depends," Catra says, and Adora raises her eyebrows. Has she not shown Catra that she's genuine yet? But Catra smiles that weak smile again. "Can we talk about hot girls?"

Adora laughs. "I'm all about the hot girls. Hell yeah."

"And you have to promise you'll never say *hell yeah* again," Catra says dryly, and Adora laughs, but nods. "Okay. Then I'd like to be your friend."

"Yeah?" Adora asks, and Catra nods again. She smiles and gently squeezes Catra around the shoulders one last time before letting go. "Okay. Who actually *is* your celebrity crush, by the way? Because that interviewer wasn't wrong. Everyone has one, and you said you wanted to talk about hot girls..."

Catra snorts with a dry laughter, but she actually answers the question. "Hayley Williams from Paramore. Specifically *blonde* Hayley Williams."

Adora wiggles her eyebrows. "You like blondes, then?"

Catra meets her gaze and rolls her eyes. "Shut up. You dont count."

"Ouch," Adora fake pouts and puts a hand over her heart, "that hurts. And to think, I was going to say *you* were my celebrity crush. I guess I've got to rethink."

Adora doesnt know if she's imagining it, but she swears that Catra is blushing. "*That* hurts."

"Now you know how I feel," Adora says. She glances towards the TV, which is still switched off. "So... movie?"

"Sure," Catra says, and when she gets up, Adora finds herself missing the way it felt to sit next to her. "You pick. Ill make the popcorn. Oh, and speaking of making things, can you make those pancakes again tomorrow? They were amazing."

Adora cant stop herself from smiling. "Sure."

Catra looks up from the cupboard she's searching in and flashes the first *real* smile Adora has ever seen on her face. It makes her determined; she's going to be there for Catra, as long as she wants her to be.

Thursday

Chapter Summary

adora keeps noticing catra looking at her

Chapter Notes

tw on this chapter for physical abuse, alcohol abuse, homophobia, suicide mention/suicidal ideation

i meant to post this yesterday so oops apologies but a day later is better than not at all

Adora doesn't know if she's imagining things, but she keeps noticing Catra looking at her.

It starts small enough. They're making pancakes in the morning, and when Adora turns around to ask Catra to pass her the butter, Catra is already looking at her. There's this little smile on her face, but it slides away when Adora turns around, and she snaps to attention, whirling around to grab the butter from the fridge.

Adora doesn't think anything of it. She assumes that Catra just zoned out.

But then when they're in the car and heading to the venue for Catra's final show of her tour, Adora looks around at her and finds that Catra's looking at her again. This time, she doesn't look away—it's like she's in her own little world, this soft smile toying at the corners of her mouth.

Adora waves. "Catra?"

It's like the sound of her name snaps her back to reality. Catra blinks, the smile drops from her face, and she coughs and turns to stare out

of the window. Adora swears there's a light blush on her freckled cheeks when she asks, "What?"

"Uh," Adora feels awkward asking why she's staring, so instead she just says, "are you excited for your show?"

If anything, Catra's mood sours. "No."

Weaver scoffs from the front seat of the car. "You always have to sulk, don't you? Imagine what Adora must think of you. Unappreciative little brat."

Catra sinks down in her seat and mutters to herself, any flash of a good mood ruined completely by Weaver and her negative comments. Adora reaches over, squeezes her hand lightly, and speaks up. She promised Catra she'd be a friend to her, and that starts now.

"Actually," Adora says, "I think Catra would be more excited for her shows if she was actually allowed to make the music she wants to make."

Weaver looks like she's been slapped, and Catra turns around in surprise, staring at her with something that looks a whole lot like admiration.

Weaver takes a few moments to compose herself, and then she smiles that condescending smile again. "Adora, dear, I don't think you understand. We have *professional* songwriters for a reason. We want Catrina's music to succeed."

"You just want to make money off of her," Adora says, "she's a person, not something for you to sell."

Weaver stares right at her with the same angry expression she directs at Catra. And then it *is* directed at Catra. "I see what you have done here. You've manipulated her into thinking you're the victim," Weaver looks back to Adora with a scowl, "she has been

given everything she ever wanted, and she is still not happy. She's a toxic waste of space and you would do good to remember that."

Weaver turns around in her seat again, and Adora reaches over to Catra. Catra is already looking at her, still with that same admiration on her face, but also a little bit of awe. Like she cant believe Adora really did that.

To be honest, Adora can barely believe it either.

Catra doesnt say anything until they get to the venue and W eaver stomps away to organise the cameras for the show later – it' s this show that's apparently being turned into a live album and the full concert will be included on the tour documentary.

"I cant believe you said that stuf f," Catra says quietly while a member of her team tries to usher her off to makeup. "Thank you."

"I said I was going to be your friend," Adora shrugs easily , "friends look out for each other."

Catra stares at her again. That same stare from breakfast, and in the car, only this time she actually seems aware of it. A tiny smile tugs at the corner of her mouth, and Adora finds that she's smiling back. It's hard not to smile, when Catra actually looks somewhat *happy.*

Carefully, Catra steps forwards and pulls her in for a hug. It's nothing like the last time they hugged in this room, when Weaver had pretty much forced her into a friendly fan' hug. First of all, this time Catra is actually hugging her because she wants to. But the real difference is the way she curls into Adora, burying her face into Adora's shoulder and wrapping her arms around her waist.

Adora hugs her back tightly, realising that Catra needs this. She doesnt know if she' s crossing a line or not, but she really doesnt mind if she is. Her hand tracks through Catra's wild, messy hair as she hugs her, running her fingers through the length of it. The motion

seems to soothe Catra, because she relaxes even more and sighs into Adora's shoulder.

"Catra, you need to come to makeup," the guy in the doorway clearly trying to move things along says, "Lonnie is waiting."

"Do me a favour," Adora says as Catra slowly pulls away. "Say sorry to Lonnie for yesterday."

Catra lets out a noise that sounds almost like a scoff she's trying to stifle. "Why should I?"

"Because it's not her fault that Weaver and the record label are assholes," Adora answers, "I know you're hurting, and I get why. I couldn't imagine having to pretend like you do. But you shouldn't take it out on other people."

Maybe it's wrong of her, to assume the worst reaction possible. Adora expects Catra to snap at her or tell her to stay out of her business. But instead, Catra sighs and runs a hand through her hair. "I know. I know that."

Adora wants to ask why she does it if she knows it's wrong, but they don't have time and she doesn't think that Catra would tell her anyway. "Just think about it, okay?"

"Yeah," Catra says, already turning away, "I have to go."

Adora watches as she traipses out of the room with a sigh. It upsets her to see Catra so melancholic all the time. Last night when they watched a movie – it wasn't much, but at least she seemed okay.

Adora had enjoyed herself, too. Once Catra let her frosty walls down, she was actually quite good company. She was funny, and she talks like she's so much smarter than people give her credit for. Even though everyone knows she went to Etheria's private high school on an academic scholarship, at least until she left to pursue music.

She's beautiful, too. It leaves Adora wondering about what-ifs. Like if Catra had never started posting her covers on YouTube, or if she went to Etheria High instead of the private school. Because of their birthdays, Catra would've been in the grade below Adora, but there still might've been chance for them to meet.

Adora could've brought up how they'd met before, at the park. They would've laughed over it, and maybe she could've gotten over her obvious nerves at meeting such a pretty girl to ask Catra out sometime, and Catra would be allowed to say yes.

But there's no way that could happen now. Even if Catra wasn't constantly overworked and forced to stay in the closet – Adora still can't believe that the conspiracy theorist fans were right all along – it's not like a mega-famous pop star would want her. Adora is just a girl from a small town, and she's destined to stay that way. Catra is an internationally famous star. They're from two different worlds.

Not just that, either. Catra is obviously struggling. She's got far too much going on to even think about a relationship, and she seems to believe that the label are going to force her into another fake one.

It would never work out, no matter how attractive Adora thinks Catra is.

It's best if she doesn't even entertain those thoughts. She doubts that she and Catra will stay in contact after Sunday when Adora goes home.

After an hour, Lonnie comes to get her. "Adora? Weaver wants me to do some light makeup for you, since you'll be on camera later."

"Okay," Adora follows Lonnie through to where she's set up. She wants to ask if Catra apologised, but then that would make it obvious that Adora *told* her to apologise. "How was Catra?"

"I don't know if that girl has been possessed," Lonnie laughs as she gets started, "but she actually apologised for what she said

yesterday. And then she said *thanks* when I'd finished."

Adora smiles to herself as Lonnie does her makeup. She knows it's not much in the grand scheme of things, but it makes her feel proud of Catra nonetheless.

When Lonnie finishes, she asks where Catra is, though she didn't really need to. The loud music coming from the stage makes it easy to deduce that Catra is at soundcheck.

Adora watches from the sidelines as Catra plays through some of tonight's setlist with her backing band. Entrapta is here, messing around with wires and changing things that are probably too complicated for Adora to understand.

Even though Catra is performing, she doesn't look too happy. Probably because they're running through a lot of songs from her second and third albums, and she's barely touching the guitar slung over her shoulder. Adora realises suddenly that even if she *has* her guitar on stage, she's not always playing it. It's more like it's there for show.

When the song finishes and they start playing a cover of *The Middle* by Jimmy Eat World, Catra's mood seems to pick up. It's sad, to see her hate her own music so much but actually have fun when she's playing someone else's. Adora wonders even more why she barely plays guitar on stage anymore when she effortlessly glides through the guitar solo like it was nothing at all.

After *The Middle*, Catra and her band play *American Idiot*, and then a few classic rock songs that Adora doesn't know. Probably something by Guns N' Roses or Led Zeppelin – Catra is always wearing their t-shirts.

When there's a break in the music, and Catra plays some random guitar solo she looks like she's making up on the spot, Adora approaches.

"You're so good at that," Adora says, and Catra jumps in surprise, accidentally picking the wrong note. "Okay, maybe not that note. But other than that, you're really good. Why don't you play guitar on stage that much anymore?"

Catra laughs derisively. "They won't let me. It's too masculine, apparently. They don't want anyone making *assumptions.* It's probably why they won't let me make rock music, now that I think about it."

"Rock music is gay now?" Adora says. It's supposed to be sarcastic, and she thinks it hits the mark when Catra laughs a little less bitterly than before. "Play something for me. One of *your* songs, not the ones they make you sing."

Catra stares at her warily, almost like she's waiting for Adora to laugh and say she's just kidding, and then proceed to ask her to play *Wildcat* or one of her other hits. Then, she glances towards the doors, like she's expecting Weaver to drag her out by her hair for even thinking about it.

"It's going to be messy," Catra says, strumming a random chord on her guitar, "but give me five minutes. I need to teach the band the changes and I'm going to get yelled at for retuning my guitar to drop C# but I honestly don't care."

For a messy performance, it doesn't sound that messy. Adora is impressed by the band, first of all, for learning a song they don't know in five minutes, but she's even more impressed by Catra. Over the last few days, she's seen Catra sing a lot, but she's never seen her perform with this much passion. The lyrics are really from Catra's heart, talking about how she feels trapped in a cage and she just wants to be set free. Adora isn't sure how, but even the guitar solo reflects the pain and sorrow in the lyrics and shows her how Catra is really feeling.

When the song comes to a close, Catra looks over at Adora almost nervously. "What did you think?"

"I loved it," Adora says, and when Catra looks a little disbelieving, she smiles and walks out onto the big stage to pull her in for a hug. It's a little difficult with the guitar in between them, but Adora makes it work. "Really, I loved it. I've never seen you play like that. You looked like you actually loved what you were doing."

Catra smiles at her again when she pulls back, in that softer way she's been doing all day so far. It makes something in Adora's chest jump, but she pushes that aside like she promised herself she would.

"I do love it," Catra says quietly. She looks away, out into the big empty crowd area where 20,000 people will be watching her sing later. "This. I mean, it's amazing, don't get me wrong. But I'd be content with one person coming to see me play if it meant I was playing *my* music."

Adora shrugs. "One person did come to see you play."

Catra sighs again, and her hand comes up to squeeze the neck of her guitar like it's anchoring her. "It's kind of like torture, in some sick way. I write these songs and record demos on my own to show them what I want, and I take them to the label, and then they twist them and edit them until it's some barely recognisable, meaningless shell of what it started as. And then they make me sing them like nothing's wrong."

Adora opens her mouth to reply, but the click of Weaver's expensive heels comes closer, and Catra almost collapses in on herself at the sound. She shrinks, like she's hoping that Weaver won't see her out there on a big stage.

"Catrina," Weaver snaps, walking up and taking Catra's guitar away from her, "you have a meet and greet. Come on. Adora, feel free to grab some lunch from catering and relax in the lounge area for a while."

Adora watches helplessly as Weaver puts a firm hand on Catra's shoulder and forces her off the stage.

She’s picking at some mac and cheese when Catra comes back into the lounge area. She looks tired already, and Adora isn't surprised. Meet and greets must be pretty monotonous.

"I got you some mac and cheese," Adora of fers her the other plate when Catra sits down next to her. "It might be a little cold, but I'm sure it still tastes good."

Catra looks at the plate of mac and cheese but doesn't make a move to eat any of it. "Thanks. I'm going to go to T aco Bell."

For a moment, Adora thinks it’s a joke. But then Catra gets up and starts walking towards the door again, and she splutters in surprise. "Uh, what?"

"I have nothing to do until my show later," Catra says, "until W eaver comes back with her stupid cameras and makes me answer idiotic questions. I go out and explore all the time when I'm in dif ferent places after meet and greets. I'm going. They can't stop me."

"But...what about all of the fans?" Adora asks. There was already a line outside the venue when they arrived earlier. It’s probably tripled in size by now. "Don't you need to take security or something?"

"I'm fucking *sick* of having to take a team of bodyguards everywhere I go," Catra snaps. "I'm going to go and get some lunch like a normal person, and if people freak out, that’s their problem."

Adora has seen the fan reaction when Catra goes places. People trying to get to her, asking for photos and autographs and hugs like they're owed it. Adora remembers the last time Catra came back to Etheria; she got completely mobbed, people online were saying she had a panic attack because she was so crowded, and she hasn't been back since.

Catra knows she needs that security team, and it feels like she’s doing something reckless just for the sake of it.

"At least let me come with you," Adora says, because it doesn't look like she can talk Catra out of this. But if it comes down to it, Adora has Weaver's number. "I could go for a crunchwrap."

Catra pauses by the door, and Adora breathes out a small sigh of relief when she nods. "Yeah. Okay. Come on."

Nobody questions them when they walk by. Not even Scorpia – she just chats happily about her day until Catra pretends she has to do something important and they slip out of the back door.

It's quiet behind the venue. There are a couple of vans loaded with backup equipment, but the guys unloading them don't pay them any attention. They walk past, but Adora grabs Catra's arm before they can walk around the corner.

It's a good thing she did, because a few feet away is the back of the line to get into the venue later. Fans are standing around talking to each other, exchanging Twitter handles, talking about the setlist and their favourite songs.

It definitely confirms Adora's theory that Catra is doing something reckless for the sake of it when she leans around the corner to look too. She pulls her back. "What the hell are you doing?"

"Do you trust me?" Catra asks, and then shakes her head. "Okay, forget that, you don't. But I need you to."

Adora sighs. "Why?"

"We're going to run," Catra says, looking her up and down almost like she's *checking her out,* "it shouldn't be hard for you."

"Catra." Adora bites down on her bottom lip, because she knows that Catra isn't going to like this, "we really shouldn't."

"I'm going," Catra says, "you don't have to come with me, but you can't stop me."

"You're being reckless," Adora says, and she holds out her hand, "come back inside with me. We can order Taco Bell and *not* get attacked by thousands of people."

Catra looks at her again. Not in that soft way from before, either. There's no smile on her face. She just looks betrayed. "You sound just like Weaver."

"Weaver wouldn't give you a choice," Adora says just to show her just how wrong she is, "I'm asking you. If you really want to go out there, then I'm with you."

Catra's gaze flicks to the corner, and Adora knows she could just grab her and drag her inside, but that *would* make her exactly like Weaver.

"Okay," Catra says, and Adora wonders if this is the one time she'll ever witness a miracle, "okay. You're right. This is reckless."

Adora lets out an almost silent breath of relief and takes Catra's hand, leading her back inside before she can change her mind. "Why did you want to do it, anyway? You can't have wanted Taco Bell that bad. At least, it's not worth getting mobbed for."

"It would piss Weaver off if I ate a lot before a show, because I'm not supposed to," Catra says, and she glances back to the door as they walk past Scorpia, who tries to chat again about the events that have happened to her in the last five minutes.

Adora realises as they head by that she's still holding Catra's hand. She almost lets go, but then realises that *Catra* hasn't let go, and she totally could.

"Any other reason?" Adora asks, trying to get her mind off the whole Catra-is-holding-her-hand thing. "You can't have wanted to get mobbed just to tick off Weaver."

"I'm just sick of feeling like I'm not *normal*," Catra stops in her tracks and leans against the wall with a sigh. "I'm sick of everything. I should be able to walk down the street and get lunch without getting attacked."

"I know it's messed up," Adora says, "but it's just something that happens with fame."

It's why I would never want to be famous, Adora thinks to herself. Because she never had, and after meeting Catra and seeing all of this, she'd never want to be.

"Don't you get it?" Catra asks, and she looks annoyed. "I never *asked* to be famous. I never wanted to be famous. Do you think I posted YouTube videos because I was trying to get famous? I didn't. I posted them because it was the one place where I could fucking express myself, because Weaver is a fucking bitch who's been forcing me to be something I'm not since the day she adopted me. The only time she's ever been nice to me is when she was parading me around like her little fucking show pony at her business functions that she forced me to go to. I've never been allowed to be *me*, and music was the one place I could do that. Writing songs, posting covers, whatever, I was finally allowed to be myself. And then Weaver, and the record label, and the fans took that away from me. I'm not even a *person* anymore. I don't feel *anything.* So if I want to go out there and let them rip me to fucking shreds, then so be it."

Catra's hand pulls out of Adora's, and she turns and stomps down the hallway.

The next time Adora sees Catra, she's performing.

That doesn't mean much. Adora thinks that Catra is always performing. But she's on stage, playing her final show of the tour. She's smiling that celebrity smile, and she doesn't look anything like the angry girl who had ranted at her earlier, or the reckless one

who'd tried to throw herself to the wolves. She looks like the one Adora sees on camera and in interviews.

When the show and encore are finished, Catra goes off to the tour afterparty. It's for everyone who's been involved with the tour, and even Adora gets an invite. Everyone except Entrapta and Lonnie and her makeup team are there – all of Scorpia's security crew, the roadies, the band – and they all seem like they're having a good time.

Adora only has one drink, and mostly keeps to herself. She does like to party, but she doesn't feel like it tonight. She's still thinking about everything Catra said.

I'm not even a person anymore.

I don't feel anything.

If I want to go out there and let them rip me to fucking shreds, then so be it.

She watches as Catra goes straight to the whiskey and starts drinking. She remembers the day at the studio, where Catra had been drinking in the bathroom after Weaver had told her she was going to do that duet with Sea Hawk. She must've realised they were planning another PR romance then. Adora remembers yesterday, when she'd found Catra staring out of that window, looking down at the ground like she was thinking about jumping. And then today, when she'd tried to just walk out and get herself attacked.

She knows that Bow is right. Adora can't help. She can't change things. She can't take on Horde Records and get Catra out of her fucked up contract.

But she can be kind to her. She can show her that there are people out there who care. She can help her get through it, if Catra will let her. It seemed like she was going to, after last night. Adora can't get a read on her. She's so hot and cold, and she's not sure if Catra

actually wants her around or if she's just playing nice until the contest is over and Adora goes home.

"Unbelievable," Weaver mutters as she walks past, and Adora wonders why she's even here. She doesn't seem like the party type. "Getting herself wasted...unprofessional."

Weaver pauses when she spots her. She still looks at Adora like she's a piece of dirt on her shoe, but she smiles professionally. "Adora. We've got Rogelio waiting outside to take you and Catrina back to the house. Kindly follow me."

Adora abandons the rest of her drink – she wasn't interested anyway – and follows Weaver over to where Catra is sat with Scorpia. Scorpia is talking, as usual, and Catra is drinking, staring blankly off into space.

"Catrina," Weaver snaps her fingers in front of Catra's face, "come on. We have to be going now."

Catra looks over her cup and snorts with laughter. "Fuck you."

Weaver looks at Adora for a moment. Almost like she's saying *you see what she's like?* Adora doesn't let her face betray anything. "*Now*, Catrina. Rogelio is waiting, and you have a guest who I'm sure would like to get to bed."

"God, fuck off," Catra rolls her eyes, "go, I don't care. I'm staying here. I'll find my own way home."

Adora jumps back in surprise when Weaver grabs Catra by the collar of her t-shirt and pulls her up. "You will not speak to me in that manner. You will treat me with respect. Am I understood?"

"You'll get respect when you fucking earn it."

It's like the room goes silent when it happens. The words sink in, and Weaver's hand comes up, striking Catra across the cheek and

leaving an angry red mark on her face.

Everything stops. Everyone looks up. The cheery pop song playing in the background keeps blaring out, but that's the only sound other than Catra's bitter laugh as Weaver lets go of her shirt and she flops back onto the couch next to Scorpia.

Scorpia mumbles a quiet, "Catra, are you okay?" and Catra just scoffs in response.

Weaver smooths down her expensive suit jacket and skirt and clears her throat. This time, she is addressing the room. "None of you will say a word of this. I will remind you all that you are under NDAs. This counts as confidential information. If even a whisper of this leaves this room, Horde Records will pursue legal action against *all* of you."

Adora stares at the woman in shock and hatred. She can't believe that really happened. It's like she can barely move.

Weaver looks down at Catra next. "You are nothing but an entitled child who has no respect for anybody. Stay here and drink yourself to death for all I care. Come, Adora."

Adora stays rooted to the spot. She wants to say no. She wants to tell Weaver that she doesn't care if she sues her, she's telling someone what just happened. But then she remembers Razz's medical bills, and her student loans, and everything else she has on her plate, and she knows she can't. As much as it breaks her heart, she can't. Not unless she can find a way around that contract they made her sign.

She looks around at Catra and finds that her heterochromatic gaze is already on her. There's a bruise blossoming on her freckled cheek. "Go, Adora. I wouldn't put it past her to smack you too."

Adora looks back at Catra hopelessly as Weaver puts a tense hand on her shoulder and pushes her towards the door.

She doesn't talk to her in the car. Weaver stays in the front seat, muttering something about Catra's *insolence* and *cheek*, and Adora decides she's never disliked anyone the way she dislikes Weaver. Is that the first time she's hit Catra? It doesn't seem like it. Catra didn't look surprised, and there was the way that Weaver had grabbed her at the studio and shoved her back.

She remembers what Scorpia said yesterday. "*Catra's told me some things that... they make my heart break for her...*"

When the car pulls up outside of Catra's house, Weaver gets out of the car to unlock the front door for Adora. She's about to walk inside and go upstairs, maybe call Angella to see if she's found anything, because Adora can't stay silent about this but she also has to think of Razz too.

Weaver stops her. "About... what you witnessed. Catrina has always been a difficult child. Absolutely rotten to the core. Some people just are, and sometimes there are no other ways to deal with them-"

"Don't try to justify it," Adora snaps, "you *hit* her. Maybe she was talking back, but I think she has a right to when you treat her the way you do, when you're forcing her to make music she hates, when you're forcing her to stay in the closet and pretend to be something she's not. You manipulated her when she was a kid so you could make *money* off of the one thing she actually loved to do. You're keeping her trapped in a shitty contract that overworks her and gives her zero freedom. You can't justify that."

Adora stomps inside and slams the door in Weaver's face. It's probably too late to call Angella now, but she can look through the contract on her own again, no matter how much it hurts her head. She's not going to let Catra stay in this situation, and she's going to find a way to help her.

She falls asleep somewhere around her fourth re-read and feeling increasingly hopeless.

Adora wakes up to a loud bang.

She sits up in bed, and has that moment of disorientation, where she can't quite remember where she is. The contract falls from her chest, where she must've dropped it when she fell asleep, and then she remembers Catra and the afterparty and *Weaver* and feels a little sick.

There's another bang from downstairs, and Adora grabs the nearest object that could pass for a weapon – a can of deodorant. From the digital clock on her bedside table, she learns that it's 3:39AM, which is basically peak time for burglars and murderers.

Adora slowly creeps out of the bedroom. Maybe the proper course of action is locking her bedroom door and calling Scorpia and her security team, but Adora has always thrown herself into everything head-first and she's not thinking rationally. She tiptoes down the stairs, squinting in the dark. There's another bang again, and she decides that if this is some kind of robber, they're not the best at their job.

She knows she's making jokes to herself to distract from the way her heart is beating out of her chest and her hands are shaking, but she ignores that little fact. Adora pauses at the foot of the stairs and looks around. She doesn't know where the banging is coming from, and she almost convinces herself that she imagined it when it happens.

Catra pops up from behind one of the couches, and Adora screams and sprays deodorant at her until she realises who it is.

Catra blinks at her, coughing, and Adora pauses to get her breath back. "What were you doing down there?"

"I fell," Catra says, and she wobbles back again. Adora drops the can of deodorant and wraps an arm around her waist to steady her. "The room is shaky."

"I think you'll find you're the shaky one," Adora says, and Catra laughs enough for her to know that she's really, *really* fucking drunk. Even drunker than she was at the afterparty. "How did you get home? How much did you drink?"

"Scorpia put me in her car . I drank a lot," Catra says, and Adora leads her over to the kitchen. She keeps one arm around Catra's waist as she gets her a glass of tap water. "How much did you drink?"

"I didn't drink anything," Adora says, of fering her the glass of water. Catra moves away from it and Adora scowls. "Catra, drink the fucking water so I can get you to bed."

"That' s a little forward," Catra says, looking her up and down, "but I'd be lying if I said I wasn't interested."

Adora almost drops her when Catra says that. "What?"

A shaky hand moves up and rests on Adora's jaw . Catra's thumb strokes her cheek as she mumbles, "you're pretty ."

"You're drunk," Adora steps back and lets her go. Creating a distance is a good idea. Catra stumbles again and grips onto the kitchen counter to steady herself, and Adora holds out the water. "Just drink this."

Catra takes the water and drinks the whole glass in one big gulp. She spills a little bit down her shirt, and she almost drops the glass but somehow manages to catch it and put it down on the counter, where it flops over again. Which is good because Adora is too focused on what Catra had said.

I'd be lying if I said I wasn't interested.

There's no way that she means that. Catra is just drunk and lonely . Of course she's not interested. She *wouldn't* be interested, and

Adora shouldn't be thinking about this anyway. Catra is in no place to get into a relationship.

"You look like you're thinking," Catra reaches out and pokes Adora in the cheek, "stop thinking and start talking. I like when you talk."

"Let's just get you to bed," Adora says, reaching out to help Catra towards the stairs. That's the important thing right now. Not some stupid drunken comment made by a pretty girl. "You've got a music video shoot tomorrow."

"Really wish I cared, but I don't," Catra says loudly, "it's for that fucking collab with Sea Hawk. They're going to make me kiss him. I don't want to kiss him but I'm not allowed to say no."

"Did you..." Adora pauses, but she asks anyway, "did you get like this so you'd be too hungover tomorrow to film the video?"

Catra snorts with laughter. It's not genuine, it's sarcastic and derisive. "Like they'd ever let me stay home. I could be on my fucking *deathbed* and they'd milk every last second."

"You need to get some rest," Adora says quietly, helping her up the stairs, "come on."

"I need permanent fucking rest," Catra mutters, and when they reach the top of the stairs, she wobbles again. It seems intentional this time. "That would be nice."

"No, it wouldn't," Adora pulls her away from the top of the stairs and towards her bedroom door. "It's going to be okay, Catra."

"It's not," Catra stumbles against her bedroom door and barks out that sarcastic laugh, "I wish I was fucking *dead.*"

Adora had known that. It wasn't hard to work out from the way Catra had been acting. But actually hearing her say it, hearing those

thoughts confirmed. It breaks Adora's heart even more. Nobody should feel like that.

"I understand why you feel that way, Catra, I really do," Adora says, and Catra's eyes meet hers like she's remembering someone is with her. "But you have to keep going. I know it feels like everything is hopeless right now, but one day it's going to be better. Your contract will expire, and you'll be free to do whatever you want. Even if that's running away to the forest and living in a little secluded cottage with your future wife."

"My wife," Catra mumbles, staring at Adora in that weird way again, "will you be my wife? I like you. You're nice to me and you're pretty. Nobody's nice to me, but you are. I'd like to live in a cottage with you."

Adora's mouth works, because what the hell is she supposed to say to that? She knows that Catra's just saying things. She's drunk and she's blurting out anything, and her emotions are all over the place as it is. Adora can't go telling her how she'd like to live in a cottage with her too, when she knows Catra doesn't mean it.

"Come on," Adora says, reaching out with one hand and pushing Catra's bedroom door open. She leads her inside, feeling heterochromatic eyes burning holes into the side of her head. "You need to get in your pyjamas and get some sleep."

Carefully, Adora sits Catra down on her bed. Catra won't stop staring at her. She looks at her as Adora roots through all of her drawers to find some pyjamas, watching her like she's some sort of puzzle she has to figure out.

She doesn't say anything either. She stays silent as Adora changes her into her pyjamas with a lot of averted eyes, and keeps staring at her as she tucks her into bed.

"Okay," Adora says, looking down at Catra. She's on her side, curled up in bed, looking right back at her. "Goodnight."

"Adora," Catra whispers, reaching her hand out, "will you stay with me?"

She can't say no. There's no way she'd ever be able to. She tells herself it's not because of the little flutter in her chest, and just because Catra needs someone. "Okay."

Carefully, Adora slips into Catra's bed next to her. Catra doesn't hesitate to roll over and snuggle her face into Adora's shoulder like it's the safest place in the world. Maybe for her it is. Adora wraps her arms around Catra and holds her close. She wants her to feel like she's safe, even if it's only for a little while. Because she's not sure if Catra knows what that's like.

"You're from Etheria," Catra says into her shoulder like she's just remembered, "do you think if- if this hadn't happened to me...do you think we'd be friends?"

Adora laughs quietly at the suggestion, because she's thought about that herself. She remembers little six-year-old Catrina in the sandbox and nods. "Yeah. I think we would."

"What about..." Catra pauses, "what about more than that?"

The question makes Adora's stomach drop. "I don't know."

"I think I like you," Catra says quietly. Her voice is muffled by Adora's pyjama t-shirt. "I know it's stupid, but you're just- you treat me like I'm a person. You're so nice to me and you don't take any of my shit and you're so pretty and *normal* and I keep thinking about it and I think I want to kiss you."

Adora bites down on her bottom lip. "Catra"...

Slowly, Catra surfaces from her hiding place in Adora's shoulder. She stares down at her and Adora knows she's inching closer. "Can I kiss you?"

"No," Adora says, and Catra looks immediately hurt. Adora knows she'd blurted that answer out in a little bit of a panic, so she reaches out and gently brushes Catra's wild, messy hair back from her forehead. "I don't mean it like that. You're really drunk right now and you don't know what you want. If- in any other circumstance, I would totally kiss you right now. But I just- I can't, okay? It wouldn't be fair to either of us."

All Catra seems to take from that is, "You want to kiss me too?"

"I would," Adora says, "If things weren't like this."

"I'll remember that," Catra says it like she's promising her, and she snuggles her face into Adora's shoulder again. "Can you tell me a story? About you?"

"Me?" Adora says like her heart isn't pounding against her rib cage. "I'm boring."

"You're *normal.* I don't mean that in a bad way. You're just- you go to school and work and you see your family and you have friends. I wish I had that. I like that you're normal. I think I like you a lot. You make.you make me feel things that I haven't felt for a really long time and I think I want you." Catra mumbles into her shoulder, and Adora's throat knots tightly. "Can you tell me about being normal? I want- I want to know things about you."

"Okay," Adora says, and without thinking about it, she lets her hand run gently through Catra's long, wild hair. "Well, my usual day tends to go like this. I get up and shower and get ready for work, and then me and my grandma have breakfast together. She cooks, because the kitchen is her turf, and she doesn't let anyone else make anything when she's home. After breakfast, I go out to work for the day. I told you I'm an assistant coach at Etheria High – I love sports, and I was really active in the sports department when I went to school there, so they gave me the assistant job when I came home to look after Razz."

She stays quiet for a few moments, wondering if Catra has fallen asleep. But Catra grips Adora's t-shirt tighter and says, "keep going."

"After work, sometimes I go home and hang out with Razz all night," Adora says, "those are the really wild nights, obviously . But other times I drive back to Bright Moon and see my friends Bow and Glimmer. They're from Etheria too, and we've been best friends since we were kids. Sometimes I'm kind of a third wheel because they got together about a year ago, but it's never felt like that. When we hang out, we do loads of different things. Parties, nights in, shopping, going out for dinner..pretty much anything you can think of."

Adora pauses again, but this time, Catra doesnt say anything. Her grip on Adora's shirt has loosened too, so she assumes she's asleep. For a minute, Adora considers leaving and going back to her own room, because she's not sure what Catra will do when she wakes up in the morning and finds her there.

But she cant help herself. Adora pulls Catra closer and closes her eyes, holding her tight, like she's trying to reassure her sleeping consciousness that she's here and she's not letting go.

After what feels like hours of lying there, holding Catra tightly, Adora drifts off into the best sleep she's had all week.

Friday

Chapter Summary

catra asks adora for help

Chapter Notes

warnings for this chapter - verbal abuse, physical abuse (mention), homophobia, suicidal ideation

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The first thing Adora registers is the harsh lighting in Catra's bedroom.

The second is the sheets being pulled off of them.

The third is Weaver's angry voice. "You are *late*. We were supposed to be on the set of the music video half an hour ago. Everyone is waiting, and I can't guarantee that word of your unprofessionalism won't get out."

Catra blinks, sitting up, and then her eyes widen and she turns a sickly shade of green. She darts over to her ensuite bathroom, and there's the distinct sound of someone vomiting. Adora jumps up too and quickly scrapes Catra's hair back from her face, rubbing comforting circles into her back even though puking freaks her out.

"Do not give her sympathy, Adora," Weaver says condescendingly from the doorway, "she did this to herself, purposely. But don't worry, Catrina. You won't miss your music video, and we'll make sure to get a few extra shots of the scripted kiss scene."

Adora isn't sure if it's the hangover that makes Catra puke again, or that. But she holds her hair back anyway as Weaver barks, "make yourselves somewhat presentable and get down to the car, *asap.*"

As the click of her heels fades away, Catra leans back against the bathroom wall. There are tears in her eyes, and she looks so *ill* that Adora wants to put her right back to bed.

Adora doesn't know what she remembers from last night, if she remembers anything. But Catra wipes her eyes with the back of her hand and mumbles a quiet, "thanks."

"It's okay," Adora says, and she holds out a hand to help her up from the bathroom floor. "Come on."

Catra stares at her hand warily but lets Adora help her up. "I'm sorry."

"Don't apologise," Adora says, even though she's not sure what she's apologising for, "it's okay. Let's just... let's just get ready."

Catra sighs, but she nods in agreement. "Yeah. Okay."

Adora goes back to her own room and gets ready for the day as quickly as she can. She hates skipping a shower, but she knows that if she takes forever, Weaver will take it out on Catra. She makes sure she has everything she might need – basically just her phone and her wallet – and then walks back to Catra's room, knocking quietly on the door.

Catra opens the door, and she looks rough. The dark circles under her eyes seem like they've tripled in size, her normally flawless golden-brown skin has a weird green tinge to it, and she looks like she's about to collapse. There's an angry red mark on her cheek from where Weaver had smacked her last night that breaks Adora's heart. But she's dressed and ready, so Adora takes her gently by the waist and helps her downstairs.

"It's going to be okay," Adora says, and she doesn't know what she's referring to. The music video? Catra's life? "You just have to get through this."

Did Catra questions, and it takes Adora so off guard that she doesn't know what to say.

Weaver goes through her usual berating in the car, though this time it's a lot more aggressive. She never raises her voice, but she uses her words like weapons, hitting Catra exactly where it hurts while Catra stares out of the window and pretends like she can't hear it. It seems like a morning routine for them.

"and you need to keep your filthy paws off Adora," Weaver says, and Adora snaps to attention at the sound of her name. "God knows what the two of you were doing in bed together, but I will not let you manipulate a fan into sleeping with you. I wouldn't put it past you to do such a thing, as depraved as you are-"

"Leave her alone," Adora interrupts, "she's not manipulating me, and I won't let you use me to manipulate her."

Weaver ignores her for the most part. "I see the manipulation is already complete, then. When she exposes you online for being the horrible person you are, do not come crying to me to fix it."

Catra acts like she hasn't heard, but her nails dig into the car seat.

When they arrive at the music video set, Catra is whisked away to makeup immediately, and Adora is left to stand around and watch. The set is a high school that's closed for the summer, because apparently that's going to be the storyline for the music video, despite Catra being twenty-one and Sea Hawk being twenty-six

Adora watches as people set things up, with the director and Weaver ordering the crew around, making them change the tiniest details. The gym that they're in has been completely decorated like a school prom, and there's a ludicrously frilly dress hung up that's obviously meant for Catra.

Adora is staring at it, trying—and failing—to imagine Catra actually wearing it when Sea Hawk sits down next to her. He's already

dressed in a standard black tux."Hello! Y ou're the person who won that contest, or so I've been told. It sounds like a lot of fun. Adventure is the greatest thing in life!"

Adora hums. "Y eah."

"I like to consider little things like PR relationships an adventure," Sea Hawk says, "Nobody in the industry ever really wants to do them, but you can make a new friend. And some people have actually developed real relationships from them!"

Adora snorts with laughter before she can think about it. "Y eah, I dont think youll be developing anything like that with Catra."

"Actually , I already have a girlfriend," Sea Hawk professes proudly , "my dearest Mermista. But she understands that these things must happen for my career to advance, and she knows that Catra is no threat."

"I might be a threat when she dumps you because you cant do anything with her anymore," Catra scof fs from behind her, making Adora jump, and Adora guesses that comment is about the girlfriend that broke up with her during her last PR relationship. "Let' s just get this over with."

Adora has to admire Lonnie's makeup work – Catra has gone from looking hungover and like she's going to collapse to runway ready in barely any time at all. She's not wearing that big frilly dress yet, and Adora can already imagine the argument that's going to break out when they try to get her into it.

"Ah, yes," Sea Hawk smiles and holds out his hand for her , "let us go forth into adventure!"

Catra scowls at him and walks away, and to his credit, Sea Hawk's big smile doesnt falter . He looks at Adora and says, "I'm sure Ill grow on her," before following her of f to the director.

They run through a few of the marks they need to hit and rehearse a few things, and after half an hour of that, Weaver snaps her fingers at Catra, who is still in her skinny jeans and *Queen* t-shirt. "Enough rehearsal. Catrina, go get into your costume, and then we shall start. I think we should record the kiss scene first."

Catra takes one look at the big dress and hears the words *kiss scene*. She pales and blurts, "I'm going to the bathroom," and shoots away before Weaver can grab her and keep her there.

Weaver tuts in disapproval, but Adora is starting to notice that's like her automatic response to anything Catra does.

Adora gives Catra five minutes, and the moment Weaver starts talking like she's going to go and get her, she excuses herself to the bathroom too. Weaver squints at her, because Adora isn't exactly in her good books anymore, but she lets her go.

It's not hard to find the bathrooms. They're on the ground floor, the same as the gym, and it's a quick jog around the corner. She understands why Catra likes them so much – they're probably the only place she ever has even an ounce of privacy. Adora pushes the door open, already expecting to find Catra mid-freak out, but definitely not expecting what she actually finds.

The bathroom window has been pushed wide open, and Catra has one leg out of the window. She looks like she's about to bolt across the big empty parking lot outside, but she pauses when she sees Adora, staring at her like she's waiting for her to shout for Weaver.

"Uh." Adora breaks the silence as she stares right back. "Are you… are you running away?"

Catra grips the windowsill. She stares outside at the deserted parking lot and eventually she nods. "I. I can't- I just- I have to go. I can't do this anymore. Please don't tell them. It's not like yesterday, I'm not trying to get myself hurt."

"But you can't just," Adora gestures towards the window, "I mean- no offense, Catra, but you go out in public and cause *mobs*. You *could* get hurt."

"I don't care. We're on the ground, I won't hurt myself on my way out. There's nobody there. Nobody needs to know." Catra says, and she looks so defeated that Adora's stomach twists anxiously. Catra looks out to the parking lot again. "I can't stay here. I think if I stay... I think it'll kill me. If Weaver doesn't do it first, I think I'm going to end up hurting myself."

Adora watches her, knowing entirely well that Catra is serious. "Catra"…

Catra looks outside longingly, and then holds out her hand in Adora's direction. "Help me. Come with me. Just- don't make me go back there. *Please.* It's different, it's not like yesterday, I was just doing that to be stupid and reckless but this- I just... I don't want to die."

Adora stares at Catra's outstretched hand. Maybe it's those stupid feelings in her gut that makes her do it. Maybe it's because she genuinely does want to help her, despite knowing just how much trouble they'll get in. Or maybe it's because Catra had actually *asked* for her help.

Adora takes Catra's hand and tangles their fingers together. "Okay. But we have to go fast. I think they knew I was coming here to check on you."

Catra smiles. Actually, genuinely smiles, so much that it reaches her eyes and makes them sparkle with so much beauty. "Thank you, Adora."

Adora doesn't think about how much trouble they're going to be in. All she knows is that Catra is genuinely asking for help, and Adora promised she'd be a friend to her. So she helps her. She runs back to the bathroom door and slides the lock across to buy them some

time as Catra swings her other leg over the window and hops out into the shrubbery.

Catra holds out her hand again, and Adora seals her fate. She grabs onto it and lets Catra help her out of the window, sliding it shut behind them. For a moment, Catra looks at it, like she can't believe she just did that.

Then she squeezes Adora's hand, and like they both have the same thought at the same time, they set off at a run across the empty parking lot.

"Weaver's going to fucking kill me," Catra says, but it's not said in that despondent tone she usually uses. Instead, she laughs, and it's actually genuine. "And I couldn't care less. I'm ordering an Uber. Do you have your ID? We're going to the airport."

Adora pauses in her tracks as Catra pulls her phone out of her pocket. "*Wait,* the airport? You said you wanted to go home."

"Yeah," Catra says, "Etheria. I want to go to Etheria."

Weaver really is going to kill them. And maybe it *is* stupid and reckless, but rule one of surviving a toxic situation is getting yourself *out* of the toxic situation. So Adora nods and takes Catra's phone, switching it off.

"I'll order it. They might track your phone or something," Adora says, and Catra looks at her with that same shining admiration again. "I'll get it to pick us up at that Five Guys down the street."

She orders the Uber, pockets her phone, and takes Catra's hand again. Catra is still looking at her like that, like Adora the greatest thing she's ever seen, and it makes that stupid feeling in her stomach happen again.

"You can go back. You don't have to come with me," Catra says, looking at her in amazement. "You've- you've already helped me

more than anyone else ever has."

"Someone' s got to be there to fight off the rabid fans for you. Like you're going to manage it when you're so tiny ."Adora teases her . It's meant to make her laugh, but that admiring expression still doesnt waver. "Besides, where are you going to go when you get back to Etheria?"

"I."Catra pauses, "I dont know ."

"Good thing I know where Razz keeps her spare key ,"Adora nudges her playfully, "and she always fusses over my friends when I bring them home."

"You'd.you'd do that?You ou'd let me stay with you?"Catra asks, but she doesnt give her a chance to reply . "I have- if the label try to threaten you, I have money, I can protect you"…

"We shouldnt think about that right now ,"Adora says, "I just.we should get you somewhere safe. And right now, we're too close. Weaver has probably already noticed we're gone and it wont be long before other people-"

"Wildcat?"

Both of them turn at the exact same moment. Scorpia has just rounded the corner from the entrance to the high school, where she's been stationed to guard it.

Catra cringes. She puts on an obviously fake smile as Scorpia approaches them curiously. "Hey , Scorpia. What's up?"

"Well, right now Im wondering what you're doing out here when you're supposed to be in there at your music video shoot,"Scorpia says, pointing towards the building behind them. "You're not.you're not doing something reckless, are you?"

Adora almost expects Catra to cave. She expects her to walk back into the building and film the music video like she's supposed to. But Catra is full of surprises today.

"I'm going," Catra says hurriedly, almost panicked, "I'm just... I'm going. I can't do it anymore. I need to go. And if you've ever been my friend, I'm asking you not to stop me."

Scorpia is obviously conflicted. She glances towards the building where the shoot is being held, and then back at Catra with a sigh. She takes off her sunglasses and passes them to her. "Here. You at least need some sort of disguise. *Go.* Before I change my mind."

Adora's pretty sure she witnesses the first time Catra hugs Scorpia first. She pounces on her, pulls her in for a tight hug, and mumbles, "thank you," into her shoulder before letting go. Catra grabs Adora's hand again and puts the sunglasses on. Adora takes off the baseball cap she's wearing and puts it on Catra's head for good measure.

"Okay," Catra squeezes Adora's hand lightly, "let's go. I'm sorry in advance for dragging you into this."

"It's okay," Adora says, "what's life without a little adventure?"

Catra flashes her that smile again. That real one, the one that makes Adora's heart clench, and she thinks Catra could get her to do anything if she just smiled at her like that before she asked.

They take one last look over at the school before breaking out into a run.

As the adrenaline starts to wear off, Adora can see that Catra gets increasingly nervous. Her phone is still switched off and in her bag, and Adora uses hers sparingly once Weaver starts to call her. She blocks Weaver's number for good measure, and by the time their Uber gets them to LAX, news has already broken that international pop sensation *Catra* has gone missing.

Catra is tense as they buy tickets. The name on her credit card says *Catrina Driluth*, and it's the same on her driver's license, and the lady selling them tickets doesn't seem to recognise her , but there are a lot of people walking around the terminal.

They don't have any bags with them; literally just two phones, two wallets and the clothes on their backs, so security isn't too stressful. Except for the part where they make Catra take her hat and sunglasses off because she looks *suspicious*. Adora glances around to make sure nobody's taking any photographs, and they seem to be in the clear. She still keeps her eyes peeled for anyone looking at them strangely or taking pictures, and checks Twitter for updates too.

Once they're out of security , Catra puts the hat and sunglasses back on, and they take refuge in one of the overpriced restaurants while they wait for their gate to come up on the screen. Their flight is in an hour and a half. That's a lot of time for Catra's management team to buy tickets and get through security to drag them back to the music video shoot.

"Relax," Catra says as they wait for the food they ordered. She looks less than relaxed herself, but at least she isn't looking around everywhere every five seconds. "If anyone figures out it's me, and takes a picture, we'll be on the plane by the time Weaver even gets to the airport. We're fine."

"It won't be hard for her to figure out where we're going, though," Adora says, and then she pales, "I think she has my address. She has to! I had to put it in when I applied for the contest. Oh, god, she's going to find us, and she's going hurt you again-"

"Adora," Catra reaches out and takes her hand on top of the table, "I know she's going to find me eventually. I just- I need to figure out my game plan before that happens. I just have to be away from her to do it."

"Your game plan?" Adora frowns. "You have a plan?

"Not yet," Catra says, "but I'm thinking of one. I'm done. I can't do all of that anymore or it's going to kill me. I have to find a way to get out of that fucking contract and the only way that can happen is if they agree to terminate it. The only way *that's* going to happen is if I have something on them. I have an idea but I'm not sure if it's entirely legal. And at this point, I don't really care."

"The things they do to you aren't entirely legal," Adora says bitterly, "do it. I'll help you."

"I couldn't ask you to do that," Catra says, and she looks over the table so softly that it makes Adora's heart jump in her chest. "You've already done more than enough. Even just- I mean, honestly, even on that first night when you told me you wouldn't put up with my bullshit. You treat me like I'm an actual person and that's more than anyone else has ever done."

"Catra, that's the bare minimum," Adora slowly lets their fingers tangle together on top of the table, "besides, I never came into this thing like a crazy fangirl who put you on a pedestal. I just liked your music."

"At least that makes one of us," Catra mutters, and then she lets out a long breath and shakes her head, "Why did you even apply, then?"

"You're going to think I'm a complete stalker," Adora says, and laughs at the worried expression on Catra's face, "relax, I'm not actually a stalker. It's just- we met before. I was seven, you were six. We built sandcastles. I like your music, sure, but I guess I just wondered if we'd get along now. I wasn't going to apply, but my friends told me to, and I figured why not because I didn't think I'd win."

Catra stares at her, and Adora assumes she doesn't remember. She didn't think she would. But then Catra smiles. "It was you."

It's not phrased like a question, but Adora answers it anyway. "Yeah. It was me."

"Of course. Adora. *Duh*," Catra says it like it's obvious and laughs quietly to herself, "I can't believe I didn't figure that out. I guess I wasn't thinking about it, but... damn."

"I take it you remember, then?" Adora asks, and Catra nods. "I didn't think you would."

"Obviously I would, that's like one of the only happy childhood memories I have," Catra says, and then realises what she'd said and deflates a little bit, "It... that day meant a lot to me. I'd never had a friend before. And I didn't have another one until I met Scorpia, and even that- I mean, she *works* for me, you know? So... I'm glad I found you again, I guess."

"I went back to the park the next day," Adora admits, "just to see if you'd be there. I wanted to build more sandcastles, but then it rained."

"I was grounded. I wasn't even supposed to be there in the first place," Catra says, and when Adora frowns inquisitively, she laughs, "I climbed out of the kitchen window at the children's home I lived in. I was bored."

Adora nudges her leg under the table with her foot, "You've obviously got a thing about climbing out of windows."

"Apparently I do," Catra meets her gaze and smiles that soft smile again. Suddenly, Adora remembers what she said last night, when she was looking at her similarly in her drunken haze. *"I think I like you. You're so nice to me and you don't take any of my shit and you're so pretty and normal and I keep thinking about it and I think I want to kiss you."*

She's so beautiful. So beautiful. It must be some unspoken rule that every musician has to be attractive, because Catra definitely fits that category. Part of Adora wishes she'd just let Catra kiss her last night, but she was drunk and confused and even if she wasn't, she's not in an emotional place for that. Adora just wanted to do what was right.

But she'd be lying if she said she didn't want to kiss Catra too.

"And we've got the cheeseburger." Adora jumps and motions to herself when their waitress comes over and places the cheeseburger in front of her, "and the chicken club sandwich. Enjoy, girls."

"Thanks," Catra says for the both of them, and nudges Adora under the table with her foot, "are you okay?"

"Yeah, yeah," Adora says, nodding and digging into her fries, "let's just eat and then we can get on the plane and get out of here."

Their gate gets announced when they've just finished eating. Adora wants to pay the bill, because Catra had bought the plane tickets, but Catra just rolls her eyes and steals Adora's debit card until she's already paid with her own.

Adora checks Twitter again, just to see if there are any updates on the Catra situation. There aren't, thankfully. Catra's sunglasses-and-baseball-cap disguise seems to have made her blend in enough at the airport, because nobody has tweeted that she's been spotted at LAX, and there aren't any photographs circulating.

Bow and Glimmer are both blowing up her phone with texts, asking her if she's okay, if she knows what's happening, if she's heard that Catra is missing. She texts them back and tells them that she's fine and she's going to be home soon, and she'll explain everything then.

They're still bombarding her with messages when she and Catra have boarded the plane – to the *business class* area – and she has to switch it onto airplane mode. The flight is around three hours and a half, and the further they get from LA, the more Adora relaxes.

Catra relaxes too. She rests her head on Adora's shoulder and carefully takes her hand on the armrest between them. "Is this okay?"

Adora ignores how her heart has decided to see how fast it can beat. "Yeah."

"Good," Catra breathes out, and a weight seems to come off of her. "Is it wrong that I feel good? I know that when they find me I'll be in literally the most trouble ever. They'll probably say I breached contract and sue me, and if they don't do that, they'll somehow figure out how to make things worse for me. But I honestly just don't care anymore. I'm done being their puppet. I want... I want to learn how to be happy."

"You deserve to be," Adora says, "honestly, you... you scare me, sometimes. With some of the... the things you'd say or do."

"I... I scare myself," Catra admits, "it's just hard when I feel like everything is never going to end. Dying feels like the only way out, but I... I don't want to die. I just don't want this life. I want to be happy one day, with... with a little house and a cat and a girlfriend who loves me and who I love just as much, and I could write stupid sappy love songs just for her and sing them to her with an old acoustic guitar on our little front porch while the sun sets. It just feels like sometimes I'm never going to get that. I'm going to be stuck in an endless cycle of contracts and albums and tours until eventually I can't take it anymore."

Adora squeezes Catra's hand like she's going to fade away if she lets go. "You'll get the things you want, Catra. I promise. I'm going to make sure you get the things you want."

"Right now, I just want to sleep for a little while," Catra says, and her fingers curl around Adora's just as tightly. "Is that okay?"

Adora smiles. "Yeah. I'll wake you up when we get to Etheria."

Catra sleeps for almost the whole flight, right there on Adora's shoulder. She's still tired when she wakes up, but it's not that long of a taxi ride back to Razz's, and Adora promises her that they can go

to bed when they get there. Whatever Weaver has been doing to find Catra, they can face it in the morning.

When the taxi drops them off, Adora takes Catra's hand again as they walk up Razz's driveway. She gets the spare key out of the hanging basket by the door and unlocks it, gesturing Catra inside first.

"Who is that?" Razz calls from the kitchen, and it's not long before she comes shuffling out with her broom poised, ready to strike the intruder. She sees Adora first, and then Catra, and she smiles. "Oh, Adora, dearie. I thought you weren't supposed to be back until Sunday. Or is it already Sunday? And you brought a friend! Come in, come in."

Adora shuts the door behind them and lets Razz pull her in for a tight hug. "Hi, Razz. I decided to come home early."

"Good, good," Razz says, "are you hungry? I was just making pie! Who is your friend? Would she like some pie?"

"Razz, this is my friend Catra," Adora introduces her, and Razz squints at her through her glasses, "she's going to stay with us for… a little while."

Razz steps forwards, looking Catra up and down with a frown. "I know this one."

"Oh, um," Adora laughs awkwardly, "about that, she's kind of-"

"The sandbox at the park!" Razz exclaims, clapping her hands together in remembrance. "Come in, dearie. You've grown a lot since then. I'll go make tea!"

With that, she bustles off to the kitchen again, humming a song to herself. Catra glances over at Adora. "If you hadn't already told me about that, I would've been really confused right now."

"She has a… *weird* memory. It's not dementia or anything, it's just how she is. I could ask her what I had for breakfast on my third day of second grade and she'd tell me, but if I asked her what she watched on TV last night, she'd have no idea." Adora shrugs. "Anyway , are you hungry? I know we ate at the airport, but we have plenty…"

"Actually , do you mind if I just get a shower?" Catra asks, and Adora takes that as *I'm not hungry.* "I always feel kind of disgusting after being on planes, and even though I might not look it, I'm still hungover as fuck. And I had to skip my shower this morning after our…rude awakening."

Adora nods. That morning feels like a million years ago, even though it's only just getting to 5pm. "Y eah, of course. Ill get you some pyjamas you can change into, if you want."

"Y eah," Catra says, "please."

Adora quickly runs to her bedroom and grabs a fresh set of pyjamas from her drawer, and then she shows Catra the bathroom and gives her a quick shower tutorial, because they're always weirdly hard to work out at other people's houses.

Then she leaves her to it and goes to join Razz in the kitchen. She' s already made three mugs of tea, and there's a pie cooling on the rack. "Where is your friend?"

"She just went in the shower ," Adora says, taking a sip of the boiling hot tea, "thanks for the tea."

She checks Twitter again. This time, her stomach twists anxiously . Right there on the trending page, there's a picture of Catra heading to the gate at LAX. From the angle it was taken at, Catra is completely blocking Adora from view aside from the top of her head, but Catra is definitely recognisable. #FindCatra is trending on T witter, along with #C omeBackCatra and #W eMissYouCatra.

Adora glances down the hallway. She knows this is a serious situation, and she knows that people are worried, but that doesn't seem to matter when Catra had asked her for help.

She scrolls through a few more tweets, but then her phone screen changes to show that Bow and Glimmer want to group FaceTime. Reluctantly, she answers.

"Okay," Glimmer says, "what the *hell* is going on?"

"Everything is fine," Adora says, showing the camera around the room, "I'm at home. It's all fine. You don't need to worry."

Bow frowns. "Aren't *you* worried? You called me the other day telling me how depressed you think Catra is, and now she's disappeared, and you don't look worried at all. People think she might've hurt herself, or *been* hurt, or-"

"Catra is with me," Adora says, and Bow and Glimmer both look at her like she just told them she's actually not a human but a being from another planet, "she's fine. She's just in the shower."

Glimmer is the first to recover. "You kidnapped a celebrity?!"

"What? No!" Adora splutters and then defends herself, "If anything, she kidnapped *me*. It was her idea to come back to Etheria."

"Okay, so, the celebrity you're spending a week with has some weird mental break and wants to fly away somewhere, and your solution is to say *okay?"* Glimmer stares at her through the camera, and even Adora feels the full effect. "What if you get in trouble?"

"It's fine, okay?" Adora tries to reason. "Really. It's fine. Catra is fine, and I think if she stayed there, she *would've* hurt herself. I was just trying to help."

Adora hears the water stop running, and she quickly cuts Bow off in the middle of him starting to say, "you can't always help," as she

blurts out, "got to go, bye."

She hangs up on them despite their protests and puts her phone down with a sigh. She wonders what *Catra's* phone is going to be like. Probably blowing up like crazy. Adora sips on her tea and watches Razz as she cleans the stovetop, waiting for Catra to come out of the bathroom.

"Hey , Adora."

"Hey , I- *whoa*," Adora cuts herself of f when she turns around and meets Catra's gaze. Because she hadn't been expecting *that.* Gone is the wild, messy mane of hair that Catra has always had. It's still messy and wild, but now it's in a short, pixie cut style. "Y ou cut your hair."

"I just," Catra pauses and sits down next to her , "I was looking at myself in the mirror and I just wanted it gone. Does it look okay?"

"Y eah, actually," Adora says, hesitating for only a second before she lets her fingers run through the length. "Especially considering you did it yourself."

"Thanks," a light blush colours Catra' s cheeks, highlighting those adorable freckles, "can you even it out at the back for me?"

Adora raises her eyebrows. "Y ou trust me near your neck with scissors?"

"Y eah," Catra laughs, "I figure if you wanted to kill me, you'd have done it by now."

"I don't know , maybe I've been waiting for the perfect moment," Adora jokes as Catra leads her back to the bathroom. There' s a *lot* of hair in the trash can. "First I kill you, and then I sell your hair on eBay. Maybe some other body parts too, if I really need the money."

Catra rolls her eyes as she hands her the scissors. "That's a great way to get caught."

"I'm not dumb enough to use my own account," Adora says obviously, "I'll use W eaver's. I can frame her and run off with the money."

"Suddenly, I'm on board with this plan," Catra jokes, and then frowns, "except the part where I'm dead and can't enjoy watching that bitch rot in prison."

Adora hums as she evens the back and the sides of Catra's hair out. It actually turns out looking really good for a bathroom job. "You look cute."

Catra is blushing again when she says that, and it makes her look even cuter. "Shut up."

Standing there in one of Adora's old t-shirts and a pair of *Adventure Time* pyjama shorts, Catra looks so small. Almost frail. The new haircut only makes her look tinier. She doesn't look like a multi-platinum recording artist who seemingly has the world at her feet. She's just a tired young girl who needs the rest she's never been allowed.

"Come on," Adora offers out a hand, "let's get you to bed."

Slowly, Catra takes her hand and lets Adora lead her down the hallway. "I like your house," she says so softly, and pushes out a quiet sigh. "I hate my house. It's too big. Too… *professional*. It doesn't look like a home. This does."

Adora pushes her bedroom door open and flicks the light on. "Hopefully *messy* can count as *home* too, because I definitely didn't tidy this when I left."

It's not really messy, but there are some socks on the floor that Adora picks up and quickly tosses in the laundry basket. Catra looks

around, pausing by the photos on Adora's wall of her, Bow and Glimmer. "Are these your friends?"

"Yeah," Adora says, remembering how she hung up on them and feeling increasingly guilty, "they're my best friends."

"I guess you're the hot one, then," Catra says, and it takes Adora so off guard that she gasps and makes a little spluttering noise. Catra turns around, and there's this small, lighthearted smirk on her face. "I'd say I'm kidding, but I'm really not."

"Shut up and get into my bed," Adora says, and then realises how that sounds, "not like that! I just mean, you know, because you want to sleep, and you're in pyjamas and you're tired and that *is* my bed, so-"

"God, you really are hopeless around girls, aren't you?" Catra laughs and clambers into Adora's bed. "That's good news for me."

"I- what?" Adora blinks, but she doesn't have time to question that, because Catra sticks a hand under the sheets and pulls out Adora's teddy bear, a stuffed unicorn she'd lovingly named Swift Wind when she was five. "That's not mine?"

"*Right,* it just came to life and decided to hang out in your bed," Catra says, and she cuddles the unicorn to her chest as she lays down, "I totally believe that."

"I mean, we've all seen *Toy Story,*" Adora says, "you never know."

"Sure," Catra says, and then she pats the pillow next to her, "come on, then. I know you're tired too. A drunk asshole woke you up at three in the morning last night."

So she does remember, Adora realises with a blush. She climbs into bed next to Catra and is far too busy thinking over the implications of that to pay any attention to anything until…

“Adora?”

Catra says it so softly that Adora wonders if she imagined it. But then warm, calloused fingers brush against Adora’s hand.

“Yeah?” Adora asks. “What’s up?”

“Can I…” Catra pauses, “can I come over there?”

Adora laughs gently and holds out her arm. “Sure.”

There’s the sound of ruffling sheets, and then Catra presses up against her. She buries her face in Adora’s shoulder like it’s the only safe place in the world. Catra curls into her, still holding Swift Wind in her arms, and she lets out a long, tired sigh.

“Thank you for today. I mean it.” Catra says into her shoulder. “Thank you for helping me.”

“You asked,” Adora says, “you needed help, and you asked for it. I wasn’t going to say no.”

Like she hadn’t spoken, Catra continues. “And thank you for seeing me. You don’t look at me and see what they want you to. I feel like with you, I can be myself. I’m not even entirely sure who *myself* is, but I feel like it’s okay for me to figure that out when I’m around you, because you don’t push me to be anything. Maybe that doesn’t make sense. I just…thank you.”

Adora squeezes her gently around the waist. “Get some rest, Catra. You need it.”

“I know,” Catra says, and if anything, she presses closer to her. “Goodnight, Adora.”

“Goodnight, Catra. Sleep well."

Chapter End Notes

listen you all know i believe in ponytail catra supremacy but short hair catra is so soft... she needed to be here

also i might be adding a chapter? i've been rereading this and editing bc fun fact i actually wrote the first draft of this before love adora so i'm pretty distanced from it and there are a few things i want to add

plus i'm away at the weekend so i might not be updating again until sunday but i might be able to push for the friday update idk yet

Saturday

Chapter Summary

catra puts her plans in action

Chapter Notes

tw in this chapter for homophobia, mentions of suicide and references to abuse

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora wakes up to her bedroom lights flicking on and off and back on again, and for a minute, she thinks that everything from yesterday was a dream. She imagines it's Weaver flicking the lights on and off, and they're going to get dragged off to the music video shoot. She imagines she never ran away with Catra, that they never got back to Etheria.

But then it's Glimmer's voice she hears. "Adora! Get the fuck up!"

Adora sits up, blinking, and a tired Catra rolls over and buries her face in the pillow. She mutters into it irritably, "Adora, make your annoying friend stop."

Glimmer laughs and flicks the lights on and off even more aggressively. "I don't care if you're famous, I'm kicking your ass just as much as I'm about to kick Adora's. Don't you know that the whole world basically thinks you're *dead*?"

Catra laughs into her pillow. "Good."

"Catra," Adora tries to say it scoldingly, but also softly, because she doesn't want to sound like Weaver. She runs her hand through Catra's hair soothingly. "I'm going to talk to my friends. You just get some more rest."

"No, no," Catra rolls over and sighs, "it's my fault they're mad at you."

"Wow, okay, she actually admitted it," Glimmer says, "I'm shocked."

Catra rolls her eyes and sits up. "Look, I'll be out of here soon, I just need to figure some stuff out. Starting with a phone call. Adora is going to be fine, I won't let anything happen to her."

"Wait in the kitchen, Glimmer, I'll be there in a moment," Adora says, and Glimmer looks like she's not going to move, but she does anyway. When she's gone, Adora looks over at Catra. "You need to make a phone call?"

"I told you that Entrapta isn't under any contract. If I can get her to go to the place we had the after-tour party, get the security footage of Weaver hitting me from the security person working there, then it's information that came from a third party. If I have that footage, I've got something on them, because I could leak it. Third party information isn't covered under the NDA. If I threaten to leak it, they might let me go."

"That's...that's the whole plan?" Adora asks, and Catra nods. "It doesn't seem very...good."

"It's the only thing I can think of that could work," Catra says, "Weaver wouldn't want anything getting out that would make her lose her nice cushy job, and the label won't let anything get out that makes them look bad. Reputations matter in the music industry."

"Okay," Adora says, "call Entrapta. You have to at least try, right?"

"Yeah," Catra nods, "I have to try. Go calm your sparkly friend down. I'm sorry for dragging you into all of this."

"You didn't," Adora says, and she doesn't know what makes her do it, but she leans forwards and kisses Catra's forehead. Then she realises what she did, blushes, and decides that apologising will only make it more awkward, so she mumbles, "I'm going to go talk to

Glimmer," and darts from the room while Catra watches after her with a surprised, but soft smile.

Adora delays the inevitable by slipping into the bathroom first. She makes sure to take her time with her usual morning routine, minus the shower, because she wouldn't put it past Glimmer to break the bathroom door down and drag her out if she heard the water turn on.

When she walks into the kitchen, Glimmer jumps up from her seat at the table. "Do you want to tell me what the *fuck* you're thinking?"

"Uh," Adora looks at Bow, but he just smiles hopelessly at her, "I'm thinking I want some breakfast."

"Oh, I know what you're thinking," Glimmer retorts, "I saw you in bed with her. You're thinking that if you do anything she asks, she'll-she'll suddenly somehow become gay and then go out with you."

"Well, she's already gay, so I can check that part off my list," Adora says as she goes to the cupboard and grabs a box of cereal. She turns to Glimmer and rolls her eyes. "I'm not doing things to get her to go out with me. I'm trying to help her. That's all. You guys weren't there, they were horrible to her. Her manager *hit* her. Don't act like you guys wouldn't do the same thing."

Glimmer's mouth snaps shut, the angry rant she probably had planned completely forgotten. "What?"

"It was bad," Adora says, "I'm not even supposed to be telling you. I couldn't make her stay there, and she was going to leave either way. It was better if I went with her, I could make sure she didn't get hurt." *Or hurt herself.*

"Okay," Bow says, "but what about the record label? What about her management? They're looking for her. *Everyone* is looking for her. Some people actually think she's in danger."

"She just needs to figure some stuff out. There's a chance she might be able to get out of her contract," Adora says, "I'm sure she'll let everyone know she's okay soon, but if they find her before she has anything on them, they'll make her go back. They'll probably make it *worse* for her. She just needs a little more time."

"Do you want me to call my mom? She's not working today," Glimmer asks, and if there's one thing Adora was expecting, it wasn't that. "If Catra has a copy of her contract, she can look it over like she's been doing with the one you sent her. That one was pretty airtight, but maybe…"

"Yeah," Adora says, "please. That might be best."

"They really…" Bow pauses, "her manager really hit her?"

"Right in front of me, and about twenty other people who were all also under NDAs," Adora feels yet another wave of intense dislike towards Weaver. "It's not just like that, either. Her manager, who also happens to be her adoptive mother, talks to her like she's nothing. They won't let her come out because it's not *marketable.* They forced her into a fake relationship, and they were going to do it again. And they won't let her make the music she wants; they just give her stuff and tell her to sing it and look happy. They don't see her as a person, just something to make money from. I don't think she's had a day off since she was seventeen."

"From a lot of my mom's lawyer talk, I think most of that counts as abuse. Illegal activity makes an NDA void, which means she could speak up about it. So could you," Glimmer says, and when Adora moves to go back to her bedroom and tell Catra exactly that, she grabs her by the hand and stops her, "okay, *I'm* not the lawyer here. It's just something I think I've picked up from hearing my mom. Maybe just… wait until she gets here and ask her before you do anything."

"Okay," Adora says, because she knows she's being rash and she doesn't want to get sued, "you're right."

"But if you think she can get out of it all," Glimmer says, "we want to help. Ill go call my mom."

Adora looks at Bow, and he nods too. "Y eah. We want to help."

"Thank you, guys," Adora pulls them both in for a group hug before Glimmer can go and call Angella, "and just a tip, dont freak out at her when she comes in here. She hates that."

Glimmer laughs as she pulls away. "How do you know? Did you?"

"She probably did," Bow laughs, "remember when we were five and we saw that guy dressed as Spongebob and she practically fainted?"

"Oh, like you wouldnt freak out if you met *Spongebob*," Adora scof fs, "It' s Spongebob."

Even though she's sitting with her best friends, laughing and joking about things, her mind keeps drifting to Catra. She glances down the hallway, but her bedroom door is closed, and she thinks that it means Catra is still on the phone.

She stays on the phone for forty-five minutes. Adora knows, because at minute forty-six, her phone buzzes with a T witter news notification.

Pop star Catra tweets following disappearance – but fans are still worried.

Adora goes to Catra's Twitter profile and sees that she's posted one new tweet, with a picture. It's a selfie in Adora's bedroom, and maybe it's stupid that she laughs at the caption.

@wildcatra: dont worry i just went to get a haircut

Adora's bedroom door opens then, and she looks up to see Catra peering out. "Hey! Is..everything okay?"

Slowly, Catra walks down the hallway to the kitchen. She casts a wary glance over at Bow and Glimmer before nodding. "Y eah. I got…

I got what I needed."

The phone in her hand rings, and Catra looks a little sick when she looks at the screen. Adora makes an educated guess. "Weaver?"

"Yeah, she keeps calling," Catra nods, "I should answer. They'll probably figure out where I tweeted from and come anyway."

Adora stares down at the ringing phone, and when she gets an idea, a quick google search confirms that it's something they can do. In their state, phone calls only require the consent of one party to be recorded.

Adora takes Catra's phone and glances at Glimmer and Bow. She places the device on the table and says, "one of you, get your phone out and record this, and then answer the call. You're a third party, right? And we know she's going to say something horrible."…

Bow pulls his phone out of his pocket to record, and Glimmer picks Catra's phone up from the table. Adora grabs Catra by the wrist and pulls her out of the room, shutting the door behind them. "Where are we going?"

"I don't know if it makes it like, *void* or something if we're involved," Adora says, "I just figured we need as much evidence of her being horrible as possible, right?"

Catra looks at her in awe again, and Adora barely has time to take the look in before Catra is cupping her jaw and pulling her in for a kiss.

Adora had imagined that Catra would be a good kisser. Not that she's thought about kissing Catra –okay, she has, but whatever – but she's so good at it. Her lips are so soft and fit with Adora's like they're supposed to be there, and she tastes minty like Adora's toothpaste. It's like she knows the perfect way to make the butterflies in Adora's stomach go crazy, but they die a death when Catra

deepens the kiss and Adora realises that they shouldn't be doing this.

Maybe she's making the biggest mistake of her life, but Adora reaches forwards and gently pushes Catra away. "Catra, we can't."

Catra stares at her, and it's not hard to tell that she's hurt. Her shoulders sag disappointedly, but she nods and steps back anyway. "That's fine. I get it."

"I don't think you do," Adora says. She reaches out and runs her hand through short, messy hair. The motion seems like it soothes Catra, even though she still looks upset. "I *really* want to. I want to kiss you, to hold your hand, to take you out on dates and one day give you all the love you deserve."

Catra looks away anxiously. "Why won't you, then?"

"Because you're not in a place for that," Adora says, "you need to take care of yourself right now. You don't know what you want, and you're going through a really stressful time right now. You can't add a relationship on top of that and that's okay. When you're ready for it, if you still want me, you know where to find me."

Catra stares at her, and for a moment, Adora thinks she's going to argue. But then she just groans and leans back against the opposite wall. "I hate that you're right."

Adora laughs. "I'm surprised you accepted it so easily."

"I really like you, Adora," Catra says, and Adora's stomach twists. All she wants to do is press forwards and kiss her, but she knows it isn't fair to Catra right now. "I don't want to jump into something with you, screw it all up because I'm so messy and have you end up hating me. You're right. We need to wait."

"Aw," Adora teases her, "you've got a little crush on me, huh?"

"Shut up or Ill take it all back," Catra grumbles. "You're an asshole."

"Still doesnt change the fact that you have a crush on me," Adora nudges her lightly, "but it's okay. I have a crush on you too."

Catra looks at her for a few moments, and her gaze inevitably slips down to look at Adora's lips. "You know...if we were to kiss right now...that doesnt mean we're in a relationship. We could just be two friends helping each other out. And we dont have to worry about one of us developing feelings, because both of us already have. It's like the perfect situation, and like you said, Im stressed. Kissing is a good way to *de*stress."

Adora raises her eyebrows. "So...you're saying that two friends who like each other should make out? You really think that's a good idea?"

"Yeah," Catra says, a playful smirk on her face that's so hard to deny. "It's like the best idea. Just...two women helping each other. Are you not a feminist, Adora?"

"Im very much a feminist, but..." at the last word, Catra groans, "It's a bad idea. You know it is. It wouldnt be fair of me to do that."

"Ugh, why do you have to be the *one* person who wont take advantage of me?" Catra rolls her eyes. "Fine. You're right."

Adora cant respond with anything other than a smile, because the kitchen door swings open and Bow holds Catra's phone out. It's not on a call to Weaver, and he grimaces. "She seems… *lovely*."

Adora's phone buzzes with a text, and Glimmer comes to stand next to Bow in the doorway. "I sent you the recording," then she looks at Catra, "I wouldnt listen to it if I were you. She said a lot of things that- they werent exactly nice."

"Probably nothing Ive never heard before," Catra shrugs passively, "she's never been particularly *nice* to me."

Adora reaches out and silently takes Catra's hand at the words. Just to let her know that she's there for her.

"My mom says she's on her way," Glimmer tells Adora, and then looks over at Catra again and explains, "she's a lawyer, so I thought it might help."

"Yeah, actually. Thanks," Catra says, "because I think Weaver will be on her way here and I should probably go over things with someone who knows what they're talking about. I need to figure out what I want from them other than them just letting me go."

When Angella arrives ten minutes later, Catra goes into the lounge with her on her own, along with Adora's laptop, which she'd logged into her business email with to download the electronic copy of her recording contract, as well as the NDA.

Adora is nervous, knowing that Weaver is on the way. She's also nervous because she doubts the record label will let her go, even with the threat of the video and the recording. Weaver doesn't seem like she's so easily scared, but she guesses that Catra knows her better than Adora does.

She waits anxiously in the kitchen with Bow and Glimmer, while Razz potters around, oblivious to the goings-on in her house. After a while, Catra comes out of the lounge and sits down next to her, flashing her a nervous smile that doesn't make Adora any less anxious.

Angella takes Bow and Glimmer home, and Adora watches as they walk out of the door with a frown. "Don't you need a lawyer with you when you talk to Weaver?"

"I'm going to record the conversation," Catra says, "it's just a negotiation. If she agrees to let me go, she'll draw up a termination agreement, and I can call my entertainment lawyer back in L.A. to go through it and tell me if there's anything shady in it before I sign anything. Something that I should've done when I was eighteen."

Adora reaches out to put a hand on top of Catra's in an attempt to comfort her but pauses before she does it. She thinks about their kiss earlier and isn't sure if it would count as *too* romantically coded, because she doesn't want to take advantage of Catra when she's not in a good place.

When she looks up, Catra is looking at her, eyebrow raised in a quiet amusement. She grabs Adora's hand and rolls her eyes, and then acts like she'd never seen Adora's hesitation. "So, what do you want to do to kill time before the evil bitch shows up?"

Adora laughs at how blunt she is. "I don't know. But I think you need something to eat because you haven't yet, so-"

Almost like the sentence had summoned her, Razz shuffles into the kitchen and immediately walks over to the fridge. She stares into it for a moment, and then inspiration strikes, because she turns to Catra and says, "You. Do you like omelettes?"

"Uh, yeah," Catra says, "but you don't have to-"

Razz has already cracked the eggs into a bowl to whisk. "I'll make you an omelette."

"Don't even try to argue," Adora quickly says when Catra opens her mouth to do just that, "the kitchen is her territory. Nobody else gets to cook unless she's out at bingo."

Razz cooks the omelette, puts the plate in front of Catra at the table, and then shuffles off into the lounge to watch TV.

Catra watches after her until she's out of the kitchen, and then turns to Adora with a frown. "I don't want to be like, an asshole or anything, but she doesn't seem like she needs you here to look after her. So... why exactly are you taking time out of college?"

"She had a minor stroke last year," Adora says, looking towards the hallway in the direction Razz had disappeared in. "She bounced

back from it really well, but that's just because it happened when I was with her so I could get her to the hospital right away. If it happened on one of the weekends I stayed at school, I don't. I don't think she'd be as able as she is now. I just don't want to risk anything and it's not like I can afford to hire someone to take care of her. But it's okay. I don't mind."

Catra hums, and once she's eaten her bite of omelette, she speaks. "Why do you put everyone else over yourself?"

Adora blinks. "What?"

"I'm not saying it's a terrible thing—most of the time it's good to help other people, but not when it's going to have a negative impact on your life," Catra says, and before Adora can deny it, she keeps going, "You're putting your life on hold because your grandma *might* get sick. You helped me even though there's like, a giant chance that a corporation will sue you out of everything for it. It's like you don't think you're worth anything except the things you can do for other people."

Adora's mouth works, grappling to find words, but Catra has left her completely speechless. And then she goes back to eating her omelette like she'd never spoken at all, and finally, Adora manages a sigh.

"My mom always taught me that I should help other people when I could," Adora admits quietly, "I just want to make her proud."

"She would be," Catra says it like she knows, and in a way, Adora thinks she does, "but just chill out with it, okay? Maybe don't do anything that could get you sued."

It's said like a joke, but Adora doesn't laugh. That was different, she justifies. Because there's a part of her that wonders if she'd stopped Catra from leaving, if she'd turn on the news one day in the future and find out that Catra had hurt herself because she couldn't take it

anymore. She said it herself. *I think if I stay… I think it'll kill me. If Weaver doesn't do it first, I think I'm going to end up hurting myself.*

But she doesn't say it. Adora just sighs and watches as Catra finishes off her omelette, knowing deep down that she's right.

Maybe Catra isn't the only one who needs to work on things.

Adora's mind is even heavier with that addition, but it all disappears in an instant when the doorbell rings and she and Catra both realise who it's going to be at the front door. Catra pales slightly but sucks in a deep breath and stands up to answer it.

Adora follows her to the front door but hangs back as Catra opens it. Weaver is there, alone, talking into a cell phone and loudly assuring someone on Sea Hawk's PR team that she'll have Catra back in LA by the end of the day to sign the contract detailing their publicity stunt relationship.

Weaver hangs up the phone and her gaze lands on Catra. The blatant anger already on her face sours deeper into disapproval.

"What in the world have you done to your hair?" Weaver scoffs, looking Catra over with those cold green eyes. "Like we don't already have to try hard enough to make people think you're straight. No matter, we'll get you some nice professional extensions."

"No, you won't," Catra says, "I'm not going with you. Come in. We have a lot to talk about."

Catra turns and walks back towards the kitchen. Even if her confidence is feigned, it's believable. Weaver has no choice but to follow her, muttering to herself about an 'ungrateful brat' and how Catra is lucky there are people here to witness.

The last part makes Adora's usually mild temper flare, and she doesn't even think about it when she sits beside Catra at the kitchen table, in the perfect position to shield her from Weaver if needed.

"I feel like I should tell you that this conversation is being recorded for my personal use," Catra says, "not that it matters to you because you'll say whatever you want."

"Enough of this silliness. You are lucky that I am doing this civilly." Weaver rolls her eyes. She hasn't sat down, and instead stands by the door, looking down on the both of them. "You have breached your contract, Catrina. If you continue to hide away like the coward you are, Horde Records will pursue legal action. You're going to come with me and we're going to go back to LA. You have a PR contract to sign. We will release a statement saying that you've had a... mental break, and perhaps a stay in a nice facility will do you some good."

"I meant it when I said I'm not going with you," Catra says calmly, "I'm done. I'm not going back, I'm not going to play pretend with Sea Hawk, and I'm not going to let you treat me like your little singing money-maker anymore."

Weaver blinks at her like she can't believe the words. She probably can't. But then her expression morphs into that horrible smug smile. "You don't have that option. Unless you want Horde Records to sue you?"

"You won't be suing anybody," Catra says, and Adora admires just how calm she looks as she picks up the laptop from the other side of the table. She opens it up and types something in, and then turns the screen to face Weaver and presses play on the security footage she'd received from Entrapta. "Not unless you want me to post this, anyway."

Adora watches as Weaver's expression turns from smug to... not guilt, but almost like she's ashamed she let herself get caught. Like a predator that just missed out on catching its prey.

She soon composes herself. "You are under a non-disclosure agreement, as well as your main contract. You can't share any confidential information. If you leak that video, we will sue you. If you

do not come with me and fulfil the duties you are supposed to fulfil, we will class it as you knowingly breaching your contract, and we will sue you. It's not a legal battle you can win, Catrina. Be sensible now and come along."

"I received this footage, as well as a recording of you being verbally abusive towards me, from a third party," Catra says coldly, "If I've got my facts right – which I'm pretty sure my lawyer and I do – then that doesn't fall under confidential information. Oh, and did you know that an NDA doesn't prevent you from disclosing illegal activity? I think physical assault is pretty illegal. I'm well within my rights to post the video, the recording, and a statement detailing everything you did to me. So... do you want to lose everything and get your company exposed for abusing their artists, or are you going to listen to what I have to say?"

Weaver clearly knows she's trapped, because she nods stiffly and mutters, "Fine. Insolent little brat."

"You're going to terminate my contract now through mutual agreement," Catra says, blatantly ignoring Weaver's insult, "you're going to give me the rights to my music, and I'll be free to come out publicly. Any relationship between myself and your company will be ended. Or I will leak the recordings and you'll have to deal with the public backlash. And I think the video proof of you hitting me and then illegally threatening your witnesses will hold up well in court and give them reason to help me terminate my contract, so it's best you just do as I ask now rather than later after all of those hefty legal fees. I don't think the label would like losing so much money."

"I knew you were a bad apple, but I never thought you'd resort to blackmailing your own mother," Weaver says, "after everything I have done for you-"

"First, you're not my fucking mother," Catra snaps, "and second, all you did was take the one thing I actually loved and turn it into your little money-making machine. You wanted nothing to do with me until you saw how much money you could squeeze out of me. I'm done

with you. You and the label will terminate my contract, youll sign the rights to my music over to me, and then I never want to see you again."

Weaver scoffs. "You dont even like your music."

"I dont care. It's my name on those albums, and my voice singing those songs." Catra says, "It's mine. Im not going to let you make another fucking penny off of me."

"Fine," Weaver stares across the table at Catra, and Adora has never seen a person look at someone with more hate. "We will draw up a termination agreement and you will be allowed to *purchase* the rights to your music. You will be expected to move out of the house Horde Records have so graciously allowed you to live in at a reduced rate for the last three years. You will be featured on the collaboration with Sea Hawk, but you will receive none of the revenue from that song and what would have been your percentage will go to the label as *compensation.* All of the songs from your fourth album will be scrapped, and you will pay the label for the studio time you wasted recording those songs. You will not release your little video, and you will not say a bad word about Horde Records or myself to the media. As far as they need to know, you have been dropped due to creative differences."

"Whatever," Catra says, "get out, make your little contract, and Ill read it over with my lawyer."

Weaver stands up and her expensive heels click across the kitchen floor to the door. She pauses on her way out. "You are making the biggest mistake of your life, Catrina. Nobody will listen to your angry rock music, certainly not when you go public with your little perversion."

"I dont care," Catra says, "at least Ill be happy."

Weaver sends her one more hateful glance before walking out of the door.

Catra doesn't look like she breathes until the front door slams and there's the sound of a car driving away outside. When she finally does, she stops the recording on her phone and her whole body seems to relax

She slumps back in her chair and meets Adora's gaze. "I know I'm not out of it yet. But she agreed to it. They're going to let me go."

Adora pauses but hugs Catra anyway. "You're free."

Catra buries her face into Adora's shoulder. Her voice is muffled when she replies, "the first thing I'm going to do after I sign that termination agreement is come out. I get to come out."

"What about" Adora hesitates, but she figures it's okay to ask, "she said you're not allowed to speak up about everything they did. Don't you want to?"

"Of course I want to," Catra says as she pulls back, "obviously I want to see them exposed for everything they did. But it's a small price to pay for everything else. I can keep quiet if it means I get to leave."

"Well" Adora bites down on her bottom lip and says, "Angella said that illegal activity makes the NDA void. I signed an NDA, and I saw Weaver hit you. Maybe you can't tell people, but I could. And I know that Scorpia and Entrapta would speak out for you too."

"I couldn't ask you to do that," Catra reaches out and takes Adora's hand again, "seriously , you've done enough."

"I want to," Adora says, "they deserve to face the consequences. Even if that's just public backlash. People should know ."

Catra flashes a small, weak smile, and Adora reaches over to pull her in for another hug. She clearly needs one. Carefully, Catra wraps her arms around Adora's waist and snuggles her face into her shoulder. "You know, maybe you should think twice about waiting

until Im all happy-go-lucky to date me. All the girls are going to want to get with me when I come out. Youll have a lot of competition."

Adora laughs. "Im not worried. Ive got the advantage of being the girl you actually have a crush on."

Catra pulls away with a soft smile. "You cant prove that."

"I think I can," Adora retorts, and the light blush tinting freckled cheeks pink is enough to confirm that for her. "So. I know it's probably the last thing on your mind right now, but... what do you want to do with your music?"

"Im never signing with another fucking label, I know that much," Catra says, and looks a little anxious, like everything just came back to her. "I wish I brought my guitar with me. Talking to Weaver never does good things for my mood but messing around on my guitar is kind of a stress relief. That's probably why she stopped me from playing it on stage as much, because she hates anything that makes me happy."

"Ive got a guitar. I was going to learn but never got around to it," Adora says, and Catra sits up like a dog that's just been told they get to go for a walk. "Whoa. Contain your excitement."

"You have a guitar," Catra repeats, "can I play it?"

"Sure," Adora says, getting up from her chair. Catra jumps up with a renewed energy. "It's probably shitty, though. I got it at a garage sale for like seventy dollars. And I dont have an amp or anything."

"I dont care," Catra says, even though she plays guitars that cost at least four thousand dollars at every show, "Ill play anything. My first one was an old Squier Strat that I got for like fifty dollars from some kid at school who didnt want it anymore. I mowed so many lawns for that guitar."

Adora has no idea what a Squier Strat is, but she asks, "do you still have it?" as she heads towards her bedroom.

"Yeah, it's on the wall in my bedroom in LA," Catra pauses and corrects herself, "soon to be old bedroom. Weaver was pissed when I bought it. She didn't want me to get a guitar because she didn't want me bothering her more than I already did'. Fucking bitch soon changed her tune when she saw she could profit off of me."

Adora pulls the guitar case out of her closet as Catra sits down on her unmade bed. "You'll never have to see her again soon."

"That's a relief," Catra says as Adora passes her the guitar case. She unzips it and pauses in surprise. "Wait. You said you got this for *seventy* dollars?"

"Yeah," Adora shrugs, "it was just from this garage sale. I actually got it because it reminded me of the one you always play. You know, with the birds on the neck."

"You got a fucking PRS at a garage sale for *seventy dollars*?" Catra stares at her in shock and then pulls the guitar out. She strums the strings and cringes when she hears how out of tune they are. "Why the fuck didn't that happen to fourteen-year-old me? I would've *killed* for a PRS back then. Like, *literally* killed. Probably Weaver."

"You're basically speaking another language right now," Adora says, watching as Catra tunes the guitar by ear, "so it's a good guitar, then?"

"Uh, *yeah*," Catra says like it's obvious, as she plays a few chords and then adjusts a couple of the strings again, "I mean, it's an SE, so it's not like the top of their range like my private stock one, but still pretty fucking good. Seventy fucking dollars. Whoever sold this had *no* idea what they had, and you clearly had no idea what you were buying, either."

"Keep it, if you want," Adora shrugs. She doesn't know anything about guitars, but she does know that this is probably the most enthusiastic she's ever seen Catra, so she keeps talking to her about it, "I'll never learn. I tried to do a couple chords and it was too complicated for me."

"No way," Catra rolls her eyes and plays a quick solo, "any old idiot can learn. Even you."

"Wow, thanks," Adora laughs, "really fills me with confidence."

"You know what I mean," Catra says, plucking at the strings, "these strings need changing, but I'll do that for you. I'll teach you some stuff, if you want."

Adora raises her eyebrows. "You say that like you're going to be sticking around."

"Yeah, well," Catra shrugs, looking up from the guitar to meet Adora's gaze, "it's quiet in Etheria. I think I need that. I'm going to get my stuff moved out of the LA house and buy a place here. Etheria… it's my home."

"Well," Adora reaches out and takes Catra's hand, giving it a gentle squeeze, "you're welcome to stay with me and Razz for as long as you want. I know we don't have a guest room so you'll have to deal with sharing a bed with me, but…something tells me you're okay with that."

"I don't know what you're talking about," Catra says, but when she meets Adora's gaze, her eyes soften in that wonderful way, "thank you, though. For the offer. You know"…

Catra trails off, and Adora raises her eyebrows. "What?"

"You should go back to school," Catra says, "you should finish your degree."

"What?" Adora frowns. When the words sink in, she shakes her head. "I can't. I have to look after Razz."

"I'll stay," Catra says, and Adora frowns even more, "I'll look after her."

"What?" Adora says but laughs when she realises it's an obvious joke. "You're kidding."

"I'm really not," Catra answers. She flashes Adora that soft, quiet smile. "Once I sign that termination agreement, I've literally got an open schedule. And I think I might start making YouTube covers again, which I can do anywhere. You should go back to school, and I'll stay here and keep an eye on Razz. She seems like good company, anyway."

"You can't do that," Adora says, "and anyway, I have to work, I have Razz's medical bills to pay off-"

"I've got that," Catra says, and Adora gapes at her, "don't even try to tell me no. If it weren't for you helping me-" Catra pauses, and when she looks at Adora, she sees how serious she is. "I think you saved my life, Adora. So you're going to let me help you out."

"Catra," Adora shakes her head, "I can't ask you to do that, and I didn't help you because I wanted you to owe me one-"

"You said I could stay here until I get a house and everything," Catra points out, "so I'd be here anyway. Go back to school."

"You're not just doing this because you have feelings for me, are you?"

Adora doesn't know where the question came from, but she had to ask. Catra looks a little bit taken aback, and then she looks slightly offended. She rolls her eyes and scoffs. "Please. I'm not that desperate."

"I didn't mean it like that," Adora says quietly, "I just... I don't want to take advantage of you when you're vulnerable."

"I get that, it's fine, whatever," Catra waves that away, "just tell me you'll consider going back to school. I'm going to be here either way."

"I'll think about it," Adora says, and she thinks she's telling the truth, "thank you for offering."

"You saved me," Catra shrugs casually, like she'd just said something as mundane as 'you bought me a cupcake', "if there's something I can do for you, I'm going to do it. Not because I like you."

Adora hums. "You *do* like me, though."

"Again, I don't know what you're talking about," Catra says, but when she meets Adora's gaze, she smiles that soft smile that makes Adora's heart skip. "But I guess you're okay. In a general complimentary sense."

"Right," Adora laughs, "sure. Just generally."

Catra looks at her for a moment, then laughs quietly to herself and flops back on Adora's bed, guitar laid out across her stomach. "It's kind of scary when I think about what could've happened if someone else won that contest. Do you believe in fate?"

"Sometimes I do," Adora says, "it's one of those things where we'll probably never know if it's real or not."

"Maybe it was fate, that you won that contest," Catra says, "or maybe it was some big cosmic coincidence. I don't know. I just know that I'm lucky it worked out that way, because if it hadn't, I'd currently be signing two years of my life away for a PR contract."

"The first time they made you do it..." Adora pauses, because she doesn't want to bring up bad memories, but Catra looks at her

expectantly and waits for her to ask. "Did you know you were gay then?"

"I've always known," Catra says quietly, "I wasn't entirely comfortable with it until I was like eighteen, but by that point, it was too late. I'd already signed my soul away to the devil, and when I told Weaver, she said I wasn't allowed to come out because they wanted to present my image in a *certain way.* There's a lot of homophobia in the music industry, and a lot more closeted people than you'd think. That's why they stick you in 'mutually beneficial' relationships. The first one with Double T trouble was because we were both closeted. They're queer and non-binary, and that's not *marketable* either."

Adora laughs bitterly. "That's so fucked up."

"Yeah," Catra sighs, "it is," she pauses, laughs in a weirdly genuine way, and strums a random chord on the guitar. "God, you don't know how fucking happy I'll be when I don't ever have to sing *he* again. Or any of those fucking generic songs. I swear, if I have to sing *Wildcat* one more time, I'll rip my own vocal cords out."

"Please don't," Adora says even though she knows she's joking, "you have a pretty voice. And I want to hear it singing the songs you want to make, if you decide to make them."

"I'm going to," Catra says, strumming another chord, "I want to make music, just...independently. On my terms. Fuck a record label."

"Yeah," Adora agrees, reaching out to take Catra's hand. "Fuck a record label."

When Catra squeezes her hand, Adora smiles. She might not be okay right now, but she's going to be.

And for now, that's enough.

Chapter End Notes

1) yes i added another chapter even though the 'storyline' is kinda resolved in this chapter but i decided i wanted a catra pov chapter instead of having this story entirely from adora's perspective plus you gotta get your catradora goodness

2) i'm not a lawyer nor have i ever studied law so if anything this inaccurate here... shhhhh this is fanfiction i can say 2+2~~5~~ in this universe and that makes it true

3) i love prs guitars can you tell?

4) free britney!i mentioned on my tumblr that her situation + a lot of the stuff fifth harmony went through inspired this fic (legit look up that leaked audio of my baby lauren saying that they were treated like slaves and their label always tried to fuck them over)

5) i was never not gonna give catra a happy ending... she is my child and yes maybe i'll make her suffer for a little while but she'll always get a happy ending in my fics

Sunday

Chapter Summary

a look inside catra's head

Chapter Notes

tw for emotional abuse, referenced suicidal thoughts, referenced substance abuse and referenced physical abuse

When her eyes open, her heart is beating fast.

It's because of the dream she was having. She knows that much. She can just grasp the tail end of the dream, where Weaver turned and walked out of the door, and Adora, beautiful Adora, tells her that she's free.

But then Catra sits up, and realises it wasn't a dream at all.

Adora is lying in bed next to her. She's sprawled out asleep, an arm thrown over Catra's waist protectively, her hair splayed out behind her like a golden halo. It's a fitting comparison – Catra thinks she's some kind of angel.

Maybe a guardian angel.

Carefully, so she doesn't wake her, Catra lies back down and shuffles closer to her. Adora is so warm, and Catra curls into her, snuggling her face into Adora's shoulder. These last three nights sharing a bed with her, Catra has slept better than she ever has in her entire life.

Catra has always had trouble sleeping. Even before everything with her career got so bad. As a teenager, she'd be up tossing and turning all night. Most of the time she'd use the middle of the night to learn a new song on guitar, or just practice some scales with a

metronome. In the last few years, she'd turned to drinking. Alcohol put her to sleep, and it helped her forget.

That's one thing that she's going to cut out completely. She's seen too many 'celebrities' fall into substance abuse. She understands why, and she doesn't want it to happen to her . Catra wants to be happy. And once she signs that termination agreement, she'll finally have the chance to be.

Slowly, Catra reaches over and grabs her phone from where she'd left it charging on Adora's bedside table. When the screen wakes up, she cringes a little at the bright light. Her gaze focuses on the time on the screen. 11AM. She can't remember the last time she ever slept in past eight. And eight was a *good* day.

She unlocks her phone and goes to her emails. She's not surprised when she sees that a Horde Records representative has already send the termination agreement in full. She knew that Weaver would want to work as quickly as possible. God forbid people find out she's a horrible person.

She forwards the email to the entertainment lawyer she knows in L.A, and decides she'll wait until she's read it to look through herself. Adora shifts in her sleep and lets out this adorable little snore, and Catra finds herself smiling despite everything.

It feels easy, to smile around Adora. Like she told her – she feels like it's okay to just *be* with her. Catra doesn't have to put on any kind of act, and Adora doesn't expect her to. Adora doesn't expect anything from her except for her to be herself, and Catra thinks that's what draws her in.

She's never met anybody like Adora. As sad as it is, Adora is the only person who has ever treated her like a normal person. Even before all of the fame stuff, Weaver was still an asshole, and the kids at the private school she went to were all stuck up bitches who wanted nothing to do with her until her YouTube covers went viral. It was kind of hilarious to her, back then, how people who made fun of

her for posting those covers were suddenly clamouring to be her friend.

It made her so cynical. She knows that. Catra mistrusts every new person, because everyone has always wanted *something* from her. Fame, usually. Some kind of shoutout, or a collaboration, or whatever. Sometimes they want money. Other times it's more innocent stuff, like a photograph or a hug, but they only want that because they put her on some pedestal just because she can sing.

If there were some magical button that she could push to make everyone except the people who matter forget her, the only people on the planet who would still be aware she exists would be Adora, Scorpia, and Entrapta.

Catra would press that button in a heartbeat.

Adora shifts again, and her fingers flex against Catra's waist. Catra knows she could have a house bought and be out of Adora's hair by tomorrow, but she really doesn't want to. She loves this, and maybe it's a little bit selfish, but she'd like to keep sleeping this well for as long as she can. And she just wants to spend time with Adora.

It's a little crazy to her, how her opinion of that stupid contest had changed over the week. When Weaver first told her about it, Catra had opposed.

"I don't want to do it," Catra had said, like saying that ever mattered, "I don't want some fucking fangirl following me around all week. It's bad enough that you make me pretend for the cameras. I'm not playing pretend in my own home."

"You'll do exactly as you are told," Weaver had pushed her harshly against the kitchen counter, "or you will face the consequences."

So the contest went ahead, and Catra vowed to be as uncooperative as possible just to spite Weaver. She wouldn't play the part they

forced on her when there were no cameras. She wasn't going to let them take the tiny piece of freedom she still had left.

She never could've imagined that something she considered an inconvenience would save her life.

Because it had. If Weaver's stupid contest had never gone ahead, and Adora hadn't applied and won, Catra wouldn't be getting ready to sign a termination agreement to the contract that ruined her life. Instead, she'd be signing two years of her life away to a PR relationship, and in her gut, Catra knows that she wouldn't have made it. She'd been getting dangerously close to doing something stupid.

It felt like there was no way out. Like she'd been locked in a tight little cage since the day she signed her recording contract. Nobody cared—the label wanted to squeeze as much money out of her as possible, and a post-humous album would have done excellently in the charts. It didn't matter to them if she lived or died, as long as she was making them money.

The only revenge she ever got was acting out. Little acts of defiance like in that radio interview where she hadn't answered the question the way Weaver told her to. It's overwhelming to know that she won't have to lie anymore. Once she terminates her contract, she can come out. She can be open about who she is.

Whoever that is, beyond the few things she actually knows. She's never had chance to figure that out. But she doesn't want to be the happy-go-lucky girl-next-door they always tried to paint her out to be. She also doesn't want to be the person she' s been since she was eighteen, so sad and angry at the world for being the way it is.

Catra just wants to be happy. With people who care about her, and one day, maybe with Adora.

Adora lets out that quiet snore again and snuggles into the pillow in her sleep. Catra smiles, and maybe it's wrong of her, but she

reaches out and brushes blonde hair back from Adora's face. In her sleep, Adora leans into the touch, and Catra's stomach twists with butterflies.

She hasn't felt like this in years. Something as simple as a crush. She's been focusing everything on hanging onto sanity by her fingertips, that she didn't think she'd ever be able to feel anything again. She'd lost the last shreds of happiness when her ex had broken up with her, leaving her alone to deal with all of the stress and pain as her career was only growing and more and more people expected that perfect celebrity she was forced to be.

That was when the alcohol had come into play. Drinking made her numb. But Catra doesn't want to be numb anymore. Even if her feelings for Adora end up unrequited, at least she's feeling something.

Because she's *allowed* to, now. Catra keeps remembering that, and there's this weird feeling in her chest. Like something is fizzing there, bubbling up at the thought, lighter than air. She thinks it's happiness. It's been so long since she last felt it.

She doesn't have to go back. She never has to play the part they forced on her, ever again. She doesn't have to pretend she's something she's not. It almost feels too good to be true. She almost expects Adora to turn out to be some label plant there to paint her out as some crazy person who had a breakdown and ran away, so that Weaver can take even more of her control.

The thought makes a chill run down her spine, and slowly, Catra sits up, distancing herself from the sleeping blonde. She knows it's not true. Rationally, she knows it. But she wouldn't put it past Weaver and she hates that this feels so fake. Not Adora—Adora has never felt anything less than genuine. Just the whole situation. The label are letting her go, and she never thought that would happen. Never in a million years, not when she makes them so much money.

She decides she needs some air, so she takes Adora's guitar from where she'd left it yesterday and slips out of the bedroom. She walks slowly down the hallway, careful not to alert Adora's grandmother to her presence. Catra just needs quiet for a while, time to process things. Maybe it'll sink in soon; she just needs to let it.

She slips out onto the front porch and sits right there on the step, focusing on tuning the guitar and getting some fresh air. She plays through anything that comes into her head, whether it be something she's making up or an old song that she'd learned. She goes nowhere near her own discography.

Catra is fingerpicking a few chords that work together when the front door opens. She stops playing in surprise. Catra expects Adora, but when she turns around, it's her grandmother.

Razz shuffles out onto the porch with a watering can in hand and starts watering her hanging baskets. "Don't stop on my account, dearie. You're very good at that."

"Oh," Catra answers, because she's never known what to say when people compliment her other than a meagre *thanks*, "thank you."

"You should consider pursuing it," Razz says, and Catra isn't sure if that's a joke or if she genuinely doesn't know. She assumes it's probably the latter. "Though, maybe not. Famous musicians can have it rough in some ways. I still remember Beatlemania. Things got so bad for them with the fans that they stopped touring. It must be hard, when everywhere you go, everybody knows you and wants something from you."

"Tell me about it," Catra mutters, picking a couple of notes, "but I'd take rabid fans over an evil record label any day. At least the fans are doing it because they kind of care about you in their own way."

"I can't say I know much about record labels," Razz answers, leaning down to water a potted plant by the door, "I don't see why they still exist, though. You kids have your technology. You can do more with

a little phone than most full Hollywood studios could back in my day. Maybe you should do something like that. Sing a song and post it on whatever website is hip now. Adora talked about some singer girl she likes, who used to do that."

"Yeah, I think I know who you're talking about," Catra stifles a quiet laugh, "maybe I will."

Razz starts shuffling back towards the door, but she pauses on her way inside. "Whatever is troubling you, dearie, just remember to always keep your chin up. Hard times happen to everyone. It's how you respond to it that matters."

Catra watches after her as she goes inside and lets out a soft, quiet sigh. Hard times. That's one way to put it. But she's already better off than she was a week ago. A week ago, there was no end in sight. But now...freedom is within her grasp. She needs to figure out what she wants after that.

"Hey," Adora steps out onto the porch, leaning against the door frame, "you know, when I woke up and you weren't there, I kinda figured I just made the whole thing up."

"I felt like that when I woke up, too," Catra says, and Adora drops down to sit next to her on the step. She looks so pretty, even when she's half-asleep and there with her bedhead. "I forwarded the termination agreement to my lawyer."

Adora hums in reply, and when a hand rests on Catra's knee, she jumps on instinct. She's not used to physical touch; growing up, the only time anybody ever touched her was when Weaver was smacking her for something.

"Sorry," Adora says, and she moves her hand away. Catra takes her by the wrist and moves it back. Adora stares down at it for a moment before shuffling a little bit closer. "How do you feel?"

"Weird," Catra says, and she supposes that she should talk about her feelings honestly. At least with Adora, she feels comfortable enough to do so. "Part of me doesn't believe it's really happening. I spent so long feeling like I'd never get out that it doesn't feel real now it's actually happening. But another part of me... I think I feel happy for the first time in years."

Slowly, an arm wraps around her waist, and Catra sighs, resting her head on Adora's shoulder. She's so calming – like Adora knows exactly what to do to make her feel better.

"Are you definitely going to stay in Etheria?" Adora asks quietly. "Like... you know, for a while?"

"Yeah," Catra says, because LA sucked the life out of her. Even though she doesn't look at Etheria fondly by any means, after all of those miserable years with Weaver, it's still her home. Maybe she can finally make it feel like that. "I don't want to go back to LA, anyway."

"Well... if I'm going to go back to school," Adora says, and Catra is genuinely happy she's considering it, "the semester doesn't start until September. We could... hang out. Over summer."

Catra raises her eyebrows. "Hang out?"

"Not like that," Adora says quickly, and there's that disappointed dip in Catra's stomach, "well... a little like that. I don't think you're ready for a relationship. But that doesn't mean we can't get to know each other properly. Sort of like... relationship prep."

"Relationship prep?" Catra repeats, and she can't help the laugh that rises. "You're such a weirdo."

Adora rolls her eyes. "I'm just... I- I just want you to know that I'm not saying no because I don't like you. You have no idea how much I want to lean over and kiss you right now, but you... you need to

figure out you. I just want to help you figure that out. And when we're both ready, and if you still want to, then...you know."

Catra hums. She could be serious right now, but instead, she just smiles. "I don't think I do know. You'll have to be a little more specific."

Adora groans. "If you still want to be with me once you've figured out what you want, then I'd really like that."

"Yeah," Catra says, and this time she *is* serious. She leans into Adora's touch and admits, "I'm pretty confident that I'm still going to want to be with you. You pull me in. Just by being yourself, you make me feel safe to be myself too. I don't feel like I've only known you for a week. I feel like I've known you for years."

"I mean, *technically*," Adora says, and Catra laughs, remembering seven-year-old Adora pining her in the sandbox. "I get what you mean, though."

"I don't think you do," Catra replies, "I've never been like this with anybody. When I meet new people—it always takes me too long to relax, because I figure they always want something from me. Most of the time it's true, so that just makes it worse. But for the rare few that don't, it drives them away because I'm so closed off. But I knew you for two days and opened up to you about everything. You might think I'm crazy, or just some hopeless romantic, but it feels like my soul knows yours, you know?"

Adora stares at her, bright blue eyes shining with something. Something soft and light and happy. Catra thinks it's that something that makes Adora push forwards and pull her in for a kiss. A gentle hand rests at the nape of Catra's neck as Adora kisses her, and when she snaps out of her surprise, Catra kisses back softly, one hand holding the guitar tight on her lap, and the other cupping Adora's jaw.

"Sorry ," Adora mumbles as she realises herself and pulls away . Catra rolls her eyes, because if there's one thing Adora never has to apologise to her for, it's kissing her. "I shouldn't have- it' s just, the things you said"…

"Pulled you in with my romantic wiles, huh?" Catra laughs. "It' s okay. You don't ever need to apologise for kissing me. It' s- I mean, you're really good at it, so"…

"Y ou know.when you said that stuf f about wanting a little house and a girlfriend and a cat?" Adora asks, and Catra nods. "I have an idea. Are you up for a little trip?"

"Y eah, I guess so," Catra says, and Adora flashes a soft smile as she gets up. She offers out a hand, and Catra reaches out and takes it. "What do you have in mind?"

"It' s a surprise," Adora answers, leading Catra inside. She takes her back to her bedroom, and Catra leaves the guitar propped up in the corner of the room as Adora goes through her drawers, "you'll need some clothes. I guess you'll just have to borrow some of mine? Unless that's weird and you'd rather wear yours from the other day"…

"It' s not weird," Catra replies, and Adora flashes a soft smile as she pulls a pair of jeans out and passes them to her , "might need to roll these up since you're like, eight feet tall, but"…

"I'm 5'8," Adora rolls her eyes, tossing a sweater over at her too. She grabs her own clothes and heads towards the door. "I'll change in the bathroom. Be right back."

Catra opens her mouth;whether to of fer to take the bathroom herself or to make some flirtatious comment about how entirely unnecessary that is, she doesn't know . But she quickly changes into the clothes Adora had given her, and maybe she brings the collar of the sweater up to her nose and breathes in Adora's scent. But if anyone asks, no she didn't.

She looks herself over in the mirror once she's dressed. Adora's sweater is big on her, but in that comfortable way, and Catra knows she'll probably make some excuse to steal more of Adora's clothes. Maybe her own stuff will get mysteriously lost in transit.

She runs her hand through her hair. Cutting it had been freeing, in a weird way. Maybe it's because she knew it'd make Weaver mad. It had always been somewhat nice to get small revenges in any way she could. Even if that was just doing things to annoy her. It's still weird to look at herself in the mirror, though. She doesn't look like the girl in all of those music videos and photoshoots.

Good, Catra thinks, *I was never that girl to begin with.*

"Hey," Adora peers around the door, and then blushes and realises, "Oh, I probably should've knocked. But you're dressed, so I guess it doesn't matter."

"Are you sure you weren't hoping to see something?" Catra says, and she gets the reaction she desires when Adora's cheeks flush pink and she starts spluttering an "of course not." "Sure. I totally believe you."

"If you're going to stop teasing me," Adora rolls her eyes and holds out her hand, "come on. We've got places to be."

Catra takes her hand and doesn't let go until she has to get into the passenger side of Adora's car. "So, is *this* the part where you take me off to kill me so you can put my head in your little stalker shrine?"

"Yeah, but first we've got to go to the candle store," Adora flashes a teasing grin as she starts the car, "can't have a stalker shrine without at least a hundred candles."

"You're a stalker *and* a fire hazard?" Catra laughs. "Okay, seriously, though. Where are we going?"

"You'll see," Adora reaches over with a hand and squeezes Catra's knee, "I think you'll like it. If not, then we don't have to go in, and we can go for like, a brunch date or something. Except not a legit date."

"Damn, you keep breaking my heart here," Catra retorts, and Adora lets out a frustrated groan, "Hey, I'm joking."

"I know, it's just... I've never been good with girls in general," Adora says, and Catra had surmised that much with how flustered she gets at flirting. "And all of the relationship stuff... there are so many random social rules and I guess I just don't want to cross any lines? I just want to respect you."

"You can respect me by making out with me," Catra says, and she gets the flustered response she expected. Adora blushes, all embarrassed, and she smirks. Teasing her for the next few months is going to be tremendous fun. "Honestly, though? Fuck the rules. I like you. You like me. Just because it's not a good idea to have a relationship right now, it doesn't mean we have to tiptoe around each other. You're like the only person I feel comfortable with. I want you to feel the same way."

"Okay," Adora looks over when she stops at a stop sign and smiles this soft little smile that makes Catra's heart hiccup in her chest. "And I do. Feel comfortable around you, that is."

"Good," Catra smiles back and savours the feeling in her stomach. It's that fizzy feeling again, some kind of happiness reawakening after so long being dormant, and it hits her that every day can be like this, if she wants it to. If she tries for it. She could stay here with Adora, forget about the fame and the music industry, and just live a little, normal life.

She loves music too much to leave it completely, but she doesn't want to go back to everything like it was before. Ever again. Not just the horrible, shady contracts, but the schedule she was on. She didn't have a single day off for four years. The label constantly

overworked her, to the point where she ended up hospitalised for dehydration and exhaustion.

If she complained about it, people would make comments. *You're a multi-millionaire.* As if money made any of it worth it. The only person she'd ever met who even slightly understood was Double Trouble. They were forced in the closet and just as overworked as she was. They bonded over the shared trauma, and considering they had to spend every day playing pretend like they were together, it was inevitable. But then the PR contract ended, and the label fabricated a bad breakup narrative to sell Catra's third album, which consisted mostly of heavily edited breakup songs about the girl who had broken her heart. She hasn't seen them since. They've talked over Twitter DMs a few times, but it's hard to find the time to maintain friendships when your every waking moment is dedicated to working.

YouTube was the good time. She was making steady money from it, without being *forced* into anything. And she was covering the songs that she actually liked. Maybe that's the way to go. Making music the music she wants to make independently and releasing it on YouTube.

She wants a break first, at least. A nice, long break. Maybe that summer of whatever Adora called it. Relationship prep? Yeah, that seems like a nice break.

"Oh, great, there's a parking space right there," Adora says as she pulls into it, and Catra snaps out of her contemplation to realise where they are. Adora flashes a sheepish smile. "Surprise."

It's the local animal shelter. Catra realises what Adora must be thinking. "You think I should get a cat?"

"Yeah," Adora says, "I think it might be good for you, to look after something. And animals are really good company. When...when my mom passed, I actually looked after my friend Bow's dog for a few months. He's called George – so is one of Bow's dads, and I think that's why Bow picked him at the shelter – and he's the sweetest dog

youll ever meet. It helped a lot, having a companion that looked at me and saw the sun even on my darkest days."

It makes her heart do that thing again. The thing it's been doing since Wednesday, since she'd finally decided to stop being so fucking stubborn and actually talk to Adora. It overwhelms her, just how much Adora cares, and she can't believe that this perfect angel of a human being actually cares about *her.*

She knows that they said *fuck the rules*, but Catra feels like she probably shouldn't just push forwards and kiss Adora anyway. She settles for reaching out and taking her hand, hoping that it can communicate everything she's thinking. "Okay. Yeah. I think it's a good idea."

"Okay then," Adora squeezes her hand before letting go and opening her door, "let's go."

When Adora walks around to Catra's side of the car, Catra takes her hand again. Because sometimes, friends hold hands. That's how she justifies it, at least. Adora doesn't push her away, and instead tangles their fingers together as they walk inside.

The reception area is empty – there's nobody behind the desk, and Adora turns to ask, "do we just walk in?" when the door to the dog pens opens and a familiar woman walks out.

She pauses in the doorway, stares blankly at her for a few moments, and then questions, "Catra?"

Adora shifts subtly in front of her, like she's going to protect her from a rabid fan. Catra squeezes her hand to assure her that it's not the case at all. "Hey, Netossa."

"I didn't realise you were back in town, kid," Netossa says, "nice of you to come visit. Who's your friend?"

She glances down at their hands, and there's a typical Netossa smirk on her face. Catra talks before she can start with the inevitable onslaught of teasing. "This is Adora. She thinks I should get a cat. And, uh, I think Im going to be in town for a while, if you still need anyone to help out."

Adora frowns. "W ait, so, you two know each other?"

Netossa nods. "Catra used to volunteer here when she was in high school. But then she ditched us for Hollywood."

"W orst decision of my life," Catra says. It' s not entirely a joke. "So… cats?"

"Y eah, come on through," Netossa gestures them through, and as Catra passes by, she smiles, "nice haircut, by the way ."

"Thanks," Catra says, and she appreciates that Netossa hasnt asked why she's back home. Most people probably wouldve, especially since it was national news two days ago that shed gone missing. "How' s Spinnerella?"

"She' s good," Netossa answers, "she' s out back dealing with the delivery guys. They didnt bring all the cat litter we need and she' s a little gentler at handling that kind of thing."

"Hey ," Adora nudges her lightly , "I didnt know you used to volunteer here."

"Any excuse to get out of the house," Catra shrugs, "you try living with Weaver."

"Oh, yeah, say it like that," Netossa rolls her eyes, "she helped out because she loves animals, and they love her too. Even a couple of the feral cats we had in and trying to socialise turned into little cuddly baby cats the moment she walked in the room. It's like she's the cat whisperer."

"Aw," Adora pouts at her, and Catra knew that would be her response, "you're so cute."

"Yeah, yeah, shut up," Catra shoves her lightly, "let's just get a stupid cat and get out of here."

"Feel free to look around," Netossa holds the door to the cat pens open for them, "I know I can trust you with them. Ill be up front if you need anything."

The reason Catra had liked volunteering at the shelter so much as a teenager was because of the way Netossa and Spinnerella ran it. There were the typical long rows of cages where the animals slept, but they had two spare rooms where they'd let the animals out to play. One room for cats, and the other for dogs. Right now, the cats are jumping around, climbing the towers, playing with toys, and she knows from the happy barking a few doors down that the dogs are doing the same thing.

"Okay," Adora smiles as she looks at the few cats who have wandered over, interested in the two new intruders, "let's find your forever cat."

They spend a little while playing with the cats and luring a few of the more antisocial ones in with treats. Adora keeps pointing at them and saying 'what about this one?' and Catra rolls her eyes fondly. None of them feel *right*, in a weird way.

That's when Catra notices it. The little black cat in the corner, shying away from everyone else. Carefully, she nudges the fluffy ginger cat off her lap and approaches it.

When it notices her, it hisses, its fur fluffing up in an attempt to make itself bigger. Slowly, Catra sits down in front of it, at a small distance. It obviously doesn't want her to come any closer. She holds out her hand and smiles, even though she knows it probably doesn't understand.

But she understands how it's feeling. It's lashing out because it's scared.

"Hey . It's okay," Catra whispers, "I won't hurt you."

She keeps as still as possible, and slowly, the little cat unfurls. It steps forwards cautiously and sniffs at her hand, until it moves so the top of its head is under her palm. Catra makes sure to be extra gentle when she moves her hand around to scratch behind the cat's ear. Underneath the fur, she feels the bump of a scar along the base of the cat's ear and wonders how it got there.

It starts quietly at first. But the little cat starts purring, and when it looks back at Catra with its big blue eyes, she knows. This is the cat she's taking home.

"I should've known."

Catra turns around to see Netossa leaning against the door. She's smirking down at her, and Catra rolls her eyes. "Should've known *what*?"

"That you and Melog would hit it off," Netossa says, and Adora looks up from the tabby cat she's petting, "he's been antisocial since we got him in. Hisses at everyone. And then *you* come in, and"…

Almost like on cue, Melog steps forwards, clambers into Catra's lap, and curls up. He nudges Catra's hand, as if to say *keep petting me.* Adora sits down next to her , and Melog pushes back against Catra's chest reproachfully. He hisses again, but Catra runs her hand down his back and says quietly , "it's okay. That's Adora. She's kind of a dumbass, but she's nice."

"Hey ," Adora rolls her eyes and holds a hand out for Melog to sniff, "ignore Catra. She's mean."

Melog presses back to Catra again, and she sticks her tongue out at Adora. "I think Melog disagrees."

"So," Netossa says, and Catra looks up, "do you want to take him home?"

"Yeah," Catra looks down at the little cat as she says it, and finds that he's already looking back at her, "I do."

Netossa smiles. "I'll get the papers ready. He probably won't go in a carry case – he doesn't like small spaces."

"We've got that in common, buddy," Catra says as she scratches behind Melog's ear, "I'll just carry him. And I'll need to buy some cat food and litter and a bed for him"…

"With all the hours you've volunteered here, I think we can pay you back with some cat supplies," Spinnerella says as she walks through the door. She greets Netossa with a kiss, and Catra smiles. Seeing them so open about their relationship had helped her figure out her own sexuality all those years ago. "It's good to see you again. Are you in town for long?"

"Yeah," Catra answers, and knowing that they'd never ask for an explanation, she says, "I'm leaving my record label."

"Oh," Spinnerella says, "your choice?"

"Yeah," Catra replies, even though she knows Horde Records will put some kind of spin on it and say they dropped her to the press. *Creative differences*, Weaver had said. More like issues with *creative control.* "I'm going to stay here for a while. Hang with Adora and her grandma. Maybe work on some new music on my own."

It's strange even having the choice of what she wants to do. Every day for the last four years, Weaver and the label have decided when and where she's going to be, and what she's going to be doing, and she's had no choice but to go. Now, she can do whatever she wants. It's such a simple thing, and something that everyone else just *has*, but for Catra, it feels like a luxury.

“Well, take care of little Melog,” Spinnerella says. She reaches out a hand to pet Melog, and he hisses at her. She laughs. “He’s a feisty one.”

“I don’t know,” Catra shrugs, petting the little cat again, “I think he’s pretty chill.”

Catra signs the adoption certificate and leaves with a new cat, some supplies, and an invitation to come and help out any time. She knows she’s going to take them up on it.

When they arrive back at Adora’s house, Melog curls up in Catra’s lap again as she checks her emails. Her lawyer has replied with a detailed list – read: translation – of the legal jargon in the contract. Catra realises that Weaver must be desperate to keep those videos private, because everything is as she asked. It’s okay for her to print out, sign, and fax back to the record label’s headquarters in LA.

She signs on the dotted line and stares at the termination agreement that details her freedom, and scans a copy using Adora’s printer for her own records. She knows that there’s a lot more she needs to do – buy a house, move her things to Etheria, recover the stuff Adora had taken for the week too – but once she signs the agreement, she takes a few minutes to breathe.

They head out again to find a fax machine they can use, and there’s one in the back of the local grocery store. A few people look at her weirdly, like they think they recognise her from somewhere, but despite her last tweet, her new haircut seems to be a somewhat decent disguise.

She knows that’ll wear off quickly, but for now, she savours it. Catra has always tried not to be bitter towards the fans – it’s not like they were the ones overworking her or forcing her to pretend all the time – but sometimes it’s hard. Like the last time she came home, before Weaver sold the old house, and she’d decided to go out for a walk. She’d been passing by the park – ironically reminiscing on that day she’d spent in the sandbox with Adora – at exactly the wrong time.

The local high school had let out probably five minutes before, and the kids mobbed her, asking for pictures, autographs, shoutouts, and they wouldnt stop even when she asked them to back up.

And like she mentioned before, she hates small spaces.

Maybe shell point a few of them out and tell Adora to give them detention. She said she was the assistant soccer coach. Maybe she has that power.

Adora holds her hand as the document gets faxed over to Horde Records and holds on even tighter when Weaver pops up on Catra's caller ID. She takes in a breath and answers the phone, hoping that itll be for the final time.

"*We have received your copy of the termination agreement,"* Weaver says immediately, *"all ties between you and the company are now severed. The same goes for any ties between you and I."*

"Good," Catra says, and all she feels is relief. Weaver had been nothing but a dark shadow towering over her since the day she adopted her. She still doesnt entirely understand why she'd ever done it, when she always considered Catra such an inconvenience. "Have a nice life."

"I do not wish you the same sentiment," Weaver replies sharply, *"you are nothing but a miserable little brat who cares for nobody but herself, and you will get what's coming to you eventually."*

For once, Catra refuses to let her ruin her mood. She'd been feeling good all day, and she's not going to let Weaver mess with that. "I'll be sure to tweet about it when I do."

"Remember, Catrina," Weaver says, and Catra can imagine the condescending smile, *"you are not to say a bad word about Horde Records or we can and will sue you. We'll be watching, even after you fade into your inevitable irrelevancy."*

“*I* wont be saying anything,” Catra replies coldly, “cant say the same for anybody else. Bye.”

She hangs up before Weaver can say anything else, and it feels so good to finally block her number. After so many years of feeling trapped with her, she never has to see her again.

Finally, she’s free.

“Let’s go home,” Catra says, and she reaches out and takes Adora’s hand, “I have to think about what Im going to say.”

“Okay,” Adora replies, and when she pulls her phone out of her pocket, she raises her eyebrows in surprise, “wow, that was fast.”

Catra takes a wild guess at what she’s talking about. “They posted a statement already?”

“Yeah,” Adora says, and she clears her throat and reads it out as they leave the grocery store and walk back to the car, “*due to unresolved creative differences, Horde Records has decided to part ways with singer Catrina Driluth, better known by her stage name Catra. The long-awaited fourth album from our previous client will no longer be released, and the single released on Friday will be removed from streaming services promptly.”*

Catra hums in thought. “That’s a lot nicer than I thought itd be.”

Adora laughs. “Maybe Scorpia wrote it.”

“If Scorpia wrote it, itd be something along the lines of.” Catra pauses in thought, “*my bestie is leaving the label and if anyone has a problem with that, they can go through me.*”

“Yeah, youre probably right,” Adora laughs, and she says no more on the subject on the drive home. It’s like she can sense that Catra doesnt want to talk about it. Instead, she just talks about little things, like good times she’s had with her friends. She not-so-subtly drops

that the sparkly girl's dad is a therapist, and Catra actually decides that she'd like to try it. She doesn't say that, but there are a lot of things she needs to figure out now that she has the time, so why not?

When they get back to the house Razz already has lunch prepared, and as they eat, Catra drafts her own statement. No. Her own statement slash coming out. Because she can come out now. The thought makes that weird fuzzy feeling happen in her chest. She knows now that it's happiness, but it's still so unfamiliar.

As a teenager, she always thought that she'd be scared to come out. She never thought she'd be desperate to. And now , she's just excited, and relieved. It'll be so nice, to not have to lie anymore.

"What do you think to this?" Catra asks, and she slides her phone over the table to Adora. "Good? Or do you think I should make it more serious?"

Adora picks the phone up and reads the words on the screen, and Catra goes over them in her head.

hey.

so, it's been a weird and confusing few days, especially from your perspective. first i go missing, then i cut all my hair off, and then my label announces that we've parted ways. there's a lot that i can't say for legal reasons, but i can tell you all that i'm okay. honestly, i'm the best i've been in four years. and that's because i can finally tell you this.

i'm a lesbian.

(big week for me right? missing, haircut, label drama and now i'm gay. oh, and i got a cat, so expect cute pics of him soon)

i realise some of you might be surprised by that due to past very public relationships. i can't go into detail so all i'm going to say is

read the first letter of the last two words in that sentence.

like horde records said in their statement, the fourth album is cancelled. i'm sorry for anyone who was excited, and i'm not quitting music or anything by any means. i'm genuinely excited to start this next chapter and i'm going to continue making the music i want to make independently. just me myself and my beautiful wife aka my guitar. so for the people who are always asking me 'would you ever make another youtube cover' the answer to that question is yes. maybe i'll release M fourth album too.

i also want to use my platform to spread awareness for the things that matter to me. i'm going to post a youtube video soon detailing my intentions, but i basically want to give advice for any kids out there wanting to have a music career who might be manipulated into something they're not prepared for, as well as help campaign for better treatment of artists already out there. the music industry is not the glamourous thing most people think it is, and i think i know that better than most.

as of right now, though, i'd like to take a break. touring over these last few years has been amazing, but also tiring. you'll hear from me again soon, because i'll never stop writing and making music, and i love to perform so you can bet a tour will be in the works. but not for a while, because to put it honestly, i'm fucking tired.

thank you to all of the fans who have supported me throughout the years. you mean more than you know. i hope we can keep going on this wild ride together.

love, catra

ps - fyi for everyone who has ever asked me this question (aka a lot of you) my actual celebrity crush is hayley williams from paramore hayley pls hmu

"I think it' s good," Adora says, "it' s not super serious and you havent said anything bad about the label but there are still hints in there

where people can figure out why you left on their own. And I like that you don't make a big deal about coming out."

"It's weird, because the actual act of getting to do it is a big deal to me," Catra reads it over once more, then screenshots and posts it in a tweet, "just because I wasn't allowed to for so long."

"You posted it?" Adora asks as Catra puts her phone face-down on the table. "You realise you're probably going to break the internet, right?"

Catra lets out the first real laugh since that call with Weaver. "I don't know about that."

"No, you are," Adora answers seriously, pausing to say *thank you* when Razz places two mugs of hot chocolate in front of them and goes back into the lounge. "A lot of fans already thought you were queer, so"…

"Wait," Catra frowns, "did you?"

Adora laughs. "Uh, no. I thought it was just fans wishful thinking. I figured that if you were, you would've come out because you were like one of the biggest female artists in mainstream music, so it would've been pretty amazing representation, you know? I guess I didn't think about what could've been happening behind the scenes."

"Not many people would've," Catra says, letting Adora know that it's okay. She glances down at her phone when it buzzes and flips it over to see a few texts lighting up the screen. The first one she reads is from Scorpia.

Proud of you, wildcat! Hope to see you soon??)

Adora grabs her own phone and laughs again. "You came out two minutes ago and you're already trending worldwide."

Melog hops up onto the table and decides to sit right on top of Catra's phone, like he knows she's going to go and check it. She smiles and scratches behind his ear as a way of saying thank you. "You're right, Melog. Probably best if I leave it for a while."

She's not sure if she means social media in general. Maybe. It's hard to feel normal when thousands of people like and reply to anything she posts, and she thinks that's what she needs. To feel *normal.* Like, an actual living, breathing human being, and not some commodity.

She takes a breath, and realises she's not scared anymore. It's probably because the thing that was making her feel the way she was is gone. She's free from that horrific contract. Starting today, her life is her own, and she can do anything she wants to.

When she meets Adora's gaze, and runs her fingers through Melog's soft black fur, Catra knows what she wants.

She wants to heal.

Epilogue: Monday

Chapter Summary

adora and catra, a year later

Chapter Notes

mild tw for references to everything else in this fic but really this chapter is just fluff

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora hums along to the song playing on the radio as she pulls into Razz's driveway. The rest of her car is piled high with boxes—all of her belongings from her university accommodation. It's the second time she's made this drive, but this time she's coming back with a college degree. After a full weekend of celebration with her college friends, she packed her things, said goodbye to Bright Moon University, and set off early Monday morning back to Etheria.

She doesn't turn the engine off once she's pulled into the driveway, because the song playing on the radio is one that means a lot to her. The heavy guitar riff of the outro that's playing right now; she first heard it played in her bedroom on the guitar she'd picked up from a garage sale, and a beautiful woman had waited for her opinion on it.

The DJ talks over the last few notes, "and that was *Freedom* by Catra, the title track and lead single from her upcoming fourth album. Maybe this time it'll actually get released!"

Adora rolls her eyes in a manner reminiscent of Catra herself. It seems like every DJ or interviewer uses that joke and has ever since the news broke that Catra had severed ties with her record label and that her planned fourth album wouldn't be released.

"Catra is actually going to be on the show next week. Her first radio interview since leaving her record label last year, right here on Etheria FM. I think it's half promo for her album and half raising awareness," the DJ continues, "she's been heavily campaigning for better working conditions and contracts for artists signed under record labels over the last few months, and she's going to be talking to us about that and answering some of your questions as well. Thursday, guys!"

Adora swells with pride at the words. Even though it was in her termination agreement that Catra couldn't speak negatively about Horde Records, that hadn't stopped her from speaking out about bad contracts and how overworked a lot of artists are. She's never referenced what happened to her, or mentioned the name *Horde Records*, but most people have caught onto what she means and are boycotting the label.

Of course, it helped when Adora posted a statement on her experiences as the contest winner, including everything she'd witnessed. And when Scorpia spoke up about working as Catra's bodyguard, and talked about everything she'd seen over the four years she'd been working with Catra. And when Entrapta quit her job at Horde Records in protest, and posted a blunt series of tweets about the working conditions there.

After all, the termination agreement only stated that *Catra* couldn't post the video and recording.

Adora doesn't know what happened to Weaver. She knows she was fired, because both Adora and Scorpia named her, and the Horde Records twitter account released a statement saying that the 'accused' was no longer associated with the label. It hadn't done much to clear the label's name, because everyone is aware that they were complicit in the way Catra was treated.

Hopefully, in a few years, Horde Records will fade into obscurity. They haven't released a hit song in a year. Meanwhile, Catra's lead single from her fourth album had skyrocketed to number one on the

Billboard Hot 100, and critics and fans alike called it her best work to date. Her album already has thousands of pre-orders. It doesn't release for another two months, and Adora knows she's already got a second single lined up for a surprise release next Friday. Catra is doing better than ever, and Horde Records are the ones fading into the 'inevitable irrelevancy'.

Her phone buzzes in her pocket, and Adora kills the engine and pulls it out of her pocket to read. Like Catra had known she was on Adora's mind, she'd tweeted.

@catradriluth can everyone stop asking me if i have a girlfriend? this is disrespectful to my wife mrs paul reed smith private stock custom 24 fret fire red quilted maple top rosewood fretboard with 57/08 humbuckers

Adora's stomach does that dip like she's just gone down the big drop on a rollercoaster. Maybe it's dumb that she gets so excited when Catra makes jokes, but it means a lot when Catra shows signs of being better. Adora can't forget that haunted, tired girl she met a year ago, but who she sees whenever she's with Catra now is actually *happy.* She smiles and laughs and jokes and she's so light and open compared to the girl who angrily lashed out at everything.

Adora jumps when there's a knock on her window and turns around to see the girl she's thinking about. Catra is peering in through the car window, an eyebrow raised in amusement and a soft smirk on her face. Her hair has almost grown out again, and Catra has pulled it back into a messy ponytail like she always has lately. She says it's because she got used to not having it in her face all the time, but Adora likes to tease her and say she's mimicking her, minus the hair poof.

"Why are you sitting in your car smiling to yourself like a weirdo?" Catra says through the window, and Adora rolls her eyes and gets out. "Seriously, you looked like you just won a million bucks."

Adora pauses. She knows what she wants to say, and she's been thinking for a while that maybe Catra is ready for that. She's happy. She's making the music she wants to make, and Adora hasn't seen her lash out in stress for over half a year.

So she smiles and says, "It's because I was thinking about you."

Catra pauses, that cute blush rises up underneath her even cuter freckles, and she rolls her eyes. "Shut up."

Adora laughs and nods to the car. "Come on. Help me with all of my boxes."

Catra looks disgusted at the mere suggestion. She glances at the boxes piled high in the trunk and backseat, and groans dramatically. "Do I have to?"

"Yeah, you do," Adora says, even though she knows Catra would do it anyway. She's just dramatic about things, and it's really a good thing that she is. It shows that she's happy enough to joke around. "Come on. Ill point out the lighter ones for you. Like that one on the top there."

She reaches out and takes Catra's hand, squeezing it lightly as she pulls her around to the trunk and pops it open. Obviously, she lets go of Catra's hand, because even Adora isn't strong enough to carry some of these boxes one-handed. But she doesn't want to.

Adora knows why Catra had tweeted about people asking her if she has a girlfriend. It's because ever since she came out, it seems like the only question anyone ever asks her. But not just '*do you have a girlfriend?*'.

More specifically, *is Adora your girlfriend?*

Weirdly, sometimes Adora doesn't know how to answer it. She knows that Catra isn't literally her girlfriend. Catra is single, and she could theoretically go out, meet a girl, fall in love with her and forget

about Adora entirely. Except when they're actually together physically, it's like the lines between friendship and romance are blurred.

Even though Catra has a house in Etheria, Adora isn't sure if she's ever actually slept there before. She'd moved all of her things into it, and they'd eaten dinner there once, but even Catra herself refers to it as her 'expensive guitar storage place'. Because that's basically what it is. Most of Catra's clothes are hung up in Adora's closet, and she'd brought the fancy red guitar she always used to use on stage over to Adora's place to play around on since she's never at her own house.

"Don't touch her, don't breathe around her, don't even look at her directly," Catra had joked when she brought the guitar over in its case, *"she's my precious."*

Adora had laughed. *"Okay, Gollum."*

When Adora came home from school on the weekends, she'd always share her bed with Catra. And it's not like they just spent the nights sharing the same bed, Catra on one side and Adora on the other. If anyone had walked in and woken them up on a morning, they'd find them curled up together, a mess of tangled limbs on one side of the bed. Usually on Adora's side, by the wall.

In the early days, it went a little like this:

On her first weekend back from college, Adora was tired. She'd forgotten exactly how much work school was, and after throwing herself right back into it, all she wanted to do was spend the entire weekend asleep.

Because she still felt guilty about Catra taking time out of her life to stay and take care of Razz, she promised herself that she was going to use her weekends to go home and help out. She almost flaked on that first weekend because all she wanted to do was curl up on Bow

and Glimmer's guest bed and crash, but Adora has always kept her promises. And she just really wanted to see Catra.

After her last Friday class, she drove back to Etheria and arrived at Razz's house like a zombie. Razz had already gone to bed – she's always been an early riser, which means she always ends up going to bed early too. Catra was waiting up for her, in one of Adora's old t-shirts and some pyjama shorts.

Adora didn't need to say how tired she was. It was like Catra just knew, and she'd offered out a hand and led her to her bedroom. They climbed into bed, separately. They always started apart back then, Catra on the left side and Adora on the right. They switched the lights off, and laid there in a quiet, sleepy silence, until eventually Catra would say something. Like she needed the quiet of a dark bedroom at night to be able to talk.

"I went to therapy today," Catra had whispered on that day, "with Sparkles' dad, like you suggested."

Adora shuffled a little closer. From the sound of ruffling sheets, she knew that Catra had too. "Micah is really good. He helped me through a lot with grief counselling after my mom"…

"Honestly, I didn't think it would help," Catra said quietly, giving up on the whole ruse they had and rolling over to snuggle into Adora's side. "I figured the whole situation would've been too niche for anyone to help with, but…even just getting things out there that I had to keep quiet made me feel a lot better. I talked about things from before the music stuff, too. I don't know if I ever mentioned this to you, but that time you saw Weaver hit me…it wasn't the first time she'd ever done that."

"I had a feeling," Adora whispered back and wrapped her arms around Catra's waist, "do you want to talk to me about it, too?"

Catra sighed. "You know she only adopted me because she wanted a kid to parade around? She couldn't have children, and all of her

coworkers would bring their kids to the business functions and pretty much just use them to one-up each other. She figured out I was smart, and she'd bring me all of these math quizzes and stuff on the initial visits under the guise of bonding. I did them all and tried my damn best doing it. I wanted her to adopt me because I... I wanted a parent more than anything."

"I couldn't have known she'd turn out to be such a manipulative bitch who would fuck me over and use me for all I was worth," Catra muttered, and Adora squeezed her tightly, reassuring her that she was there. "When she adopted me, I did anything she asked because I wanted her to love me. She never would've. I don't even know if she's capable of it. But no matter what I did, I was never good enough. She set her expectations too high, and I was just a kid who couldn't reach them. Any time I disappointed her, she... well, you know. I think that's why I fell for it, when she started being so nice about my music. I thought I'd finally managed to please her, and part of me still wanted that parental figure. But she was just manipulating me."

Adora knew that she could never understand it. She had a perfect relationship with her own mother, before she lost her. So instead, Adora pulled her closer and ran her fingers through Catra's short, messy hair as she talked, just being there to listen to her.

They talked a lot at night—sometimes about trivial stuff, and sometimes the more serious topics. Adora talked to Catra about schoolwork and stress and Catra told her about therapy and the music she'd been working on, and she'd always let Adora be the first person to watch the YouTube covers she'd gone back to posting. In a way, their late night conversations were kind of like therapy for the both of them.

"So, you're dating, right?" Glimmer had asked when Adora came back to Bright Moon after a weekend with Catra. Adora had a big smile on her face, and she'd been recounting this amazing dinner that Razz had taught Catra how to make when Glimmer had interrupted.

"Uh, what?" Adora frowned at the question. "Of course not."

Glimmer snorted with laughter. "Okay, she cooked you a whole dinner, you guys sleep in the same bed, you're always smiling like an idiot any time you talk about her, and she's obviously head over heels for you. That's lesbian activity."

"Catra isn't my girlfriend," Adora said, despite the butterflies at the pit of her stomach. "She's not in a place for that right now. She's trying to work on herself."

"Bow, tell her that Catra is basically her girlfriend," Glimmer laughed, "honestly, who shares a bed with their friend every night? Who eats nice romantic homecooked meals with their *friend*?

"Glimmer kind of has a point," Bow admitted, and Adora rolled her eyes, because obviously he'd side with her. "I'm not saying she's your girlfriend, I'm just saying... you guys do come off like you're more than friends."

"That's dumb," Adora ignored them both, acted like they were totally wrong, but when she returned to her bedroom and saw a text from Catra, she felt those butterflies again.

She felt them even more when she read the actual text. *just filmed a q&a for youtube and literally 90% of the questions were 'do you have a girlfriend' or 'is that adora girl your girlfriend' so do with that information what you will*

Adora continued to deny the whole thing. She knew that Catra had feelings for her, and obviously she knew her own feelings too, but they were just friends. They weren't going to complicate things, not when they both had stuff they needed to sort through first.

Eventually, it became hard to ignore. Like when the mainstream media caught onto their vaguely romantic undertones after pictures of them holding hands – *in a friendly way* – in the local grocery store leaked to the press.

Or any time Glimmer came over too. Like when school broke up for winter break and Adora and her friends came home. Bow and Glimmer decided to come over for takeout and a movie night, and when Adora's car pulled up in the driveway, Catra was already waiting on the porch, acoustic guitar on her lap.

"Hey ," she said when she saw Adora, and basically *only* Adora, "I have a song I want to run by you. Do you mind?"

"No, not at all," Adora shook her head and said quickly to Bow and Glimmer, "you guys wait inside," before dropping down on the porch next to Catra.

"*Girlfriends*," Glimmer coughed as she walked past, and feigned a whole coughing fit to add, "*you're both so gay,"* as Bow laughed and ushered her inside.

So Adora knows that they maybe cross a few lines and blur a few others. But there's one line they haven't crossed; they haven't kissed since that time outside the animal shelter last year. But Adora would be lying if she said she didn't want to. She'd definitely be lying if she said she didn't think about it every day .

"You said this is a light box," Catra glares at her over the top of it as she starts hauling it towards the open front door. "I'm starting to think you and I have different definitions of what *light* is."

"Not my fault if you don't hit the gym enough," Adora teases her , "we could go together. I'll spot you while you lift."

"Yeah, no thanks," Catra rolls her eyes, "I think all of those years with a personal trainer and getting yelled at if I ate anything other than carrot sticks has traumatised me away from the gym. I'll stick to the occasional run when I can be bothered."

"Carrot sticks are nice. Maybe not for every meal, but for a healthy snack." Adora grabs two boxes – totally not to rub it in that she can –

and follows Catra towards the door. "Speaking of meals, Bow and Glimmer are going to come over for celebratory takeout tonight."

"Didn't you spend the entire weekend celebrating?" Catra raises her eyebrows, and Adora blushes, because yeah, but that was with *everyone* from college. And she hasn't celebrated with Catra yet. "Well, you graduated college. I guess you've got a right to celebrate."

Adora hums. "We're also celebrating how *someone's* lead single has been at number one for six weeks."

"Wow, congratulate them for me," Catra says, and Adora laughs at the sarcastic tone. Those butterflies in her stomach go a little crazy again, because she always feels that when Catra makes a joke. "You're still coming to LA with me next weekend, right?"

"Of course," Adora reaches out and takes Catra's hand, "you asked me to be there. I'm going to be there."

Catra tangles their fingers together and smiles. Adora knows she's grateful, because it's her first real round of press since everything that happened last year. She's nervous about it, and she'd asked Adora to go with her for moral support.

A quiet meowing takes Adora's mind off that, and she lets go of Catra's hand to kneel down and pet Melog. "Hey, little buddy. You decided to grace me with your presence, huh?"

"Wouldn't it be perfect if Melog could help with your dumb boxes too?" Catra says, but she reaches down and pets the little cat affectionately. "Come on. Let's get your car unpacked and then we can relax for a while."

Relax usually means curling up on the couch under the same blanket and watching some stupid movie or TV show. And during that time, Adora is usually thinking about pulling Catra in for a kiss.

Just because she's looking forward to snuggling up with the prettiest girl in the world, Adora tries to carry three boxes at a time, drops one, and then has to spend even more time picking up the contents while Catra laughs at her.

She would be mad at how unhelpful she is, but she loves Catra's laugh, and loves what it means.

Once Adora is officially moved back in from university, Catra takes her hand and pulls her down the hallway. "Come on. I already went out and bought a bunch of snacks, so you get to pick the movie."

Adora acknowledges that with a hum. She tends to pick movies she doesn't actually want to watch, because she spends most of the time watching Catra, wondering if it's time, if they're finally ready to do this.

Catra is okay now. She's still got some things she's working on, but who doesn't? The important thing is that she's happy. She's making the music she wants to make, she's surrounded by people who care about her, and she's *happy.*

"Your chips," Catra holds up a big bag of barbecue chips, and then grabs a bag of microwave popcorn, "and I'm going to make my popcorn. Go pick the movie."

Adora doesn't move. She takes the bag of chips and smiles. "You remembered my favourite flavour."

"Uh," Catra rolls her eyes, "you love barbecue chips so much that I'm probably going to buy them for your every birthday, Christmas and anniversary present."

Adora goes to laugh at her joke, but then realises the last thing she said. She smirks and elbows her lightly. "Anniversary present? Already planning ahead?"

Catra hesitates, like she's trying to figure out what to say to that. After a few moments of thought, she smiles and reaches out to take Adora's hand.

"When I first started going to therapy with Micah, the feelings I had for you were some of the first things I tried to sort through," Catra says, and Adora doesn't know how that answers the question, "I didn't mean for it to be that way. Obviously I had a lot of other things I needed to deal with. Some of which I'm still dealing with now. But he mentioned something entirely in passing that kind of sent me spiralling."

"He said that it sounded like I'd latched onto you because you were the only person who'd shown me even a little bit of kindness. Because you were the only one who ever treated me like a normal person. That my feelings weren't because I knew you and I liked you, but because I liked the way you treated me." Catra sighs and squeezes Adora's hand. "He was right. Truth was, I didn't know you. I just knew you were kind and beautiful and that you treated me like an actual person."

"I started thinking maybe I didn't like you in the way I thought. That it was just confused friendship because you were actually nice to me. But then we hung out with Sparkles and Bow a few times, and they treated me like a normal person too. I tried to make a real effort with Scorpia and she was the same. And I still felt differently towards you. There was always something there with you," Catra continues, "so while I was trying to get to know myself, I was getting to know you too. Learning your favourite things, your least favourite things, all of the little mannerisms you have like the way you eat with your knife and fork in the wrong hands like a dumbass."

Adora laughs lightly, and Catra smiles. "I didn't know you. But I do now, and I like that person and want to keep learning about her. You're still kind and beautiful, but you're also an idiot who thought that the black market was a literal market that people go to and the weirdo who walks around the house with one sock on and one sock off because *I'm cold, but not cold enough for both socks.*"

"So yeah," Catra says, "anniversary presents. I'm definitely planning ahead."

"Well," Adora says, because it's the only thing she thinks she *can* say. Catra's whole speech had taken her off guard. She's so good with words – obviously she is, she's a lyricist – but it makes Adora's heartbeat ten times faster. Or maybe a hundred times faster.

She tries to find something to say. Tries to find the words she desperately wants to speak. But her mind fails her, so she does the only thing she can think of. She wraps her arms around Catra's waist and pulls her in for a kiss.

It's just as magical as their first kiss last year. Only this time, everything else is magical too. There's no shady contracts looming over them, no evil record label, no pressure. It's just Adora and Catra, how it's always supposed to be.

Catra smiles against her lips and curls into her touch, and her lips part easily when Adora deepens the kiss. The most beautiful sound reverberates at the back of Catra's throat, the softest type of moan, and Adora thinks it's the most amazing thing she's ever heard.

When she pulls away, there's a beautiful smile on Catra's face, and adoration shining in her heterochromatic eyes.

"You kissed me," Catra observes, and Adora nods, "okay. Is this an *I slipped* moment or a *we're ready for more* moment?"

"Definitely the second thing," Adora says, and Catra's smile grows, "remember when we ran away, and you told me on the plane that you wanted a little house and a cat and a girlfriend who you could sing to?"

There's a soft smile toying at the corner of Catra's mouth when she remembers. "Yeah. I remember."

"Well, you've got the little house. Not that you've ever actually stayed there. And you've got the cat," Adora glances over at Melog, who bats a paw at the bag of barbecue chips in her hand. "Do you want the girlfriend too?"

Catra hums in thought. "I don't know. It depends on who she is. If you're offering up Sparkles, then no thanks."

She flashes that teasing smirk, and Adora laughs softly. Her stomach flutters, and the butterflies come alive again. Has she mentioned how much she loves it when Catra makes jokes?

"Okay, I know you like Glimmer and Bow, so shut up," Adora rolls her eyes, "but I'm serious right now. I think I... I think you're ready. And I know I am."

Catra lets a breath out of her nose. It's sort of shaky, like a surprised gasp, or a confused laugh. But from the way she's smiling, it's definitely a good thing. "You're really serious?"

"Yeah," Adora says, and then she lets out a quiet laugh when she remembers something, "Everyone already thinks I'm your girlfriend, anyway. We might as well make it official."

Catra laughs, that real, beautiful laugh and Adora notices the tears sparkling in her eyes. They're happy ones, she knows that, but she still puts her arm around Catra and pulls her close. "Girlfriend, huh?"

"Yeah," Adora says, "so I expect you to follow through on that *singing to me* promise."

Catra laughs. "I don't know how to sing. There's not a single musical bone in my body."

"*Sure*," Adora rolls her eyes, "so... will you be my girlfriend, Catra?"

Catra looks up at her, pure happiness shining in those heterochromatic eyes. She looks so different to the tired, depressed

girl Adora had met last year. She looks nothing like the pop star who seemingly had the world at her feet, either. Or the lonely sixteen-year-old girl making covers in her bedroom.

She does look a little bit like six-year-old Catrina, though. There's that same playful spark in her eyes she'd had on that day in the sandbox.

"It's nice to meet you, Catrina!" Adora said, sticking her hand out for the other girl to shake like Grandma Razz taught her to do. "We should be best friends!"

Catrina looked her up and down suspiciously, and then glanced at Adora's outstretched hand. After a few moments, a smile toyed at the corners of her mouth, and there was a playful sparkle in her pretty eyes as she took Adora's hand. "Okay. Let's be best friends."

Slowly, that real smile shows. That adorable toothy grin that shows that Catra is really happy. A soft hand reaches out and takes Adora's.

"Yeah," Catra says, squeezing Adora's hand gently. "I'd love to be your girlfriend, Adora."

Chapter End Notes

aaaaaaaand that's a wrap! thank you for taking the time to read this, and i hope you all enjoyed. feel free to subscribe to me if ur into my stuff, if not then i hope you enjoyed this fic anyway

also for this chapter specifically but also in general: PONYTAIL CATRA SUPREMACY

ily all thank you for reading

End Notes

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